

Life Lessons to Empower Change

SIX DIMES AND A NICKEL

DAMON WEST

Bestselling Coauthor of *The Coffee Bean*
and Author of *The Change Agent*

Advance Praise for Six Dimes and a Nickel

“Damon has one of the best comeback stories of all time, and he’s become one of the great storytellers of our era. His ability to weave life lessons with relatable stories make this book both educational and entertaining. A must read for anyone looking to become a better version of themselves.”

—JIM NANTZ, CBS Sports Commentator

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of the Kansas City Chiefs

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*This book is dedicated to Don Sanders.
The most remarkable individual, whose humility, kindness,
and generosity have profoundly impacted the lives of those
around him. His unwavering support and encouragement have
inspired countless people—myself and Kendell included.*

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PREFACE

If someone took control of your life tomorrow, what's the first thing they would change?

When I first heard this question posed by James Clear, it struck a chord with me. If you can answer that question, you already know what *you* need to change. Then, the question becomes: *Why have you not already made that change in your life?*

Usually, that answer is rooted in some form of fear, because change can be both difficult and scary. I personally believe we resist change because it takes us outside of our comfort zones. However, that's a great destination to navigate towards—outside of your comfort zone. That's where growth takes place. Nothing big ever happens in comfort zones.

I understand all too well about making big changes. In fact, I wrote a book about them, called *The Change Agent*. What I learned through writing and sharing that book is that people learn best through stories. We can digest and retain wisdom more easily when it is embedded in a story.

Storytelling is probably the oldest form of both entertainment and education. For millennia, humans have learned morals, principles, laws, and lessons through stories, from personal anecdotes to shared experiences to parables. In the beginning, we huddled around campfires and caves. As time progressed, humans

gathered in tents, huts, dens, churches, temples, homes, and apartments to learn at the feet of storytellers. Stories are in our DNA.

A good storyteller will captivate an audience and elicit emotion. Eliciting emotion is critical for the storyteller because once emotion is involved, memories get created. Making someone feel something is the goal of the storyteller. One of Maya Angelou's most famous quotes touches on this: "*...People will never forget how you made them feel.*"

People, I have found, love stories with certain elements. Almost universally, we love stories about the underdog journey, the redemption story. Life can be difficult, so we want to see people overcome adversity. When they do so, we're given hope that we can overcome our own struggles as well. In the underdog story, that underdog represents us; when they win, we win.

Love stories are usually memorable, too. At the core of being human, we all want to belong and be loved. That's why stories of the *happily-ever-after* are so popular. Many of us have grown up on these stories, which let us know that there is someone out there for each of us. We're hardwired to root for love conquering all obstacles. These stories instill hope in humanity.

In my experience, though, I've found people *really* love true-crime and prison stories. It is in these stories that our curiosity about the underworld is fulfilled. We live vicariously, comfortably, through the exploits of people who are breaking the rules of society, and we either root for them or root for their comeuppance. Most of us will never enter the criminal justice system. These stories are as close as we get, as close as anyone *should* want to get, and that distance grants us the safe thrill of voyeurism into the criminal mind. Whether uplifting like *The Shawshank Redemption* or gory or suspenseful or inspirational, prison stories present us

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with stories we relish hearing but have no desire to live through firsthand.

My story has all the above elements. My actual job, as a keynote speaker and author, is to travel the world inspiring audiences. A journalist once called me “the modern-day *Shawshank Redemption*” and compared me to one of its main characters, calling me a “real-life Andy Dufresne.” I pushed back against this; I told him that I understood where he was going with the comparison, but the biggest difference between Andy and me was that Andy was innocent, and I am guilty of the crimes that landed me in prison.

In 2009, a Dallas jury sentenced me to sixty-five years—a life sentence—for engaging in organized crime. Or, in prison slang, I got six dimes and a nickel. It was a RICO case, of which I was the ringleader. My actions put me into the harshest environment on earth: a Texas, level-five maximum-security prison with my whole life ahead of me.

This element of my story is why James Clear’s question piqued my curiosity so much. The Texas Department of Criminal Justice *did take control of my life* because of the choices I made. I was at a monstrous fork in the road. I knew that *something* had to change and that *something* was me. I just had no clue where to begin.

Inside those suffocating walls of prison, fighting for my life and my sanity, I found grit, courage, and determination to make the change. Sometimes, actually, it found me. It found me in the form of other inmates, sharing their wisdom learned from going through what I was about to go through. It came in the form of wardens and other prison officials who saw humanity in me, who sparked in me a desire to become the person they thought I could be. It came in the form of family and friends who never let me

forget there was a world waiting for me outside of prison walls, one I should never give up on. I had help, I continue to have help, and that help gives me the strength to challenge myself in ways big and small.

But first, I had to make it to a release date, one that could have been almost fifty years from the time I'm writing this now. With help, my dungeon became a cocoon, where I experienced a spiritual awakening. I became a redeemed man, a changed man. The change was so extreme that the parole board released me in 2015. However, I would be on parole—to serve the remaining years of my life sentence on supervised release—until the year 2073.

A few years after I got out of prison, I released my first book about making that change: *The Change Agent*. It was my autobiography, in which I told the story about a guy who had it all, squandered it all, and then defied all odds by making one of the most incredible comebacks. It was the book that introduced my story and me to the world.

Since then, I've written several other books, many of which became *Wall Street Journal* bestsellers in the business/personal development space. Although *The Coffee Bean*, my personal development bestseller that I coauthored with Jon Gordon, is the book most of the world knows me by, *The Change Agent* is my favorite of all my books. Part prison diary and part manifesto for transforming a life under the most extreme odds, it showed people that they are always capable of way more than they think. It was a blueprint for not allowing overthinking to get in the way of overcoming. In a word, it was all about *change*.

This book will pick up where *The Change Agent* left off. For those of you who have not read *The Change Agent*, no worries.

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You will be fine. I'll utilize part of this book to give you the back-story. I won't go into the level of detail *The Change Agent* contains regarding my past, my addiction to meth, my crime spree, or my daily life in prison; reading *The Change Agent* is not a requirement to understanding this book.

So much has happened since *The Change Agent* was published in 2019. In fact, I would venture to say that the transformation since then has been *more extreme* than the transformation I was able to complete inside of a maximum-security prison in Texas. Without getting too ahead of the story, I've become one of the most sought-after speakers on the planet, a bestselling author, a husband and stepfather, a college professor, a philanthropist, and an extremely successful entrepreneur.

More important than any of that, however, is that I have maintained my sobriety and created a life of impact and purpose by working a program of recovery—one day at a time. It is from the teachings of my program of recovery that so many of the principles in my life derive. If *The Change Agent* was me writing my story, this book aims to share the uncompromising principles I implemented to rewrite my story.

This is not a book primarily for people in recovery. Rather, this book, and the principles herein, are intended for everyone. It is a guide for living. Everyone has unlocked potential to make their own lives better through helping others, and I believe my story demonstrates ways to make positive changes without first going through devastating addiction or time in a maximum-security prison. Luckily, those are not prerequisites for this course.

Like the ink blot on the cover of this book, a literary journey begins when you put pen to paper. Each chapter title is one of the principles. The chapter content includes stories behind the principle, stories that either illustrate how adhering to the principle

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brought opportunity or accomplishment to my life, or illustrating how ignoring these principles landed me in the very deep hole from which I had to climb. At the end of each chapter there will be a reflection on the principle in the hopes you can apply these proven principles in your life. This book will be a tactical guide to discovering your maximum potential and rewriting *your* story in life.

This is my wheelhouse. I am a *storyteller*, who has learned the art of weaving real-life events into personal development gold. If you're wanting to not only make a change in your life but also discover how to maintain that change and become the best version of you, then you've come to the right place. Keep reading!

Damon West

December 2024

PROLOGUE

RELATIONSHIPS ARE EVERYTHING

The Compounding Interest of Doing the Next Right Thing

Heathrow Airport
July 7, 2022

“I believe we’re going to avoid an international incident,” Kendell said to me, adding some nervous laughter, once we had finally made it through the long lines at Heathrow Airport. My wife, my stepdaughter (Clara), and I sat in the United Airlines Lounge, waiting to board our flight back to Houston.

It was important for me to not miss my flight. I had made an agreement with the government of the United Kingdom that I would be out of their country today. Felons are not allowed to legally travel to the United Kingdom without a lot of paperwork, especially not felons like me, who were sentenced to *life* in prison and are on parole until 2073.

Being on parole for the rest of your life is like always having a sword hovering above your neck. The key is to acknowledge and respect the sword, but not to live in fear of the sword. Perspective

is everything. Every day when I wake up and my feet don't hit the cold, concrete floor of a prison cell is a day that I'm winning.

Prison, and then my new life today as a keynote speaker, college professor, and author, has taught me so many lessons about finding opportunities in adversity. One of the lessons I learned, exemplified by this trip to London, is that anything is possible if you have the right people that believe in you. Relationships are everything. Earned trust is everything.

Lucy Fato is the relationship that brought me to London. Making sure that I am on time to fly out is the small way I continue to earn her trust.



On April 1, I got a call from Lucy that I thought was an April Fool's joke.

"Given your new profile in the insurance industry, a group of risk managers in the UK have asked if it is possible for you to travel to London to meet with them. There is a significant focus on prison reform in the UK, which frankly I was unaware of. Risk managers from different corporations are working together to find solutions and they are interested in hearing from you directly about your experience. We thought we could couple that with you speaking with my team in London. They've been closely following you and your mission through the pro-bono work we are doing around criminal and social justice reform. And the risk managers will host you at The House of Lords! We want you to explain how your Be a Coffee Bean Foundation is addressing the needs of children in America who have incarcerated parents."

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Lucy was essentially pitching me on two speaking engagements that any normal keynote speaker would seize on with excitement.

“Lucy! That sounds incredible, but I can’t go.”

“What do you mean? I didn’t even give you a date, so you can’t possibly tell me you have a prior engagement,” she said with a tinge of annoyance. Lucy was not someone who hears “no” often.

Being a felon on parole means you must explain things to people that don’t necessarily make any sense. I can never vote again. I cannot become licensed for many jobs. I cannot get life insurance. I don’t have a right to refuse a search of my home or any vehicle I’m driving. But, relevant to Lucy’s exciting offer...

“I can’t go to London because felons are not allowed to travel to the UK.”

“I don’t understand. Why would your criminal background prevent you from traveling? You went to prison, did your time, and they let you go. You weren’t even a violent criminal.”

See what I mean? Lucy is applying logic to a situation that defies logic.

Rather than focus on what I can’t do while on parole, one of the many incredible things I have been able to do since walking out of prison is go back to school, earning a master’s degree in criminal justice and then becoming an adjunct professor at the University of Houston Downtown. For three years, I taught a class called Prisons in America, making me a university professor, teaching a class about prisons, who also lived in prison.

My students got to learn from someone who had firsthand experience with all facets of the American criminal justice system. From being a criminal on the streets, defendant in a courtroom, to inmate #1585689 in the Texas Department of Criminal Justice.

As a parolee on parole for life, I am that rare lived experience with which no textbook can compete.

In my class, I *was* the textbook.

On the first day of class, I asked my students if they thought America was a nation of second chances. After all, in front of them was one of the greatest comeback stories of a formerly incarcerated individual. Most of the criminal justice majors in the room were idealistic about their nation and their chosen profession, wanting to believe the best in our country and in a system in which they were planning their careers.

However, I would always pull the rug out from under them on day one with three simple, powerful words, told to me by a warden. It is the same sentence I told Lucy when she couldn't understand why the UK wouldn't let me in.

"Punishment never stops, Lucy."

Silence on the other end of the phone. Lucy is one of the most brilliant people I know. She is also someone who became a lawyer when she personally witnessed injustice in a Pittsburgh courtroom as a young woman. I knew what I said struck a nerve and she was digesting those three words, carefully choosing a response.

After a moment, she asked me to tell her more about the laws prohibiting me from traveling to the UK. I told her everything I knew, but I cautioned her that my information came not from a legal text, but from the network of other formerly incarcerated individuals in America with whom I was connected. There is actually a social network of formerly incarcerated men and women, all of us out there becoming pillars of society, showing by our actions that second chances are worthwhile, that worthy lives after prison are possible. Several of us are entrepreneurs. The reality is that many formerly incarcerated people become

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entrepreneurs out of necessity. If you must check that felony box on an application in America, you will find yourself shut out of many jobs.

Interestingly enough, a lot of these formerly incarcerated men and women are lawyers, like Lucy.

I explained that there are several dozen countries that deny entry to felons from America. In turn, America also denies entry to those countries' felons. Kind of like a bizarre import/export embargo on formerly incarcerated people. Every continent of earth was represented.

Heck, Australia was even on the list, and it began as a penal colony in the 1700s, when the British started sending their criminals there. Talk about forgetting where you come from!

"I'm thinking we should plan these London presentations the first week of July," Lucy responded to me, unfazed by everything I had shared with her about travel restrictions. "Bring Kendell and Clara. You can make a family vacation out of it."

Her response did not surprise me. Lucy is a solutions-oriented leader who uses common sense and finds a way to win. Moreover, she is someone who champions the underdog. As the lead counsel for a high-profile, global company, she uses her experience and platform to fight for the little guy.

That was how Lucy and I met.

Last year, Lucy came across my profile on LinkedIn and sent me a DM. We hopped on a call and then she brought me in to speak at her corporate offices in New York. Then, she introduced me to the pro-bono program she oversaw, whose purpose was to find underdogs in all walks of life and help them overcome adversity with the resources of a massive global corporation behind them.

The Be a Coffee Bean Foundation, whose mission is to provide children of incarcerated parents with extra-curricular scholarships, became the beneficiary of Lucy and her company's pro-bono resources. In an instant, the foundation Kendell and I created had the resources to help at-risk kids all over America with the finances to become involved in activities that were once out of their reach. Lucy saw what we saw. Kids don't get to pick their parents, and kids with an incarcerated parent were at greater risk to one day become incarcerated themselves than a kid who did not have an incarcerated parent.

This travel thing, however, was a different beast, a fight too big for Lucy. "Lucy, I love your warrior spirit, and there is no one else I want in a foxhole with me than you, but this is a foreign policy that is shared by both the UK and the US. Not to mention, the Texas Department of Criminal Justice, which would have to issue me a travel permit, one I'm guessing it has never issued."

Silence on the other end of the phone.

After a moment, Lucy responded. "Damon, let's start by applying for your visa. I'm confident we will get this done."

Everyone needs help. Lucy wants me to be in London, and she's devoted herself to being that help. Relationships are everything.

Following Lucy's instructions, I worked with members of her team and applied for my visa. The response from the UK Home Office was swift and the answer decisive:

Your application for entry clearance is refused under paragraph 9.4.1 of Part 9 of the Immigration Rules because

Paragraph 9.4.1(a) states that an application for entry clearance, permission to enter or permission to stay must be refused where the applicant has been

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convicted of a criminal offence in the UK or overseas for which they have received a custodial sentence of 12 months or more.

You state that you were convicted of a criminal offence and sentenced to 65 years in prison on 18/05/2009.

You have received a custodial sentence of 12 months or more. It is therefore mandatory to refuse your application.

Honestly, I was not surprised at all by the response; I expected it. I forwarded the email to Lucy with three words: "Punishment Never Stops."

Lucy replied within minutes. Her email simply said, "I'll take it from here."

After consulting with a well-known immigration attorney, who told her getting me a visa would never happen, Lucy said, "Thank you very much," and instead turned to her own team. Over the next few weeks, we worked on immigration and background information, enlisting help from a global private investigative firm that partnered with Lucy on various pro-bono matters. It is the kind of firm high-profile individuals hire to do self-due diligence and background checks to see if there was any *discoverable* dirt on them. I can honestly say the dossier it put together on me was more than my lawyer did for my organized crime trial.

Admittedly, it was a little baffling to me that we were doing all this work considering the odds were so overwhelmingly against us. From time to time, Lucy would call me to go over the agenda

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for the trip, even telling me that she personally bought all of us tickets for Wimbledon at Centre Court.

Meanwhile, I still hadn't even purchased plane tickets.

I consider myself a confident person, but Lucy was on a whole different level. If she had doubts, she hid them from me.

Then, on May 27, I opened my email, and my jaw dropped. It was from the UK Home Office, the same agency that had denied me a month earlier. I was stunned in disbelief as I read the letter.

Dear DAMON JOSEPH WEST,

Please note that your visa decisions has been overturned/a correction is required to your visa.

Please submit your passport to the Scan Hub at the following address with a copy of this e-mail ensuring that the envelope is clearly marked with the word "OVERTURNED" on the outside.

Once we have confirmation that the passports have been received, we will send out a new decision to be endorsed on your passport.

Kind Regards,

UK Visas and Immigration (UKVI)

My first call was to my wife, who was equally shocked. We had both agreed to not mention anything about a possible England trip to her daughter, Clara, until I could verify the email was real. My next call was to Lucy.

By the tone of Lucy's voice, it was obvious she already knew. In fact, she had always known. "Lucy, I survived living in a max-

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imum-security prison by not asking a lot of questions. I have to find out. How did you do it?”

“It doesn’t matter. All you needed was someone who could talk common sense to them. Your track record since you left prison speaks for itself, and they are lucky to have someone like you visiting their country to educate others on important issues like prison reform. I never doubted my team would get it done. Have you told Kendell and Clara we are all going to England?”

After I hung up the phone, I purchased three round-trip tickets to London and called Kendell to tell her it was time to tell Clara we were going to London. Just the thought of taking the trip made my eyes well up with tears.

I wasn’t emotional because I was going to England. I wasn’t even emotional that Lucy had put so much confidence in me, that her continued belief in me allowed me to meet new audiences and share my message. I had to take deep breaths because after the poor decisions I had made as a drug addict and criminal, and the consequences that came with them, my family would not have to suffer because of me.



Back at Heathrow, Kendell squeezed my hand, realizing how unlikely it was for us to be returning from the UK. When we were married, the conversation about honeymoon destinations was a reality check regarding her decision to marry a formerly incarcerated individual. We ended up going to Mexico, without facing any travel restrictions.

“You’re a good man, Damon, who does a lot for so many. Lucy coming into your life is proof of that. It’s God’s way of sending an angel to help you.”

I call these things *God Things*. Only God could be responsible for some of the things that have happened in my life. I have help. Relationships are everything.

“Speaking of angels,” she asked, “what are you going to post for your anniversary at the end of the month?”

I knew what anniversary she was referring to: July 30. A SWAT team boot on my chest. A rock bottom rapidly approaching. A fork in the road.

“Hard to believe it’s been fourteen years since those angels rescued me.”

Reflections

The choices you make today will go with you for the rest of your life. These consequences are the by-product of your thinking at the time. This story illustrates the fact that there are both good and bad consequences of your thinking and your choices. Years ago, my best thinking turned me into a criminal, and the consequence was life in prison and, subsequently, on parole until 2073. On the other hand, because I changed the way I think, the consequences today are that people believe in me.

Everything goes back to your thinking. How you think matters because your thoughts control your actions, and actions have consequences.

Once your thoughts and actions are aligned in a positive way, you begin attracting the right people into your life. These relationships are the building blocks for both your successes and the platform you will create that can help

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others. In healthy relationships, we look for ways to help and serve others.

Lastly, be a connector. A constant theme in this book is connecting people.

CHAPTER 1

YOU ARE THE SUM OF THE PEOPLE AROUND YOU

Surround Yourself with the Right Crowd

The Backstory: July 30, 2008
Dallas, Texas

I never set out to be the leader of a criminal ring. Heck, when I was growing up, I wanted to be a sports agent. Instead, I became an alcoholic, a drug addict, and a thief. As a drug addict, I gave up my goals in exchange for my behaviors.

Addiction touches every person in this country. Whether you're an addict, the victim of an addict, the family member of an addict, or a friend of an addict, no one is immune from the epidemic of addiction in America. Maybe you're one of the luckiest people who don't fall into any of those categories. In that case, your taxes are going to treat addiction, often in the form of incarceration. It touches you as well.

My fifth-grade teacher told me, "Damon, you're a natural-born leader, and you will either lead people the right way or the wrong way in life."

She was correct on both accounts. I had once led people the right way, as evidenced by being the starting QB for a D1 football team. I had also led people the very wrong way, leading a group of addicts who broke into homes and apartments in Dallas.

We stole for meth.

It was a hot July day. I had not slept one minute the night before. Meth will do that to you. It keeps you up. However, this day was made even more difficult because I was a marked man.

I was sitting on the couch, in a little apartment, smoking meth with my dealer, a guy named Tex. As we were passing this pipe back and forth, I was telling Tex he needed to leave. "The cops are closing in on me. The end is near. You don't want to be here right now."

Ten days before this, my partner in crime, Dustin, had been picked up by the Dallas Police Department. It was all behind a stolen car. Now they had him in custody, which meant I knew it was just a matter of time before I was in custody. In crime, everybody talks! There is no honor among thieves. And that is exactly what we were: thieves.

As I was passing the pipe back to Tex, the window to my right blew out and shattered. Tumbling across my living room floor was a canister going end over end. It was smoking on one side. I knew what it was because I had seen this in a movie before. As quickly as my brain could send the signal to my legs, I leapt off the couch and tried to get out of the living room.

Too late. Boom!

The flashbang grenade went off in my face. A bright white light. A loud noise. My ears were ringing. I was temporarily blinded. The flashbang achieved its purpose of disorienting me.

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When my eyes could focus again there was a cop standing over me in full SWAT riot gear. His boot was on my chest and the barrel of an assault rifle was pressed into my eye socket. Cutting through the ringing in my ears was his voice, screaming at the top of his lungs, “Don’t move! Don’t move!”

I screamed back to him, at the top of my lungs, “Don’t worry! Don’t worry!”

Then I heard another officer call out loudly, “We got him! We got The Uptown Burglar.”

The Uptown Burglar. A name I’ll live with for the rest of my life.

About a dozen other meth addicts and myself—young and old, male and female, black and white and everything in between because drugs and addiction do not discriminate—broke into the homes of dozens and dozens of people in the uptown neighborhood of Dallas (and beyond) to feed our insatiable meth habits. Our crime spree had gone on for about two years.

I had surrounded myself with the wrong crowd, but they had as well. I was just as much the wrong crowd as anyone else in the crime ring.

When you’re a quarterback, you may take the field as the star, and you may take the field as the savior, but you do not take the field alone. You are the sum of the people around you. You are the best qualities of your coaches and teammates. When you go to work, you are the sum of the people around you, and your best work will come driven by the quality of your team. In my own life, I had been part of the best crowd, my family, who loved and supported me. By the time I was an adult on my own, they had equipped me with all the tools I needed to have a successful life.

When you're an addict, though, those tools rust, and instead of being part of a team, everyone is focused on themselves. And you contribute the most to your own destruction. I once played football, cheered by tens of thousands of people. I once was the son of two proud parents. That had been my crowd. However, now my crowd was other addicts and criminals, strung out, desperate, and looking for the next victim. I was not above them; I was them. The crew of meth-addicted thieves saw the exact same bad crowd in me as I saw in them.

On July 30, 2008, the Uptown Burglaries came to an end because the ringleader of the entire thing was zip-tied on the dirty floor of an apartment on Holland Avenue. The police lifted me up, read me my rights, and dozens of officers made a path in my living room for me to be escorted out. I looked down both sides of the street and saw that it was cordoned off for blocks. Dozens of DPD cars were littered all over. Police were everywhere. They watched as I was marched out of the building. They shoved me in the back of a police cruiser.

Dallas County jail is one of the biggest jail complexes in America. More populous than many small towns, it houses about nine thousand inmates. No other inmate I knew of in Dallas County had a bond the size of mine. At \$1.4 million, my bond made it harder for me to bond out than child molesters, rapists, and murderers.

My crimes were nothing like those crimes. Mine were property crimes. No one was ever home during my burglaries, my victims and I never saw each other, no one was physically hurt, and no weapons were used. However, Dallas County sent a clear message with my bond: I was not getting out of this.

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Mind you, this was not the first time I had ever been arrested. Over the past few years, as a drug addict, I had had several minor arrests and run-ins with the law. I was out on bond for another charge when SWAT took me down. That previous charge meant that I had to have an ankle monitor on me and report to an officer, which is how SWAT knew exactly where I was.

What shocked Dallas PD and SWAT was that my ankle monitor was not on my ankle when they took me down; it sat on the end table next to the couch. When I felt the heat closing in on me after Dustin's arrest, I figured out how to remove the monitor without it setting off any alarms. The wiring diagram for the monitor was on the internet.

Successfully free of the monitor, I had been able to make some moves around Dallas in those final few days before being taken down. Alas, with no real plan, and no ability to score meth anywhere else, I was a sitting duck in my apartment that day with Tex.

Tex was my meth dealer and "friend," who had been in and out of prison, rolled over on me the minute SWAT escorted me out of the apartment. With no stolen property in my actual apartment, Tex took DPD to the second apartment I had down the street on Holland, which contained over a million dollars' worth of peoples' stolen property from the Uptown Burglaries.

When DPD booked me into jail, it was kind of like some twisted version of being a VIP at a club. They literally escorted me to the front of the dozens of other people who had also been arrested that day and were awaiting booking. In their haste to get me in holding, they never patted me down. Had they done that, they would have found a baggie of meth and the key to the other apartment where all the stolen stuff was.

Damon West

Once past the desk, I went to one of the toilets, ate the meth out of the baggie and then flushed both the key and the empty baggie down the toilet, having no clue that would be the last hit of meth I would ever take. Evidence flushed, I settled into the waiting area with all the other newly arrested people and began intake processing.

I was called in for my mug shot and fingerprinting, then sent back into the holding area, where everyone sat in front of a TV on the wall. Within hours, the breaking news of the arrest was announced, and my recently taken mug shot was plastered on the screen. The newscaster said, "Today, police announced the arrest of Damon West." Every head in the holding tank turned and looked at me, while some of the people started laughing and pointing in my direction.

Despite all the negative attention and warning signs going off, my main thoughts that day and night were focused on meth. As in, *how was I going to get more now that I was in jail?* That is the thought process of every addict; we obsess over the thing we are addicted to.

Later that night, as more of the newly arrested were booked into county, I began coming down off both my high and the incredible events of the day. It was finally over. In a perverse way, I felt a stronger presence of my faith at that moment than I had in ages. I felt I had brought this onto myself because I prayed for it to be over.

About a month before my arrest, having been out of dope for a few days, coming down hard from about a three-year high, I lay on the floor of my apartment and prayed to God for all of the misery with my addiction to be gone.

Perhaps I should have been more specific with my prayer.

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Reflections

Looking back, I realize that SWAT didn't just arrest me that day; they rescued me that day. My angels did not have wings. They had assault rifles, shields, and helmets. They came through the windows and busted my door off the hinges to pull me out of that world in which I existed.

The police who built the case against me, the SWAT team that led the arrest—they were stronger than the sum of their parts. Those men and women had surrounded themselves with the right people, people who would not let my crimes go unnoticed or unpunished, people who believed in justice.

It's not lost on me that they did not know if I was dangerous when they burst into my apartment. They didn't know how much of a fight I would put up. In the restraint they showed, they gifted me the first seed of an opportunity. I no longer had my crew. I was about to be about as isolated as a person can be. It was now that I could start rebuilding my life and rebuilding the crowd around me. I had to find the right people to bring myself back, and more than that, I had to be the right person in their crowd.

In my life since that day, I have tried at every chance to shift my mindset to look for those opportunities, to become a more positive person, who sees the potential in even the toughest of times, who can be the right crowd for others.

Two key ingredients in this new way of thinking are humility and grace. The former to be able to know your

place in this world is not as grand as your ego may have you to believe—being right-sized. The latter is so you can accept the situation and move on; however, grace is difficult because grace always costs the person giving it more than it costs the person who receives it.

Most people will never go through a real SWAT raid. However, the SWAT teams of life come for us in different ways. A SWAT team can be a bankruptcy, a marriage failing, the loss of a job, a loved-one dying, the loss of a pet, or a life-altering event. Growth is when we understand, in these situations of pain and adversity, there is an opportunity for us to become better versions of ourselves.

Angels are all around us. They are always the best crowd to surround yourself with. Sometimes they are difficult to see in the tough situations they usher in. Other times, they are easily recognizable. Especially the ones that you seek out for their help.

CHAPTER 2

ALWAYS ASK THE QUESTION

Stay Ready to Be Ready

August 4, 2022

Winning takes care of most problems. This was my thought as I surveyed Coach Saban's office in Tuscaloosa. It was in this same football facility, five years ago, that I earned the respect of Coach Saban, his team, and the operation's director, who could not believe I had the audacity to proposition Coach Saban for an endorsement video. The ops guy did not know me well enough then to understand that I *always* ask the question.

Five years ago, Coach Saban's belief in me, and his endorsement video, helped propel me in the speaking world. Not just on the college football circuit, but also in the world of corporate speaking. CEOs and leaders follow teams that win championships and, when possible, try to deploy the same motivational resources those winners use.

Since the world is not running low on keynote speakers, I put in a lot of work to create separation from the crowd. Building a career and a platform out of this, differentiating myself in a dense field of speakers, requires a ton of dedication, persistence, and relationship building. Honing a clear message and connecting

to people is a talent people can have naturally, but to be able to adapt it to *all* crowds and *all* situations is something that comes with practice. It requires a lot of preparation to tailor my message to each audience, often with at least one pre-presentation conference call so that I can learn the client's core values and be able to speak intelligently about the things that are important to them.

Most of the words I say on stage I've said to myself in the mirror a thousand times before. I practice so I can convince others what I believe—that my message is a positive one and it can help people. I have a lot of practice in convincing others, but first I started by convincing myself.



My first job after prison was working at the Provost Umphrey Law Firm in Beaumont, Texas. That law firm job was one of the biggest doors opened to me after prison. Truth be told, it opened while I was still in prison, writing my own appeal. The owner of the firm, a legendary Texas lawyer named Walter Umphrey, read my legal writ and was so impressed with my work that he told me, “You put together one hell of a writ for a guy who’s never been to law school. If you ever get out of prison, come see me. I’ll hire you.”

True to his word, on my second day out of prison, I went to see Walter. Just as I had many times over the previous years, I sat across from someone and convinced them what I had convinced myself was rock-solid truth: *My past was in my past and I had made myself ready to make the most of every opportunity.* Walter hired me as a paralegal. Although I was a convicted felon, on parole for life, I was now gainfully employed at one of the most prestigious firms in Southeast Texas. I began my career in law working for a

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brilliant lawyer at his firm named Christopher Kirchmer. It was another God Thing, as Chris was more than just my boss; he became a best friend.

Walter did more than just give me a job; he gave me instant validation. I was spared the stigma most formerly incarcerated people endure when they return to society. Head held high, I began rebuilding my life one day at a time. I kept myself ready to seize upon any opportunity to better myself.

One way I started doing this was developing out my story to share with others. I wanted to use my story to help catch people before they hit rock bottom, to get to them before a jury or a coroner did. When I asked the firm for its support in this endeavor, I once more had to present myself as the person who would make the most of it.

Luckily, the firm and Chris supported my vision of sharing my story with others. They felt it was a public service project unique to Provost Umphrey. In the beginning, I would use my sick and vacation time to go speak to local schools, civic organizations, church groups, and youth sports teams. When I ran out of available time off to use, they always made sure I was able to have more, making the impossibility of speaking while holding down a job possible. I made little to no money speaking in the first few years, so maintaining my employment there was a lifeline.

On the days when I was not speaking, I practiced my presentation in front of a mirror in the spare bedroom in which I lived at my parents' house. Getting in my reps by practicing my presentation each day, I was preparing myself for the right opportunity to share my story in front of college football teams. A college football team may seem like a strange group to target. They seem motivated already! They also have coaches, fans, and each other

to motivate themselves. But I wasn't trying to get them psyched up for the game on Saturday. I was trying to get them to follow a better path than the one I took. College football was where I believed my story would have a major impact because I was once a D1 quarterback; the players and I could relate to each other, and the lessons within my story would help them tremendously.

It had been twenty years since I had taken a snap in college, though, so I did not know anyone in college football, and they did not know me. Regardless, I prepared each day, waiting for that opportunity.

My call came on January 11, 2017, from Michael Orta, a close friend and my videographer. Michael also worked as a sports photographer for KHOU, the CBS station in Houston. That was the role he was in on that fateful January day.

"Damon, get to Houston right now," he said, with urgency in his voice. "I'm working an event, the Bear Bryant Coach of the Year Award. The eight best coaches in college football are in this room at the Toyota Center. I've got an extra press pass. Get here and I'll sneak you in so you can meet them."

On the other end of the phone, a smile pursed on my lips and my pulse increased. My friend did not have to say another word. Houston was ninety miles away and it was closing in on rush hour. "I'll be there in two hours." This was a major opportunity, so I logged out of my computer and shut the light off in my cubicle.

I knocked on Chris's door and asked him if I could leave early. I told him what it was for. "Get out of here," he said, without hesitation. In that moment he was speaking more as my friend than my boss. "This could be your shot."

On my way to the Toyota Center, I stopped at home to change into a suit. At the time, I still lived with my parents. Obviously,

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that's not the normal situation for a forty-one-year-old man, but I was making around \$30,000 a year and rebuilding a life I had burned to the ground; I would need help putting it all back together. My parents, thankfully, were always there to help me.

Properly suited up in the better of my two hand-me-down suits a friend donated to me when I was released from prison, I headed to Houston. On my drive, I rehearsed how I would ask to be invited into their locker rooms. I repeated and repeated my elevator pitch as to why the coaches should bring me in to speak to their teams. One by one, I envisioned each coach smiling back as I shook their hands. Manifesting a vision of succeeding was something I had used in both sports and in prison.

Michael met me at the door of the Toyota Center and slipped me a press credential that would allow me full access to all the coaches. He shared with me the press notes for all the coaches, so I would have some background information. It was like a who's-who of college football, with eight head coaches from schools like Clemson, USC, Wisconsin, and Penn State.

Once inside, I wasted no time. Just as I had envisioned doing, I began going up to each coach, shaking their hands and giving them my pitch of why they should bring me in to speak to their teams. Unfortunately, reality was nothing like the vision I had created only a few hours earlier driving on I-10. One rejection followed another, until, after only one hour, I had seven nos. It was a bloodbath of rejection.

Retreating off to the edge of the room, far away from all the people who were enjoying the gala, self-doubt began creeping into my thoughts. The voice in my head told me things like: *You don't belong in this room, Damon. Did you expect one of these coaches to say yes? You're an imposter. Go home!*

After a few minutes of licking my wounds and feeling sorry for myself, I snapped out of it. Being ready means being ready to pivot, or if you believe your plan is built on a solid foundation, to keep moving forward with it. Shutting off the voice in my head, I stopped listening to myself and began talking to myself. It was a technique I learned in prison to tune out negative thoughts, especially that lying voice of fear that screams so loudly in difficult situations.

Out loud, I reminded myself that I had survived prison; this situation was nowhere near as bad as that. With the simple application of perspective, I stood a little taller and began getting my courage back. Sure, the odds were against me, but I reminded myself that odds do not matter. What were the odds of me even being in that arena to begin with? What were the odds of me making it out of prison in seven years?

Telling myself I was not leaving until the final coach in the room told me no, I began looking for Dabo Swinney, from Clemson University.

Dabo was the hardest guy to get to in the room. His team had just beaten Alabama two nights before in the national championship. Everybody in the room wanted to shake his hand and take a picture with him. Regardless, I was not leaving until I gave him my pitch and asked to share my message with the champions.

I looked like a stalker. From a distance, I followed Dabo and his entourage. At one point, I anticipated his path and went to hide behind some fake plants in hopes of ambushing him.

Weaving in and out of the crowd, I finally found myself face-to-face with Dabo. We shook hands and I got right to the point. I knew I was speaking too fast, but I was passionate, trying to get

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in as many key points of my story as possible. After about sixty seconds, he stopped me and asked, “You got a card on you?”

Reaching into my jacket, I handed him a card. He glanced at it, put it in his pocket and said he would check me out. Then, he was gone. As nice as he had been, I knew from his brevity and his body language that he was my eighth, and final, no.

No matter. I felt good about the effort I gave because I left it all on the field. Despite the fact I had been shut out, I asked every coach in the room the question I came to ask. Defeated, but not devastated, I held my head up high as I headed for the exit of the Toyota Center. On the way to my car, I called Michael. “Hey, brother. Thanks for getting me in. They all said no, but I showed up and fought hard.”

“Dude, it’s like that old guy told you in prison, about fighting all your fights. Be safe driving home and rest well. No regrets. You’ll get there.”

Indeed, no regrets. I put the Toyota Center, and the whole experience, in the rear-view mirror.

Several months later, I received an email that almost made me fall out of my chair. It was from the director of football operations at Clemson University.

Subject: Coach Swinney Gave Me Your Name

Would love for you to speak to our team, between Aug. 1–12 at some point. Working on the calendar with Coach Swinney, but we 100 percent want you in front of our team.

Mike Dooley
Clemson Football
Director of Football Operations & Personnel

Oh my God! Not only did I get a yes from that night at the Toyota Center, but it was also the *biggest* yes in the room. The head coach of the national champions wanted me to speak to his team.

Mike Dooley asked me if I had August 1 open. I told him, “I have every first open.” Most of my presentations at that point were to kids, to local civic organizations, or in front of a mirror in my parents’ spare bedroom.

Time marched on until that August date finally arrived. I had spoken in front of a few college football teams in the interim, thanks to a football operations director named Randy Ross. Randy believed in me before anyone else. He made some calls and got me in front of some teams, for which I was eternally grateful. But Clemson was the Taj Mahal of college football. Even more impressive than the millions of dollars that went into the buildings was its culture. The team—from coaches to staff to players and their families—was truly one big family, who loved each other.

Right before my presentation, I gave Dabo a wooden coffee bean keychain. It wasn’t much, but I could not afford to give much. I told him the keychain would make sense after he heard me tell my story. Then, it was gametime. Mike Dooley escorted me down to the massive team room, where more than one hundred college football players from the defending national champions were waiting to hear me speak.

At that moment, I thought about how far away I was from that maximum-security prison. *If the boys in the joint could see me now*, I thought. As I always did before I spoke, I said a prayer, asking that I be used as a conduit of hope and to have a positive impact.

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After my presentation, the team erupted with a standing ovation and the players approached me, one by one, to thank me. It was an incredible high because I could see and feel the impact it had on them. After all the players finally left the team room, Dabo came up to me and spoke passionately about what he witnessed from my presentation. He had never seen his players so engaged, had never had to shut down a question-and-answer session following a presentation because of time constraints.

“Everyone needs to hear your story. Have you been to Alabama, to talk to their football team?” He asked.

My first inclination was to say, *Who do you think you’re talking to? I’m a nobody*. Instead, I said, “No, sir. This is the pinnacle of my speaking. Alabama doesn’t know who I am.”

“We’ll see about that,” Dabo said. He told me he had just texted Nick Saban from the back of the room and told him what he witnessed.

That caught me off guard. Not just because he helped me, but also because he wanted to help his arch-rival, Alabama. Talk about character.

Dabo asked if he could do anything to help me get the coffee bean message out further. “How about a video?” I asked.

Without hesitation, Dabo told me to pull out my phone and then he recorded an endorsement video that went wild on social media. Before leaving, he and I exchanged numbers and promised to stay in touch. I could barely sleep that night after such an amazing experience.

The next day, I received a voicemail from the director of football operations at Alabama. The message said that Dabo *called* Coach Saban and Coach Saban could not wait to hear my story

in front of his team. “How does August twenty-first, at 7:30 p.m. work for your calendar?”

My calendar, I thought, laughing out loud. I had *nothing* on my calendar. Besides, I would hitchhike to Tuscaloosa if I had to in order to make that appointment. I immediately called the operations director back and agreed.

Dabo did not stop with Alabama, either. He would go on to call every head coach in his phone and advocate for them to bring me in to speak to their teams. And to think it would have never happened if I left the Bear Bryant Coach of the Year Awards in 2017 without sticking around to pitch Dabo after receiving those seven rejections.

Years after that night in Houston, I asked Dabo why he said yes. He told me he could see the conviction and belief in my eyes. He said he knew that look because he had it too when he was trying to prove himself as a young coach. Growth follows belief.



Five years later, I counted Alabama’s operations director as a friend, as we had grown our relationship since that somewhat-tense first encounter. He also became a believer in me after hearing my story and seeing how Coach Saban enthusiastically recorded that endorsement video. Tonight, I would share that same message to a new Alabama football team.

The ops director and I shook hands, and he wished me luck. Then, just as he did five years earlier, he introduced me to the Crimson Tide. Walking out on that stage felt different this time, though. It felt more...natural.

As I surveyed the room, I saw all the players locked in. Coach Saban was in his usual seat. Front row, center chair, notepad

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out. The clock in the upper right corner was set at forty minutes and was now ticking. I had kept myself ready for these moments. Go time!

“Gentlemen, I’m here tonight to talk to you about finding the opportunity in adversity. Because inside every situation of adversity, there is an opportunity for you to grow. An opportunity for you to become the best version of yourself. Let me tell you the story of the coffee bean.”

Reflections

The only question you know the answer to in life is the one you do not ask. That answer will always be no because you never asked your question. Simply by asking your questions, you increase your odds of getting what you want. It is much easier to live with a defeat than to live with regret.

Wayne Gretzky may have said it best: “You miss one hundred percent of the shots you do not take.”

You gotta take your shots in life. If you don’t do it, no one will do it for you. No one else will fight harder for your hopes, goals, and dreams than you.

And no one else will believe in you until you believe in yourself. Belief that you are worthy because you are. That belief will be felt by others. By practicing your craft, in any part of life, though, you will get yourself ready, so that if you get the yes to your question, it will pay off for the person giving it. It will lead to more opportunities, to more yeses.

Damon West

See yourself succeeding. Manifest your dreams in your mind before you do them. Your mind and the power of suggestion are powerful forces when they work in a positive direction.

In my story, I used surviving prison as a reminder of a time when I overcame adversity. Most people will never have a real prison as their reference, but everyone has a memory of a time they persevered through a difficult situation. That time you overcame adversity. Remind yourself of that memory and focus on it to keep chasing your dream. Use that memory to shut out the “imposter syndrome” voice when it surfaces.

CHAPTER 3

TWO KINDS OF ADVERSITY IN LIFE

The Kind *Life* Creates & The Kind *You* Create

The Backstory: May 18, 2009

My organized crime trial took place ten months after my arrest. With so much overwhelming evidence of my guilt, Dallas County put me on the rocket-docket. That's when the authorities want you in a courtroom ASAP, because the case is still fresh in the minds of people and they're planning to make an example out of you.

Adding to my concerns, was the fact Judge Mike Snipes had presided over the entire thing. Snipes was bad news for me. He and I used to move around in the same social circles in Dallas, before I was a meth-addicted criminal and he was a criminal district court judge. We met in the late '90s on my friend's boat and would run into each other occasionally at bars and clubs. He was a former full-bird colonel, and I was an arrogant former college quarterback who knew it all. We were not what I would consider good friends.

Still, we were cordial and friendly to each other. The last time I had seen him, before this current legal nightmare, was in 2004. His father had just passed away and I bought him a shot to celebrate his father's life.

Five years later, on trial for my life, there was not a single hint of friendliness coming my way from Snipes. In fact, it was the opposite. In my opinion, he handled me roughly, even making comments about me from time to time that I believed were out of line. Such as when he called me the “Hannibal Lecter of burglaries.” To this day, I’m confident no one in that courtroom other than Snipes knew what that meant. That was during a pretrial hearing when I was trying to get the search warrant from the SWAT raid thrown out. The whole case hinged on that warrant. The warrant was a potential disaster for the prosecution because Snipes signed it and, in my opinion, it lacked any probable cause.

I believed he knew it, they knew it, and my defense surely knew it. No matter, Snipes cleaned up his own mess when he refused to allow an outside judge to review the warrant, subsequently denying our motion. The mountain of evidence against me would remain a part of the case.

The trial was brutal, too. What evidence law enforcement didn’t already have, and my co-conspirators did not testify to, I provided in the form of jail-house recordings. Criminals are stupid, and I was one of the dumbest based on all the things I said on the phone calls.

In the end, those calls made me the biggest witness against myself; I did sound like the mob boss the prosecutor told the jury I was. Since I didn’t take the stand, there was no way I could tell the jury that I was just a dope fiend, trying to raise money from other criminals on the phone so that I could bond out of jail and get high. The jury’s impression of me was of a guy who had it all, threw it all away, and used his leadership abilities to lead people in the wrong direction.

In the punishment phase of the trial, to fully inform the jury of how I got there, my lawyer introduced the most private details

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of my life. When I was nine, I was the victim of sexual molestation by an adult female babysitter. Even though I would never blame the molestation on the choices I made to steal, I could absolutely trace my substance abuse back to that event. That's when I began putting chemicals in my body to change the way I felt. It was embarrassing to hear it talked about in a packed courtroom, but I was willing to use those dark memories to mitigate the damage I had done.

The punishment phase presented the jury with the full spectrum of how I had landed there. At nine, life created adversity for me. Then I picked up that baton and ran with it, bringing more adversity into my life, first with drugs, then with crime. Once started, the misfortunes just continued until I landed in Judge Snipes's courtroom.

My attorney was another form of adversity that I brought into my life. Personally, I thought Ed Sigel was a bit of an anachronism. He was a throwback from the '60s, always telling people he served in Robert Kennedy's justice department. His hubris often got in the way of reality, as he was convinced my case did not meet the RICO (Racketeer Influenced Corrupt Organization) statute standards. This was a constant issue, too, because the State, the Judge and, by now, the jury believed it was RICO.

My jury despised me. I could feel it from across the courtroom. They clearly believed the prosecution's depiction of me as a crime boss who systematically ordered others to commit crimes for my personal gain. Locking me away meant one less person stealing what they had worked for.

What was obviously missing from the prosecution's narrative was the fact that I was an addict, a junkie. At every turn, when we would try to bring up the intoxication element of the crimes, Snipes shut us down. It was, at this point, on that final day, where

I realized how big of a mistake it was to plead *not guilty* and to not take the stand in my own defense.

So, I asked Ed the same question I posed one week before, when we were picking a jury. "Can I take the stand?"

"Absolutely not!" he said, raising his voice. He explained that when you're guilty of more than what the jury already believes, all you can do is make it worse. The range of punishment was ten years of probation to life in prison. He estimated we would be there for another week if I took the stand. "You'll be answering questions about other crimes. Like stealing a vehicle from the Texas Rangers. How would you explain that one to the jury?"

He had a point. The last thing I needed were the *omitted* crimes I committed coming to light. The Texas Rangers were no joke, either. One of the bailiffs in this courtroom told me he was a former Ranger. He made it a point to let me know that on one of the lunch breaks during my trial. The way he said it felt like he was letting me know that he was aware of me stealing crucial evidence from that vehicle impound yard.

Speaking of omitted crimes, I was shocked to see the prosecution never mentioned anything about the methods I used to gain access to residences. I kept waiting for them to tell the jury about the post office I broke into and the mailman suit I stole, which gave me the ability to move around neighborhoods with impunity.

And there was nothing about the reverse peephole viewers or wireless camera receiver Dustin and I used to make sure no victims were ever home. In the end, Dustin obviously did not totally give me up.

"Ed, if you had to guess, what are they going to sentence me to today? I mean, I know I'm going to prison. The question is, for how long?"

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“This is a burglary case, Damon. The max on that is twenty years. You won’t get more than twenty.”

“Ed, we’ve been over this. It’s a RICO case. And I’m the boss. I have a bad feeling about this. Have a bad feeling during this whole trial.”

“Well, I would refer to this as *disorganized crime*. Y’all were a bunch of *dopeheads* who got lucky for a few years.”

Who uses the term *dopeheads*? This guy was such a dinosaur. He was also extremely naïve. For the entire time he defended me, we never saw eye-to-eye. I tried to get Snipes recused from the case and he fought me on it, saying Snipes was a former colonel and that meant he had honor.

Then, Ed had a bicycling accident a few months before my trial, which made him even more aloof. My family—who cashed in their retirement to hire Ed—hired a second attorney, Karen Lambert, to assist with the case, which only pissed Ed off. Karen, on the other hand, was a phenomenal attorney. She listened to my concerns and answered all my questions. Unfortunately, she was second-chair counsel, meaning Ed was the voice of our legal team.

That’s the other thing about bringing adversity into your life. At a certain point, the people around you amass enough evidence that you can’t be trusted to not make an even bigger mess. They’ve seen the wreckage of terrible decision after terrible decision and so they gently take the keys from your hands. I could complain about Snipes and Ed. I may have been “right” about both, but who was going to listen to the guy who had made all the choices to land in that courtroom?

Throw into the mix that I was a terrible defendant, who was guilty of everything, violated the social contract at will, created victims all over Dallas, played cat-and-mouse with Dallas PD, and

evaded capture for years. Then, I ran my mouth for hours on a recorded prison phone. That makes for a toxic soup.

The day of my sentencing felt different. Up until then, there was always time on the clock. As if on cue with the dreadful clock in my head, the bailiff entered the room on Ed's side of the glass partition and made the universal gesture for "time's up" by tapping the watch on his wrist.

Without saying another word, Ed stood up, straightened his tie, patted his hair (for an old man, he had a very full head of hair), and gave me a thumbs-up as he left the holding area to go into the courtroom. With Ed Sigel being the only thing standing between a lengthy prison sentence and me, I knew today was going to be bad.

As feared, the final day—the mitigation phase—of trial was a disaster. Called *mitigation* because it's supposed to lessen the severity of the evidence of my guilt, we called up witnesses who could attest to my character and expert witnesses who could explain the addiction element to my criminal behavior.

However, Judge Snipes made a mockery of the process when he argued with my witnesses. It did not matter if it was an expert witness psychologist or a close friend of mine who once ran for governor of Texas, Snipes was hostile to the point that he was doing the prosecution's job. I wish I could say I was surprised, but he showed his hand all the way back on the search warrant.

When the jury finally got the case, it was lunchtime. After the jury filed out of the courtroom, the bailiff brought me to the holding cell area in the back. Then, he brought me the customary two bologna sandwiches for the inmate lunch.

Being in a trial was a grueling process which made me ravenous. I barely had time to take a big bite out of the first sandwich before the bailiff reappeared. As he unlocked the cell door, he

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said, "Let's go. The jury has made their decision." He did not try to hide the grin on his face.

Immediately, my throat tightened up and the piece of sandwich I was chewing on became stuck in my throat. Anytime a jury deliberates that quickly, it is an awful sign. I spit out the bite of sandwich in the metal toilet and flushed the remainder of it as well. In an instant, fear flooded my body, and my appetite vanished.

Karen was waiting for me at the defense table. She looked as fearful as I felt. Her words confirmed what we both were feeling when she told me to brace myself because it was going to be bad. During the brief fifteen-minute recess, she said the jury had only one question for Judge Snipes: "Can we sentence West to life *without* parole?"

That focused my attention. Life without parole is capital punishment, reserved for crimes where people are killed. "What did Snipes say?" I asked, in return.

"He said, 'You can sentence him to life, but not life without parole.'"

After the jury filed into the courtroom and took their seats. Judge Snipes called the court back into session.

"Mr. Chavez, it is my understanding that the jury has reached a unanimous verdict. Is that correct, sir?"

Chavez was the jury foreman. A young Hispanic man who had watched me for six days with contempt oozing out of his pores. I got it. In front of him was a guy who had it all in life. I came from a great, two-parent home, was a star quarterback, graduated college, and had all the best jobs. Life had been easier for me than most.

"Please stand to receive the verdict," Judge Snipes said, glaring at me.

On wobbly legs, I stood, took a deep breath, and exhaled.

The verdict was read. "We the jury, having unanimously found the defendant guilty of engaging in organized crime as charged in the indictment, assess his punishment at sixty-five years' confinement in the Texas Department of Criminal Justice, and a fine of ten thousand dollars."

Snipes made eye contact with me. A smirk appeared on his face as he said, "The defendant having nothing to say, it is the order of the court that you, Damon West, being judged to be guilty of the offense of organized crime, a felony, in Case Number F09-00248, and whose punishment has been assessed at sixty-five years in the Texas Department of Criminal Justice Institutional Division and a fine of ten thousand dollars, be delivered by the sheriff of Dallas County to the director of the Texas Department of Criminal Justice Institutional Division."

He paused and continued. "You shall be confined for sixty-five years in accordance with the law and governed by the Texas Department of Criminal Justice Institutional Division. Also, Mr. West, you will be eligible for parole in fifteen years."

In Texas, anything over sixty years is a natural life sentence, and the maximum fine you can be assessed is \$10,000. The jury maxed me out on both. Honestly, I was floored. These were property crimes, where no one was ever physically hurt.

Snipes then thanked the jury for performing their civic duty, declared the court to be in recess, and banged the gavel for effect. Everything sped up. The bailiff was on me immediately, handcuffing me and ushering me out of the courtroom. I searched over my shoulder and said to my parents, sitting on the front row, "I'm sorry, Mom."

Then, I exited Criminal District Court Seven through the side door. The door the condemned take. That was the moment I

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knew that something had to change, and that something was me. I was clueless where to begin. Change was going to be a long road.

Reflections

Long before that day in court, I had believed the lie that I still had control over my addictions. I also believed I would not be held accountable for the things I did. Most of the time if you believe a lie, you will find the truth. In my case, the truth found me. Because I handled the adversity that had been brought upon me in a destructive way, both for myself and others, I welcomed in all the adversity that a life sentence promises.

In thinking about what principles should guide my life, I think back to my years of addiction and criminality a lot. I have to in order to help deliver my message to others. I have to think back to a nine-year-old Damon and what advice I would have given him, or the fifteen-year-old making bad choices, or the twenty-year-old squandering opportunity, or the twenty-five-year-old out of control.

I'd tell each of those Damons that living in reality is always better than living in a lie. Be honest, first, with yourself and then, with each other. Practice holding yourself accountable. To do this, start by keeping the promises you make to yourself.

Like my friend, Ed Mylett, says: "You build confidence by keeping the promises you make to yourself."

CHAPTER 4

SERVANT LEADERSHIP

Humility Creates Good Character

September 20, 2022

“If you’re free on a Wednesday night, I need you to come out to a meeting at Unity House. Those guys there are really trying hard, working their programs. Some of them have read your book, too. It would mean a lot if they could hear your recovery journey in person.”

My sponsor in my program of recovery is a guy named “Ray.” As my sponsor, Ray is the person who knows most about me. He’s heard my innermost thoughts, fears, doubts, resentments, and everything else that can hold a person back in life. He’s the person I run everything by so that I can remain sober and work my program of recovery to the fullest. Everyone needs a coach in life. Ray is mine.

The Unity House was an all-male residential rehab center in Beaumont. I had been there a few times to speak in the past, but it had been a while. Many of the men there are either just getting out of prison or trying to avoid going back to prison. It’s a place where everyone is looking for hope.

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“I’m on the road pretty heavy right now, Ray. It’s a busy time of the year on the speaking circuit. Might be a few months before I can get there.”

Ray absorbed this information for a moment. Then he mused, “When you were in your addiction, I bet you were never too busy to meet up at the bar or visit the dope man. Are you sure you don’t have any time to serve these men?”

Ray wasn’t calling me to ask if I was available; he was telling me to go do service work in my local community. He was correct, too. In my addiction, nothing could stop me from getting my next fix. This is how recovery works; we hold each other accountable.

I looked at my calendar with a different viewpoint. “Hey, Ray, I can be there on October fifth. I’m speaking to a company in Lafayette, but it’s only a few hours away. I’ll drive in and meet you.”

“Perfect! The guys will be thrilled. Be there by six o’clock. Oh, and Damon, can you bring some more of your books? I’m out. Need to have more to give away.”

Ray did not play games with recovery. He had been with me all the way back to when I was in prison because he was the guy who brought the meetings into prison. The day I got out I went to my first twelve-step meeting in the free world at his home group. He became my sponsor and the Keep it Simple Group became my home group.

That first day, Ray made me promise I would go to any lengths to stay sober. One of the ways he did that was to push me into service work projects, because serving other people makes us *selfless* instead of *selfish*. In fact, long before I began going around my community sharing my story, he had me going to senior citizen centers on the weekends. I would go to the front desk, ask

for a list of residents who never received visitors, and spend my weekend just listening to people who did not have someone to listen to them anymore.

That service work project taught me a lot about gratitude and humility. Mainly, it taught me that whenever I felt like I was going through something difficult, that was always a good time to help someone else in need. It got me out of my own problems in my head and it allowed me to feel useful.

As much as Ray embodies the concept of servant leadership, as influential as he has been on my life, and as much as he pushed service-work projects on me, he was not the person who introduced me to the concept of serving others. That was another man, named Joe Tortorice.



Joe was a Texas A&M Aggie who moved back to Beaumont after college and opened a sandwich shop in 1976, called Jason's Deli. He began with one store and four employees. By the time I met Joe in prison, through the Kolbe Prison Ministry, Jason's Deli had hundreds of stores and over ten thousand employees. However, Joe didn't measure his success by his accumulation of wealth or his business acumen. He measured his days by how much he could put back into the stream of life, how much he could help others.

Joe's real passion was prison ministry. Every Monday night, Joe would come into Stiles Unit to fellowship with inmates in the Chapel of Hope. I remember thinking: *This guy is a multi-millionaire who owns a private jet. He could be anywhere else in the world, but he chooses to be in prison with us.* During those fellowship sessions, Joe would talk to us inmates about servant leadership.

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When I got out of prison, I looked Joe up. He lived in the town next to where I was living with my parents. I asked for a meeting, and we met up at Jason's Deli in my hometown of Port Arthur. I arrived ten minutes early, thinking I would beat Joe. But he was already there. He was wearing an apron and helping prepare food behind the counter.

Fresh out of prison and wanting to make the most of my second chance in life, I asked Joe if he would be my mentor. Joe smiled, stuck out his hand across the table to shake mine, and said, "It'd be an honor to be your mentor."

I did not understand at the time how it was an honor for him, but I would eventually learn what he meant. Joe took his mentorship seriously and wanted to meet often, which I thought was great. Unsurprisingly, we ate a lot of Jason's Deli during our mentor-mentee meetings, which I also thought was great because I love their food. In one of the earlier meetings, I asked Joe where he learned about servant leadership.

In 1996, Joe said his company exceeded all expectations, having franchises in multiple states and making great profit. Despite the success of Jason's Deli, Joe did not feel like a success, and he did not feel like the culture at Jason's was great. In short, he was in a rut.

As an alumnus of Texas A&M, Joe would get invited to their events. The one he attended in 1996 not only changed his life but also changed the trajectory of Jason's Deli. He said the speaker at the business symposium that day was a guy named David Glass. Joe was excited to hear his presentation because David Glass was the CEO of Walmart, the guy Sam Walton hand-picked to take over when he stepped down.

David Glass spoke about *servant leadership*, an unfamiliar term to Joe. Joe got excited telling me the story. “David Glass said ‘servant leadership was helping other people reach their goals in life; helping to raise other people to a different station in life. When we help other people grow, we grow, too.’ This turned everything I always thought on its ear. I thought servants did the menial tasks while the leader watched them work. I realized I had not been such a great leader after all.”

Joe said he went back to Beaumont, to the corporate office, and told the board about the new direction he wanted to take the company. Better benefits, better wages, and a family culture. Servant leadership would be the company’s new mantra.

Joe said Jason’s Deli was transformed as a result of the change in its mission. On the business side, the company exploded with growth, eventually reaching over three hundred stores. However, on the people side, the growth and transformation were even greater. The stores truly became like a family, so much so that Joe saw employee retention reach levels unheard of in the hospitality and food industry. “We have employees at stores that have been with us for twenty, twenty-five, and thirty-plus years. Imagine that, Damon. People working at a sandwich shop for decades. It’s because we cultivated an atmosphere of servant leadership, where everyone is family, and the standard is to lift each person up.”

Having Joe as a mentor was one of the most important things to happen for me after prison. He invested in my dream to share my story as a speaker, enlisting me to speak at the Jason’s Deli quarterly management meetings. He often said, “If an employee can’t be motivated by your story, then they can’t be motivated.”

In the few years we were together, he taught me so many lessons that took him a lifetime to learn. Unfortunately, on August

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10, 2019, Joe lost his battle with esophageal cancer. It was a devastating blow to countless people. From his family and friends, to the philanthropic world of Southeast Texas, and to all of the men in prison who experienced Joe's love through his life as a servant leader, the world lost one of the greats.

One of the last pictures I have with Joe was at a golf tournament in Beaumont. On our team that day were myself, Joe, my father, and Ray. I captioned the photo on social media as "My Three Dads."



"I appreciate the call, Ray, and the reality check. I'll bring a box of *The Change Agent* as well. Every man will get a copy. Looking forward to sharing with them."

"Hey, no problem. That's what the program is for. We help each other get there. *Spiritual progress, not spiritual perfection.*"

I love Ray. He's the perfect sponsor for me. Because he saw my spiritual awakening from inside prison, he understood the mission I was on and the powerful way my life could be used to help others. However, it was all contingent on keeping my program of recovery in front of everything else. If I ever started to slip on going to meetings, he would call me and ask where I was. That's what it takes with us addicts. We need someone who has been where we've been.

"Keep spreading that coffee bean message. See you soon," Ray said as he hung up.

He's helped me reach my goals in life. His path of servant leadership is one I hope to emulate in every action I do.

Reflections

Ray once told me that “humility is becoming right-sized. Only when we are right-sized can we become useful to ourselves and to other people.”

I was humbled by life. That is when the process began of me going from useless to useful. It did not happen overnight, and I did not do it alone; I had help.

Everyone needs help in life. None of us get where we are going without help. But it must be the correct coach, who truly aligns with where you want to go in life. Each of us has the potential to help at least one person. It is imperative you find that person you can help. Think about it like this. If everyone is looking for that one person to help, then someone out there is looking for you so that they can help you. Give of yourself to others and watch life take off.

CHAPTER 5

BE A COFFEE BEAN

The Power Is Inside You to Change the World Around You

The Backstory: 2009—Leaving County Jail for Prison

From the day Muhammad and I met in South Tower jail, he was both a friend and a mentor. We already made an odd pairing because the code in there dictated that he, a Black man, shouldn't be friends with me. There were other factors, too, that made our friendship unlikely. We came from different Americas. He was older (late fifties) while I was younger (early thirties). He was Muslim and I was Catholic.

It was before my trial when he first approached me. I braced myself, already semi-aware of the separation of races in the jail system, but he disarmed me with the first thing he said: "Word on the street is that one of the guys in this pod is about to cut a deal with the DA. He's gonna tell them you confessed to being the Uptown Burglar."

It did not pay to have a high-profile case because it made you a target for several reasons. I knew about the jailhouse snitches, so I did not discuss my case. Regardless, I did not want this dis-

traction while on trial for my life. That day on the rec yard, as he cut his eyes from one corner to another, looking to see if anyone was watching him, he whispered, “When they serve chow this evening, don’t go to get your tray. Instead, get on the phone and call your attorney. Tell him the inmate’s name who’s running his mouth about lying on you.” He told me the guy’s name and walked off.

That tip not only got the other guy rolled (removed from our pod), it also prevented him from using me as a “get out of jail free” card. I soon stopped checking my periphery to see if Muhammad was a distraction for someone else and eased into more conversations with him.

I remember being blown away by his knowledge of the law and the courts. Intelligence of that level was just not something you typically found in that environment. What began as legal conversations about my impending trial quickly morphed into discussions of other areas of my life. Admittedly, he said he was curious about me because it was not often someone like me—white, middle class, well-educated—ended up looking down the barrel of a life sentence.

“Black folks have always dealt with what you’re going through. The criminal justice system has devoured us for generations. But you? You look and speak like *The Man*,” he said, pausing as if in deep thought. “You need to get ready because *The Man* is coming for you.”

I thought about everything he said before responding. I knew what he meant by *The Man*. *The Man* was the system, society, and all the social factors that keep someone down. The disparities in life were created—often intentionally—by *The Man*. Obviously, with my pedigree, I represented everything about *The Man*.

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I also knew The Man was a useful foil for some. As if reading my thoughts, he said, "So many people waste their lives and opportunities blaming The Man. Look around in here, most of these inmates will live their whole lives blaming The Man, while never addressing their own behaviors or doing anything to help themselves. Perpetual victimhood." Muhammad did not pull any punches, and he was always very thoughtful of the words he chose, which is why I paid attention to everything he said.

"You and I both know I'm guilty of everything in this organized crime indictment. How much time will the jury give me is the real question?"

He thought for a moment. "West, keep in mind you are putting your life in the hands of twelve people who either could not figure a way out of jury duty like everyone else, or they did not *want* to get out of jury duty—my biggest fear. Who wants to sit on a jury for ten dollars an hour, a meal, and a parking pass?"

Of course, we know how the trial turned out. The jury sentenced me to sixty-five years in prison. Life. Muhammad was correct about everything he said.

Immediately after my trial was over, the bailiff escorted me out of the courtroom and put me on the other side of a bullet-proof-glass partition. It was the place where attorneys met with their clients. The place where Ed and I met hours before. The bailiff told me to wait.

Then the courtroom door opened and in walked my parents. They looked terrified. The glass partition between us had tiny holes drilled into it so conversation could be heard.

My mother spoke before I could say anything. "Damon, neither one of us really knows how to process the sentence we heard the judge give you ten minutes ago, nor do we know how to

process all the things we heard about you for the past six days of your trial. That will come later, I believe. They agreed to give us five minutes to speak with you, so we need to talk quickly.”

I’ll never forget her words.

“Debts in life demand to be paid,” she said.

She said the state of Texas had just hit me with a massive bill for a debt I owed society. Since I had done the things they accused me of, I was going to go to prison and pay my debt.

“Do you understand me, Damon?”

“Yes, Mom.”

She told me I hadn’t been paying my debts for a long time now, that I owed an unpaid debt to them. “We raised you with proper morals, and provided you with all the love, opportunities, and support to achieve any goals. Do you understand what I am saying, Damon?”

“Yes, Mom.”

She told me that I could not go to prison and become someone they didn’t recognize. Specifically, I was not to go to prison and get into one of the many white hate gangs because I was scared. I was raised better than to hate. “You’re from Port Arthur, a giant melting pot of a city. Race has never been the lens you were taught to view life through. Don’t start now. Besides, anything you look at through the lens of race will give you a distorted image.”

Moreover, she said, I was not going to prison to sit around. She told me to get on God’s back, let Him carry me, and work on myself. She reminded me I couldn’t do this alone, and that my way of doing things obviously did not work. “Like I told you the first time you called from jail, ‘You are now a captive audience to God.’”

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“Mom, I’m scared.” I started to cry. Then I looked at my father, whose face had regained composure, masking pain, confusion, and rage.

His disappointment was written all over his face.

I am so sorry, Dad.

Now was not the time for an apology. Besides, my apologies rang hollow. Only my actions would speak for me going forward.

My mom said they couldn’t even imagine what kind of hell I was about to go through. She reminded me again that my only option was to do this time with God as my guide.

“You owe us this much. No gangs. Don’t you dare come back with a bunch of swastikas tattooed all over your body. Don’t you dare come back as someone we don’t recognize.”

She made me promise I would come back from this as the man they raised me to be. In fact, she told me not to come back to them at all if I failed to keep my promise.

“I promise, Mom. No gangs, and I will let God carry me.”

When I came back to my cell after my trial, every man in there just stared at me. Of course, they all knew I received a life sentence because the case was high profile enough to be on the news. No one dared approach me. No one except Muhammad.

“West, when I saw they gave you six dimes and a nickel, my heart sank. I’m so sorry, brother,” he said as he gave me a hug.

My eyes began welling up with tears and he gave me a look that said *hold it together*. As we walked to my bunk, he told me to go hit the showers. “You can cry in there because no one will see you.”

As if in a daze, I followed his instructions, got my shower shoes, soap, and towel, then headed straight to the showers. Thankfully, there was no one else in there. As soon as the water

hit my face, I began crying like a baby. Scared and hopeless, I did what so many do in my situation: I began to pray. I asked God to forgive me and to help me. What happened next changed the trajectory of my life.

As a Catholic, I had an image of what I believed Christ looked like. It was that image who appeared to me in the shower to tell me everything was going to be OK. There was no condemnation and no scolding. Just this all-encompassing peaceful feeling and an invitation to get on His back as my mom had told me to do hours earlier outside the courtroom.

The next day, I told Muhammad about my vision, and he assured me it was real. Here he was, a Muslim man, wearing a kufi on his head, confirming that my conversation with Christ was valid. I asked him about that.

“West, you’re in a spiritual realm now. It doesn’t matter who you or I call God. Religion is manmade; spirituality is your conscious connection to what you call God. All that matters is that we believe and that we surrender.”

Over the next few weeks, Muhammad shared many things with me regarding my journey into the belly of the beast that was the Texas Department of Criminal Justice (TDCJ). Especially useful was the conversation he had with me regarding race.

“The Golden Rule you must always remember in there is that prison, as an institution, is all about race. *Race runs everything.*”

He emphasized that this was how the inmates, and everybody else, wanted it. If all the inmates stuck to their own races, there would be less likelihood of racial violence and racial wars.

“West,” he said, “the reality is you might not live through this. Because of your time, you will be subjected to the worst of the worst Texas has to offer.” He reiterated that everyone would hate me because of the way I looked, acted, and spoke.

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“Your life will be very violent initially,” he said somberly. “Physically and mentally, you’ll be going to war. Always remember this. You’ll win some fights, but you’ll lose a lot more than you win. That’s OK. You don’t have to *win* all your fights, but you must *fight* all your fights.”

He told me to never turn down a fight in there, that my life depended on me never backing down. He said the minute I showed any weakness, it would be over for me. They would be like sharks with blood in the water. “When you get knocked down,” he said, “get back up as quickly as you can. Never lay down.”

He said people were going to be coming at me from all directions. “It’ll be all the white gangs first, then the black gangs are coming after you because the white gangs will ask the black gangs to do it.”

I was going against the status quo, he said, and herding me into my proper group—the whites—was going to become a shared mission with just about every gang and race in there. The Mexican gangs might cut me some slack and take a pass if I showed heart. He was clear that I should prepare myself mentally and physically to taste blood from just about everybody there.

“This is going to be awful,” I admitted.

“No doubt. But, West, you can survive it. Others have survived what you’re about to go through. I’ll shoot you straight, though. Most don’t survive to the point they have the autonomy you’re seeking. It’s the toughest environment I’ve ever witnessed,” he said.

He got deadly silent and stared into my eyes. A menacing stare that shook me a bit. Then he whispered, “The strongest man in prison always walks alone.”

The fear in my eyes was palpable. From the look he gave me, I could tell he saw it, too. That’s when he said, “West, let me try

to break it down for you a different way. Imagine we have a pot of boiling water,” he said, holding his hands cupped to appear like a pot. “This pot of boiling water represents the atmosphere in prison. Boiling water, like prison, is hot, and the heat and pressure in both will forever change anything you put into it. I want you to put three things into this boiling water. A carrot, an egg, and a coffee bean. If I put a carrot into a pot of boiling water, what happens to the carrot?”

I answered quickly, “It turns soft, mushy.”

He smiled and said I was correct. A carrot, he said, goes into prison and gets beaten constantly, gets robbed, gets extorted, and he may even be raped or killed. “You don’t want to be the carrot in prison.”

I was holding my breath at his description of the carrot. I breathed out and nodded. “No, being the carrot is not an option.”

“What about the egg?” he asked. “What happens to an egg when you throw it into boiling water?”

Again, I answered quickly. “The egg turns hard, like a hard-boiled egg.”

He nodded, saying the egg went into prison, but didn’t suffer the fate of the carrot. The egg’s hard, outer shell would protect it physically from the heat and the pressure of prison. But on the inside, the egg was just as hard. The egg became *so* hard that it was incapable of giving or receiving love. “The egg gets a bunch of swastikas and other hate-filled graffiti tattooed all over it. Prison is the only place the egg truly feels at home because it is institutionalized.”

“Doesn’t sound like the egg is someone my parents will recognize.”

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“The egg is what your parents made you promise you wouldn’t become. Your debt to pay to them is to avoid becoming the carrot or the egg.”

I was following him perfectly. I asked, “What about the coffee bean?”

“You tell me. What happens to a coffee bean when you put it into boiling water?”

I didn’t have an answer.

He said the coffee bean, the smallest of the three things, small like me, went into the boiling water and turned the water into coffee. “The coffee bean has the power to change the atmosphere inside the pot. The water in the pot becomes coffee.”

He said that if I was going to not only *survive* prison, but *thrive* in there, I’d have to be like the coffee bean. I was going to have to change the atmosphere inside that dark, evil place by being positive in the face of complete and total negativity.

Every person puts out energy in a little environment around them, and energy attracts similar energy. He used the example of a negative person who walked around with a scowl on their face. That person was guaranteed to attract the same type of person. Conversely, a positive person would attract other positive people.

Moreover, opposite energy repels, and a person could ward off potential negative encounters just by remaining positive.

“You’ll either *infect* others around you or you will *affect* them,” he said.

I understood everything he was saying.

He told me I was one of the most positive people he’d ever seen in that environment, which I took as a compliment coming from him. “You’re about to be thrown into that pot of boiling water that is prison. You’re gonna have to go in there with a

smile on your face and a great attitude no matter how painful it gets. No matter what, you can never let them know they're getting to you."

He emphasized that my survival was contingent upon me bringing my positive personal energy in there and changing the atmosphere. It was a task that would not be easy because resistance to my positivity was going to cause me more pain and suffering. "You're gonna be a light that many will want to snuff out. Don't let that happen. Eventually, you'll be left alone, and the other coffee beans in prison will find you because they'll know you by your like-energy."

I thought deeply about everything he said. It made perfect sense to me. In theory, this sounded simple enough. In practice, it was much more difficult.

"What do you see more of in there?"

He answered quickly. "Eggs. Prison is mostly eggs."

Muhammad said being an egg was the natural evolution of most incarcerated people because the energy in there was so thoroughly negative that it demanded the sacrifice of many eggs.

He promised I would see plenty of carrots, too. They were the saddest, most miserable and lost people in there.

"If you want to find the coffee beans," he said, "try looking in the chapel. They'll have their strongest representation in there, mixed in with the charlatans and fanatics."

Then he looked around the pod, cutting his eyes to every corner, and whispered, "The coffee beans will find you, West. They'll be your gang."

He shook my hand and walked away. Muhammad had a way of delivering meaningful points, which often made me do some serious thinking. This coffee bean thing, however, floored me. It

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empowered me, actually. Taking the power away from the world around me—the criminal justice system, the guards, the other inmates—and putting it back in me.

Not too long after he told me about the coffee bean, the guard came by Muhammad's bunk and told him, "Hat on tight." Jail slang that meant he made his bond and was being released. The day he bonded out of jail, he came by my bunk, told me goodbye and said four words as he walked away: "Be a coffee bean!"

Those four empowering words marked the beginning of a long journey.

Reflections

The coffee bean message is about the power inside you to change the world around you. It is the ultimate message that our worlds are created from the inside out, not the outside in. It's important to remember this during the difficult times—the carrot days or the egg days. It's OK to be the carrot sometimes, because feeling sad is a natural human emotion. Likewise with the egg, because you will have egg days where you get mad. Feel your pain because pain demands to be felt. But don't get stuck in your pain. Because you have a third choice—to be a coffee bean and change the world around you with the power inside you.

Once you commit to being a coffee bean, you will discover you have the power to start your days over anytime they get off track. Does not matter what the clock says, restart your day and remind yourself that you have the power to choose your attitude.

CHAPTER 6

NO SUCH THING AS AN OVERNIGHT SUCCESS

Stay the Course

November 12, 2022

In May of 2022, I flew to LA to record a podcast on *The Ed Mylett Show*. It was an incredible episode, and the energy between Ed and I could be felt by the listeners. Honestly, it's the best interview I've ever done. Ed is such a great listener, an incredible communicator, and his vulnerability allows the guests to be equally vulnerable.

That podcast accelerated my message quickly. Thousands of people wrote to me through my website and the various social media platforms. Connecting the coffee bean message to a massive influencer was like serving water from a fire hydrant.

It was also the beginning of my friendship with Ed. Which leads me to today, in Nashville, speaking to the Arete Syndicate, the platform Ed and his business partner—Andy Frisella—created to help business owners and entrepreneurs reach their maximum potential. The stage was set, thousands were in attendance in the arena, and I was the next speaker. Kendell helped me mic up to

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her iPhone and then she went out into the audience so she could record my presentation.

Ed and I were catching up in the green room. He asked me if I had talked to Jon lately. Anytime someone mentions Jon Gordon, a smile comes to my face and my brain is flooded with so many positive thoughts. In this situation, however, Jon's presence was especially dominant as Jon was the connection between Ed and me. He was my best friend, my mentor, and my coauthor. Without Jon, none of this incredible new life is happening.



When I walked out of prison, I knew I wanted to share my story with others, in the hopes that my life could be both a lesson of what not to do as well as a story of perseverance. Knowing that most people would never find themselves facing down a life sentence or living in a maximum-security prison, I had to figure out a way to make my story relatable. With no coaching on how to speak publicly, I used YouTube to watch other speakers work their crafts.

Everyone is a teacher, I would learn. Some people's purpose is to teach us what not to do. As I culled the best examples of what a good presentation looked like, I began to see myself on those bigger stages beyond schools and prisons. However, that vision and my reality were miles apart. Again, so much goes back to the power of belief others have in you. In the beginning, there were two men who made it possible for me to begin telling my story.

Brad Burnett and Marcelo Molino, a judge and a law enforcement officer, respectively, were the first to use their platforms to help me share my message. Without them, it would have taken years to earn the public's trust after all the damage I did to my

reputation. Ironically, their backgrounds were the very reason why they saw the value in me. All too often, they saw young people who needed an intervention to steer them away from the criminal justice system. We all understood the mission: serving those young, at-risk people who needed hope.

As much as the original intent was to be a warning and a message of hope, my story and the message of the coffee bean grew into something bigger than anyone—myself included—could have ever imagined.

It's not entirely different from when a band takes off. One day you are playing to twelve people at a back-yard party, another day you are playing to thousands in a stadium, and in between those days a whole lot happens. Work happens and dedication happens, and development happens, but word-of-mouth also happens. People taking notice also happens. Bigger opportunities happen.

After I spoke to Clemson's football team for the first time, in 2017, Dabo Swinney became my biggest advocate. He was a connector, using his powerful rolodex, calling many head coaches on my behalf. Before I knew it, I was speaking to nearly every team in America. The biggest connection Dabo made for me, however, was the day he introduced to me to Jon Gordon—one of the biggest keynote speakers and authors in America.

It was in August of 2018 when Jon called me out of the blue. He said he had just spoken to Clemson's football team. After the presentation, he was in Dabo's office, talking to the coach. Jon noticed Dabo carried a wooden coffee bean keychain and asked him what it was for. That's when Dabo told Jon how he received it from me prior to my first time speaking to Clemson. He then relayed my story and the message of the coffee bean.

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“Damon,” Jon said, getting straight to the point. “The coffee bean message is powerful. Let’s team up to write a book. We’ll call it *The Coffee Bean*.”

I was stunned. Not what I was expecting at all. Jon Gordon—*The Energy Bus* guy—the person I went to every day on social media for my motivation, just asked me to coauthor a book with him. Fumbling for the correct response, I responded, “Wow! Jon, I’m speechless, humbled that you’re asking me to write this book with you...but the truth is, you don’t need me. You should write the book yourself.”

“That won’t work,” Jon explained. He told me he always listens to what God tells him, and God told him to write this book with me. He said he could immediately envision it when Dabo was telling him about the coffee bean. “Let’s write this book together, Damon. *The world needs the coffee bean message*.”

Silence on my end.

“I’ll split everything with you fifty-fifty,” Jon said, as if I needed extra incentive to write this book with him.

How could I refuse? I could feel that this was a big moment. “I’m in, Jon, and I’m looking forward to learning from you in this process.”

As far as the impact they’ve had on my life, there’s no difference between Brad Burnett, Marcelo Molino, Dabo Swinney and Jon Gordon. All are essential to any success I’ve had in my field since getting out of prison. But in building my brand through constant speaking jobs, through connecting with people, and through living with integrity so that people always knew they were getting a reliable, prepared person to come speak to their organization, people with larger platforms began to be more receptive to me thanks to Jon. Jon Gordon knows what success as a speaker and

author looks like, has experienced it constantly, and he was willing to attach his name to my message. It didn't happen overnight, but it did happen every day and night, gig by gig, brick by brick.

For weeks, Jon and I went back and forth on emails, texts, and phone calls, crafting our book into the perfect fable around the message. Mind you, we had never met each other in person. Yet, we were about to publish a book together. I often wondered about whether someone from Jon's camp ever said to him, *What are you thinking, Jon? This guy is an ex-con. An unknown quantity. You can't tie your brand to him.*

No matter; Jon never flinched. The process of creating our book kept marching on until we turned in our manuscript in the spring of 2019. That's when my advance payment for half of the book arrived in the mail. A check for \$50,000. It was the most money I had *legally* held at one time in my hands.

At this point in my life, I had moved out of my parents' spare bedroom and was living with my then-girlfriend, Kendell. When I showed her the check, she saw the grin on my face and returned the smile back, saying, "I already know what you're going to do with the money. Yes! Go do it. I'm so proud of you, Damon."

Pulling out my phone, I called my father. "Dad, you and Mom at home? I need to drop something off." I knocked on the door ten minutes later and my dad answered. I reached into my pocket and handed him the check from the publisher, saying, "I told y'all I would pay you back."

He looked confused, or rather he knew what I meant but wasn't ready to let himself believe. "For what?" he asked, to make sure.

"For dipping into your retirement to get me lawyers when I went to trial."

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His eyes welled up with tears. My father was not an emotional man, either. He said, “Damon, I never thought we would see this money again, and that was OK. We just wanted the best for you.”

My mom, who by this time was behind him at the door and heard everything, grabbed my hand and pulled me into the house. We all shared a big hug and a good cry. It felt so good to repay that debt to the two people who believed in me when no one else could.

The book hadn’t even hit shelves yet, and Jon had already performed one miracle by making me financially whole with my parents.

When the book finally launched, in the summer of 2019—exactly ten years after I first learned the coffee bean message in a jail cell—it rocketed to the top of so many bestseller lists. It became so popular that it got global publishing deals. Chinese, Spanish, Arabic, French, Italian, and German were a few of the languages it was translated into.

As the book grew in popularity, so did my presence on the speaking circuit. I have never had an agent or belonged to a speaking bureau, so every opportunity was created from this new platform. Being connected to Jon, with the coffee bean message, was like hooking up my little wagon to a rocket ship. The pace and momentum of speaking gigs was extraordinary. Which was fine by me. I had been working for years to get to this spot and felt I was made for the moment.

In January of 2020, *Forbes* listed it as a Top 20 Book...to Crush 2020. The message kept spreading. Then, in March, a global pandemic brought it all to a screeching halt. My final presentations before the shutdown were to the Minnesota Timberwolves and Walmart. I had finally gotten into the NBA and the biggest

employer in America. Now, overnight, it was all gone. No more speaking and no more book signings.

The first few weeks of the pandemic were the worst. Every email I opened was a cancellation notice for a speaking engagement. In a matter of days, more than \$250,000 in future presentations were gone. Like many, I became angry. I moped around for about two weeks and felt sorry for myself. However, I snapped out of my funk and found the opportunity in my adversity.

My opportunity was that the world became a pot of boiling water, and I was sitting on the best message to help people navigate it. But, since no one was meeting in person, I had to find a way to get the message out virtually. Partnering with friends of mine—Lisa and Rex Spain—I began using their Zoom platform to do my presentation virtually. Over the next four months, we must have done more than one hundred presentations. The same presentation I was once charging for, I was now doing for free for anyone who signed up.

Maintaining success isn't an overnight process, either. It may take some time, but if you turn off the stove everything on it will cool down. Same as my success. I had to keep everything on a simmer as best as I could.

A few things happened at the same time. One, I had a purpose. Every day, I woke up and I knew there were people waiting on me to be inspired. Two, I found a way to serve others, which is the best way to be useful. Three, I got in my reps and kept my presentation polished. And finally, my story and message circulated to places it would have never been had I not changed my mindset about the shutdown.

Once July rolled around, and people began moving around in public, the most incredible thing happened. My DMs on all my

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social media platforms and the email through my website began lighting up. People I had shared my message with during those past four months were reaching out to me with the same general request. Their groups, teams, and organizations were starting to dig themselves out of the lockdown, and they needed the coffee bean message.

Even better, they were now offering to hire me to speak. Within a few months, I replaced the lost fees from cancelled contracts in March and my calendar was filled more than ever. My business was saved. It was not lost on me that none of that reversal of fortune would have been possible had I not believed in myself, picked myself up after the pandemic knocked me down, and made the decision to serve others during a time of great need.

In other words, had I not applied the coffee bean message in my own life, my new life would have never happened.

Looking back, Jon's initial phone call, when he told me the world needed the coffee bean message, was eerily prophetic. The entire world was one big pot of boiling water. But Jon and I kept making coffee. We even coauthored another book during the pandemic, called *The Coffee Bean for Kids*.

His mentorship and fingerprints have been all over my life since. My entire life post-prison, and the positive impact I get to have all over the world, is directly related to the belief Jon had in me. I once asked him about his initial decision to write a book with me. Here I was, an ex-con who had only been out of prison for a few years, an unknown quantity with a past track record of making mistakes. "Why did you risk your whole platform, and everything you had built, to attach yourself to me?" I asked.

His answer was simple, yet powerful. "God told me to write the book with you." He said he had a vision immediately of the book cover and that my name was on that cover, so he called me.

Then, he gave me some of the best advice I've ever received. He told me to stay focused on telling my story and spreading the message of the coffee bean, especially when it feels like nothing is happening. Far too often, he said, people don't see results quick enough—everyone wants the overnight success—and then they change their message or their brand. This only confuses people as to what you stand for. Your growth will follow your belief in yourself because other people will not believe in you until you believe in yourself.

Jon told me about a time early in his career, when he was trying to get *The Energy Bus* published. Dozens of publishers turned it down. He bet the farm, so to speak, on this book and he knew it would be great, but no one else saw what he saw. In a last hope, and in a state of resilience that only the most determined know, he cold-called the John Wiley & Sons publishing house and pitched them his manuscript. They agreed to publish the book and the rest is history. *The Energy Bus* has now sold millions of copies worldwide. Of Jon's thirty books he's written, it's the one people know him best for. In fact, he's known as *The Energy Bus Guy*.

"If you will do this, Damon, one day you'll be known as *The Coffee Bean Guy*, and that will be a pretty awesome thing to be."



I told Ed I had called Jon on the way to Nashville. I always call Jon and Kathryn (his wife) and thank them when big moments in my life happen. As we were wrapping up our conversation in the greenroom, he said something to me that hit me like a bolt of lightning. "You're *The One*, Damon."

Ed's overarching message is centered around the idea that in every successful family (success is measured in many ways),

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there was *one* person who came along, and through their grit, hustle, determination, resilience, and hard work, they changed their entire family tree. The One!

Ed was The One in his family. Now, he was telling me I was The One in my family. “Wow! That’s heavy, Ed. I have never seen myself that way but coming from you means so much. Thank you for helping me get to this station in life.”

Ed continued, reminding me I fought hard in prison, fought hard after I got out, and now my life was one of purpose and with meaning. “I know for a fact how hard you fought to get into this room today. Don’t ever stop telling your story.”

The exact same advice Jon gave me.

The producer came in and told me it was time. When I walked out that day, there were thousands of people in the audience. I began with a quote from Ed, saying, “My good friend, Ed Mylett, says, ‘Life doesn’t happen to you; life happens for you.’”

Reflections

There’s no such thing as an overnight success. Nothing important in life will come to you quick or easy. Results take time to measure. Especially, if you’re trying to make big changes in life, you must allow time to grow into your results.

All too often, I see people who give up on their hopes, goals, and dreams because they didn’t get the results they wanted fast enough. In reality, they were probably closer to their dream than they knew. That’s the key, that every step you take toward your goal is one step closer. It may not be a direct path, but it’s one step closer, and along

Damon West

the way, those steps you take can bring you unexpected successes as well.

If you believe in what you're doing, don't give up before the miracle happens.

CHAPTER 7

ANYONE CAN BE A MESSENGER

Listen for Clarity

The Backstory: 2010

When you go to prison, you take a lot of people with you. The victims of your crimes, your family and friends who believed in you, and the taxpayers who fund it. No one goes to prison alone. However, once you're inside the gates and those doors close on your cell, you are completely alone.

That first full year living inside of a level-five maximum-security prison was the hardest of them all. At times, I did not know if I was going to survive. Not just physically, but also emotionally and spiritually. By design, prison is a punishment. It was all the extra adversity—the stuff not on the official brochure—that made it the most formidable training ground on earth.

What *was* on the brochure was the guarantee that, as a lifer, I would live segregated from the rest of the general population. This designation marooned me to a building on the Mark Stiles Unit, called Seven Building. Otherwise known as the Life Sentence Building, Seven Building housed 432 men. While the entire prison held 3,000 men, we were not allowed to interact

with those general-population inmates except for chapel services. This separation of inmates by length of sentence was done so that lifers could get acclimated to prison and, hopefully, get escaping off their minds.

Being a lifer also meant that I was not allowed to have a job in prison. At first glance, this might sound great but in reality, it was terrible. Having a job was one of the best ways to escape the daily monotony of the drama-filled dayrooms. It was also a way to give a person purpose and to fill your day with something besides the thoughts in your head.

The thoughts in your head could either be your salvation or your undoing. A man had to keep his mind busy—or he would go mad. You had to figure out a way to do your time and not let your time do you. Your thinking was everything in there; the prison in your mind was even more oppressive than the physical prison in which you lived.

If two or more people are talking to you at the same time, your brain can kind of tripwire where it sounds like soup, and you can only pick out a few words. But inside of your head, your mind can process all of the voices of doubt, of self-destruction, of hatred, of anger, of grief, and even when they are all shouting at the same time, you can still absorb every word of their message. What a person needs to seek, or to welcome into their life, is a messenger who speaks so that you can listen for clarity, to cut through the noise and help you understand how to turn your life around and live with integrity.

After Muhammad, my first messenger was also my first cellmate in prison: Carlos. A bank robber from San Antonio, Carlos stood about 5'5". He was serving ninety-nine years for attempted capital murder that stemmed from a shootout he got into with

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San Antonio police after a failed bank robbery. Thankfully, no law enforcement officers were killed. Despite the crime that landed him in prison serving life, he was a great guy who was extremely remorseful for the crimes he committed, the victims he created, and the damage he did to his family.

Carlos was like a brother to me as he patiently assisted me in acclimating to prison life. Everything from showing me how to use the toilets (you had to flush as you did your business so that your waste did not sit in the toilet bowl—the toilet was also a place to do your laundry and your dishes after your meals), how to walk (eyes forward and never look in another man's cell because that was window shopping), and how to have situational awareness with all of the predators around you (and they were everywhere).

Early on, Carlos asked me if I was gay. At first this caught me off-guard because I did not know if he was propositioning me. “No, I’m straight. Why are you asking? Are you gay?” I asked back.

“Definitely not! And I would not have cared if you were,” he responded, quickly. However, he told me that there was a very large gay population in prison, especially where the lifers lived. To assist me in understanding the new world in which I resided, he pointed out the men he knew to be gay. It was about 25 percent of our section (a section had forty-eight men). He explained most were harmless, just people trying to live out their lives in their forever homes, since most of the lifers would eventually die in prison of old age. Some of the men were publicly known as couples, while others were more private about their sexuality. But, in prison, nothing was private; everyone knew each other's business. “Give these men the respect and dignity a human deserves. Their

choices have nothing to do with you and most of these men are not a threat to you.”

Listening for clarity isn’t always about elevating yourself above the noise. It can also be a way of protecting yourself. Carlos was serving as a messenger to me, teaching me that what I knew about community and sexuality was going to be very different in prison. He was also teaching me how to guard against people who wanted something from me.

The phrase “*most* of these men” hung in the air. Then he explained that there were sexual predators all around us. These men *were* a threat. Men who would offer me things for “free.” He told me to never accept anything from anyone without paying in some way, as there was no such thing as *free* in prison. *Everything* had a price and was transactional. Often, he warned, the barter they would want was something I would not want to give. I understood exactly what he was saying and, more importantly, what he was not saying.

Carlos warned me about the biggest manipulators and the most toxic men around us: anyone who had a pet mouse. At first, I did not understand how someone who had a pet mouse could be dangerous. That’s when he told me how the inmate got the mouse to obey them and become their pet.

Mice were everywhere in prison. It was not difficult to catch one, either. A common trap was to smear peanut butter in an empty potato chip bag and place that bag on the floor of the cell at night. Once the mouse entered the bag, you could just close the top of the bag, and the mouse could not escape. This allowed the inmate to release the mouse outside the next day.

However, some men kept them as pets. They were the ones who would *break* the mouse. Carlos explained what it meant to

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break a mouse. The inmate who captured the mouse would use the toilet inside the cell as a torture chamber. He would throw the mouse into the toilet and allow it to drown because the mouse's claws could not gain purchase on the metal toilet. Once the mouse was exhausted and finally quit fighting for his life, the inmate would reach into the toilet and "save" the mouse.

"This is where it gets crazy," he said, preparing me for the worst (actually, diabolical would have been a more apropos word). The inmate would then take the soaking, wet, and terrified mouse into a warm embrace, drying the mouse off, letting the mouse smell him, caressing its fur, loving on it, feeding it, telling the mouse "I love you and will protect you," and, finally, giving it a home in an empty peanut butter jar to rest. The mouse was made to feel out of danger, secure.

Then, over the next few days, the inmate would repeat the drowning and saving process. In fact, he would do this to the mouse so much that the tortured mouse would no longer see the inmate as his tormenter; rather, the mouse would see the inmate as its *savior*. Once the inmate broke the mouse, there was no need to keep it in a jar because the mouse would never leave his side. Life became the mouse's cage.

"The vilest of the inmates in here, the manipulators and predators, treat people the same way as the mouse. Stay away from these men. They are toxic," he warned.

I was floored by his description. However, it was not difficult to understand. I listened for clarity and heard Carlos's message loud and clear.

Over time, as I earned my right to exist (through violence, sports, and a fan motor Carlos gave me to beat a potential rapist in the showers), everyone left me alone. I began working on

myself. It was slow going. But, hey, I had a life sentence. Time was on my side. One night, in our cell, I told Carlos I was struggling. "I can't figure out how to be a coffee bean," I confided.

"Why would you want to be a coffee bean?" he asked.

So, for the first time since Muhammad told it to me in county jail, I shared the coffee bean message with another person. Carlos, wowed with the concept, paced around our tiny cell (exactly five steps, from one side to the other). "I really like this coffee bean concept. But you're no coffee bean, and you'll never be a coffee bean."

Immediately, I angrily got into his face. "What do you mean I can't be a coffee bean?"

He laughed at me and explained that I could not be a coffee bean because of the way I think. My problem, he said, was that I thought of prison as a punishment when I should be thinking about prison as an opportunity. My opportunity, he explained, was that I got to work on myself twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week. "You can become the best version of yourself while you're here."

At lights out that night, while the prison was quiet, he peeked his head down from the top bunk and whispered, "What are you prepared to do tomorrow with your opportunity?"

That little dude refused to call prison a punishment and God put him in a cell with me. From that point on, prison changed because my thinking changed.

I woke up every day in that dungeon and began putting in the work to turn my life around. Days became weeks, weeks became months, and months became a year. One day at a time, I began getting a little better. A spiritual awakening was happening inside me, and I could feel the change taking place.

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Carlos was instrumental in teaching me to see the opportunity in adversity. Unfortunately, he failed a drug test for marijuana and was sent to medium custody. That was a huge blow because, at that point, Carlos was my closest ally in prison. I remember laying in my bunk, wondering who my next cellmate would be. It kept me up all night.

Then, Sabur arrived. Sabur was his Muslim name. A Black Muslim man from Dallas, Sabur was my age and was serving a life sentence for robbery.

Sabur loved his cigarettes, weed, and using cell phones—all of which were illegal inside prison. In those days, drugs were everywhere, and you could get just about anything you wanted. Personally, I wanted nothing to do with drugs after the disaster my life turned out to be because of my addictions. In fact, I had been sober since the day SWAT took me down. I jokingly told Sabur I was taken into sobriety at gunpoint.

It was never a big deal to me if my cellmates did drugs, as long as they would take responsibility for anything found in our cell. Just as Carlos agreed to ride his own heat, Sabur did the same. Regardless of his partaking in the underworld of contraband, I loved Sabur; he was also like a brother to me.

In some ways, we were each fascinated by the other. Given my background and the jobs I had had in politics and finance, he would ask me questions or have me tell him stories each night, after lights out. I, on the other hand, would ask him questions about his faith and his race. Since I had never been Muslim or Black, it was a terrific opportunity to learn from someone who lived in those roles.

One day, Sabur came back from the rec yard grinning from ear to ear. “According to ROY, you’re gonna start a free tutoring

program, to teach people how to read and write. You really doing that to get folks ready for the GED Test?”

ROY was prison slang for *Rumor On the Yard*. Sabur always had the latest gossip. Because he was into the prison underworld culture, he had a natural pipeline to the people who usually started the rumors. However, this rumor wasn't a bad one.

“Yeah, I'm opening a free tutoring service. Ever since they took away our ability to work, I figured I could try to create something positive for these guys to fill up their days,” I told him. The atmosphere was becoming increasingly more strained because everyone was bored, with nowhere to go. The dayroom, already a place full of drama, became a cesspool, where agitated inmates boxed each other daily. The only way off the pod was to go to recreation, the law library, the chapel, or the schoolhouse.

“Man, that's genius,” he said. “This place is getting crazy.”

“Exactly. And it also keeps me busy, too. I can only read so many books.” Books were great for many reasons. I never saw a guy reading a book get into a fight and I never saw a fight over a book.

“I need to ask you something. Will you come speak at our Muslim services at the chapel tomorrow?”

Taaleem services were held on Saturday afternoons. It was an opportunity for the Muslims to get together and fellowship. Because so many Muslims controlled the tobacco and drugs in the prison, many people thought they were a state-sanctioned gang (the right to worship and have a place to do it is guaranteed by The State). I never saw them as that, even if I saw many of their members in the *game* (slang for prison underworld activities).

“Brother Sabur, you think they want to hear from a White guy, like me? Besides, I've never really spoken to a group before.”

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“Damon, those guys need to hear about the coffee bean at Taaleem.”

That Taaleem meeting was my first time ever speaking in front of an audience. I found out I was pretty good at it, too. In fact, Sabur brought me back a few more times, until the afternoon when he got arrested (you can go to jail in prison) for possession of a lot of tobacco. A guard walked into our cell right after he got his drop of several cans of Buglers. True to his word, Sabur took responsibility for the tobacco and went to medium custody.

I never worried about who my cellmate would be after Carlos and Sabur. They both taught me so much that I began seeing a pattern to life. God was constantly sending messengers, and He could use any messenger to get through to me. Like Him sending Muhammad to me in county jail, the messengers may not look like me or come from the same background as me. The trick was to be receptive to all the messengers so that I could get all of the messages.

By the end of 2010, I was teaching three men how to read and tutoring one guy in my pod who was taking college literature. I may have even written his term paper on *Old Man and the Sea* (I’m a sucker for Hemingway). It felt good to teach because the purpose of school was to prepare people for independence. Now that I had a purpose and was serving others, I began to get into a groove with doing time.

Teaching, it turned out, was something I did well.

Reflections

My experiences taught me that everyone was a teacher. Some people were put in our paths to teach us how not to do things, while others were there to teach us how to

do things correctly. With an open mind, you can learn something from every person you meet.

Learning from others is also a great way to avoid stepping on proverbial land mines. The knowledge of others can tell us where the land mines are. Like a map, showing where danger, difficulty, failure, misery and adversity are hiding. Land mines are only dangerous if you don't know where they are buried.

Being open and receptive to all people is born from humility. Humility is also the antidote to ignorance. Herbert Spencer, writing in the Big Book of AA, said it best.

*“There is a principle which is a bar against all information, which is proof against all arguments, and which cannot fail to keep a man in everlasting ignorance—that principle is **contempt prior to investigation.**”*

Or, as my sponsor, Ray, says: “The mind is like a parachute. It only works when it's open.”

CHAPTER 8

THE HEALING POWER OF FORGIVENESS

Making Living Amends

February 7, 2023

“Your story is like an onion, Damon. Finding the guy who told you about the coffee bean in county jail is just another neat layer to it. I’m excited to share this with our viewers.”

Kevin Reece, one of the best storytellers in news, met me at Dallas Lincoln High School to cover the latest “layer” to my story. He’s been the guy at WFAA who covered my comeback story over the years. This was kind of ironic, because WFAA was also the station that covered the downfall part of my story.

Kevin and I linked up for the first of many stories a few years ago. It took quite some time for me to get comfortable with the idea of doing that initial story because all my burglary victims lived in Dallas. The last thing I wanted to do was to be in their faces and cause any more negative emotions than my previous bad behaviors created all those years ago. It was going to be the first they had heard from me since I was transported away on a prison bus in 2009.

That initial story, in 2020, had me riddled with anxiety.

As a formerly incarcerated person on parole in Texas, I am prohibited by law from ever contacting or apologizing to the victims of my crimes. It is another felony. Any attempt to apologize—directly, indirectly, through social media, or media interviews—to my victims could send me back to prison. A complete no-go zone for me. No apologies can ever be made. Period.

I am fully on board with Texas's law. In my opinion, the intent of it was aimed at the victims of violent crimes (think: rape, assault, robbery, molestation, murder), so that the victim could move on after such a traumatic *physical experience*. Non-aggravated crimes, like mine, where there are no physically harmed victims, were likely lumped in as a collateral effort to prevent any victim from having to face the person who harmed them.

It also takes the burden of forgiveness out of the hands of the victim. When you apologize, you are asking for forgiveness. It can be granted; it can be denied. But a person who has victimized you, whether physically or not, holds some corrupted version of power over you. If they ask you for forgiveness, it can feel like an obligation to grant that forgiveness, even if the victim isn't ready to move on, ready to grant that forgiveness. Whatever the original intent of the law, I agree with its application.

In my program of recovery, there is already a built-in mechanism for amends that cannot be made because it could cause harm. A *living amends* is what the program calls for. This means you must go out and do good deeds and expect nothing in return. While the person you harmed may never know about the good works you did to help others in exchange for the harm you did them, you know that you are doing your part to make the world a better place.

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In this way, a person can receive the healing power of forgiveness without burdening the person they victimized. It hopefully allows everyone to move on with their lives.

This inability to apologize creates an odd juxtaposition because a news story lacking an apology could come off as someone who is unremorseful or does not own their past behaviors. If people only knew that the Texas Parole Board would never release you *unless* you show remorse and accountability; it is a contingent element to earn parole.

Nevertheless, Kevin was convincing. He assured me the old story of the Uptown Burglar had already been told ad nauseum. The new story—what the former Uptown Burglar was doing now to make a positive impact in the world—was the one he was interested in telling. That was the story, he said, that would show everyone (including the victims) that redemption is possible.

No story of redemption can be told without telling why redemption was necessary. This is where I, ironically, felt comfortable on my footing. For years, I had been telling anyone who would listen that I deserved to go to prison, that I earned my life sentence. In the end, that life sentence was the best thing that ever happened to me. It forced me to change because the sentence was indefinite; TDCJ could have kept me forever.

What finally tipped me over the edge about doing the story, was a conversation with my sponsor in my twelve-step program of recovery. Ray pointed out to me that I had paid for my mistakes with a currency greater than money: time. He told me, “Damon, in the end, you committed a bunch of crimes and you paid a hell of a price. You’ve owned your mistakes and done your time. *Still doing your time* because you’re on parole for the rest of your life. Your side of the street is cleaned. *Other people’s opinions of you are none of your business.*”

That story aired in January of 2020. Kevin did a great job telling all parts of my story. When I heard my voice in the story say, “I was a scumbag; I was a bad guy,” I felt like he did me right because he allowed me to tell the world in my own words that I owned my past. Admittedly, all my fears were unfounded.

Well, almost unfounded.

Following the story, I received two surprise emails. One was from one of the detectives who had taken me down. The tone was mostly skeptical. He clearly did not believe the person he helped take down in 2008 was a changed man in 2020. I sat with his email for a while—why would he bother to write that to me? What did he stand to gain? But I gradually understood that when he was pursuing me, he was representing society. He was letting me know that society, my community in Dallas, did not grant me forgiveness. To him and everyone else, I would have to continue to make living amends and not fixate or even consider whether he noticed or not.

I did not reply to his email. He’s entitled to his opinion. Besides, he had no power over me because I was no longer a criminal.

The other email was from a name I did not recognize. Its subject line said, “Hey, Damon, I forgive you.” When I opened it, the first sentence made my stomach drop, shaking me to the core. It was from the person I had always regarded as the biggest victim of my crime spree.

In July of 2008, Dustin and I broke into an Uptown Dallas condo whose owner was out of town. Like the scumbag addicts we were, we searched her place for anything we could sell or trade for dope. There was a safe in the closet, which we cracked open. In the safe was a diamond ring, which we stole.

Six Dimes and a Nickel

What we did not see was the tri-folded American flag on the wall, the military memorabilia, or the KIA plaque. It turned out that the ring we stole was the engagement ring her fiancé gave her before he deployed to the Iraq War and was killed in action defending our country. We stole her last, and most sacred, memory of him.

I remember her testimony at trial, vividly. It replayed in my head on a constant loop and haunted me the entire time I was in prison serving my life sentence. It was *my* punishment, a pittance compared to the one I caused her. That burden stayed with me all over that maximum-security prison and became like a toxic companion. My constant reminder of the violation I caused my victims that went beyond the property I stole.

I held my breath as I read her words. She poured her heart out about the pain I caused her. I could feel the struggle in her heart as she described the mix of emotions upon seeing that I was out of prison. Tears began welling up in my eyes and I began to tremble as she progressed through the pain and into the healing.

With that, I'd like to say: I forgive you.

I'm moving on in the hope that you're a genuine person with a good heart. In the hope that you put others before money or fame as you share your story. In the hope that you and your family never experience great loss or violation. Most importantly, in the hope that you feel peace in knowing that we are saved from the mistakes we make in this world, thanks to the unfailing love of Christ.

Life is such a gift. May you live it to the fullest, Damon.

The dam burst and the tears were flowing. Part of me felt completely unworthy to receive forgiveness, while another part of me felt so much relief. The person I had violated most forgave me. The selflessness and grace she showed were more than I ever expected to find in life. *Grace*. That ever so difficult-to-attain attribute because *grace always costs the person giving it more than it costs the person who receives it*.

After I composed myself, I did what I had been instructed to do if a victim ever reached out. I forwarded the email to my parole officer, Ms. Braggs. Immediately, I called her and asked her to please check her email.

“Wow! I was not expecting all that. I remember you telling me about her and the ring.”

Quickly, she went into parole officer mode. “West, do not reply to her. I advise you to have no communication at all. Part of your contract with Texas is to not reach out to your victims and absolutely to never make any apologies. Do you understand me, West?”

I did. But I didn’t like it at all. Nevertheless, I always obeyed Ms. Bragg’s orders.

After I hung up with her, I had one more person to call: my sponsor. Ray is a relic, a dinosaur, a throwback to a different era. He still carried a flip phone, so he did not have access to text, and he did not have an email account. So, I read the entire email to him. He, too, was aware of this victim. In the eighth step of the program of recovery, you make a list of all the people you harmed. She was at the top of my list.

“Isn’t that something, Damon. God did for you what you could not do for yourself. That’s the program at work. Keep living with integrity and the rest will work itself out.”

Amen!

Six Dimes and a Nickel



That morning, Kevin and I met up at Dallas Lincoln High School. He was mic'ing me up as we waited for the students to arrive. "I'm grateful it's you who is telling this part of the story," I told him. "Not that our other stories weren't incredible, but this one is incredibly special and personal to me. One of James's sisters is going to be here today."

The *James* I was referring to was James Lynn Baker II, aka Muhammad. The guy who told me the story of the coffee bean all those years ago in Dallas County jail. "Her name is Vetia Smith. She is one of his three living sisters. She's agreed to be interviewed as well."

"How did you finally find him?" Kevin asked.

For years, the most frequent question I had been asked was: *Where is Muhammad now?* My answer was that I could not find him because I did not know his real name. Muhammad was his Muslim name. He was like many people who adopt a Muslim name when they convert to Islam. Like Cassius Clay becoming Muhammad Ali.

After I was released from prison, I called Dallas County jail to see if I could find him. They told me they needed his real name or his birth date, vital information. Which I did not have. At that point, I had to hope he could find me.

Here's how he found me.

In 2022, I received a letter from an inmate in the Texas Department of Criminal Justice. This was not uncommon because I receive a lot of mail from men and women who are incarcerated. My PO Box is always full of correspondence from people on the inside looking for hope from the guy who was once where they were but has shown what is possible. This particular letter was different. It had no return address on it, which definitely stood out. When I opened it, the letter contained only one sentence: *Find James Lynn Baker and you find Muhammad.*

I did a Google search which came up with a few entries of criminal cases out of Dallas. Next, I purchased one of those people-finding subscriptions online and was able to get a more complete picture of his criminal record. It matched everything he told me when we were in County jail together. In and out of prison his entire life, it was evident from the arrests and convictions he was an addict. Like me.

Then, I spotted it. He was in Dallas County jail in 2009, the same time I was there. I immediately called my friend and Dallas attorney, George Milner III, and hired him to get his best private investigator to find my friend. It felt great knowing I was going to finally see my friend again. The man who saved my life with his patience, love, and wisdom in those dark, horrible days after being sentenced to life in prison back in 2009. All we had to do was find his current address.

Sadly, James Lynn Baker II, the man I knew as Muhammad, died in Dallas on May 9, 2017, of an opiate overdose. It was devastating. He never found a program of recovery and he died in his disease of addiction.

Without hesitation, I told George, “Let’s go find his family. I need to honor him somehow. I’m not here today without him. Plus, they need to know about the impact he’s had on the world through me.”

When we found out about his sisters being Dallas Cowboy cheerleaders, we also found out that his mother was a notable figure in the history of Dallas civil rights. In 1948, Bertha Baker, a nurse at Parkland Hospital, opened the first licensed Black day-care (Mason’s Lullaby) in Dallas. She also purchased the abandoned South Dallas Good Samaritan Hospital, in 1951, to establish a boarding house for Black families migrating to Dallas in search of better employment. Called *The Baker Residential Hotel*, that structure is now a city landmark in Dallas.

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I was floored that this was Muhammad's family. The PI found a cell phone number for one of his sisters and reached out to tell them about me. They agreed to speak to me. On a layover in Atlanta's airport, I excitedly called the number and made initial contact with two of his sisters, Vetia and Vanessa. They were blown away, both at my story and the fact that their brother had so much impact on me. They told me about the struggles with James. He was a brilliant man, especially in math, but his addictions always got the best of him. I assured them I understood.

After telling them the few details he shared with me in County jail, I asked the sisters if I could ask them a few questions.

"Who told him about the coffee bean?"

They both felt like it had to be their grandmother.

"Was James raised around White people?" I asked.

This caught them off guard, and one of them asked, "Why would you ask a question like that?"

I responded, "Because the code inside the penitentiary is that race runs everything. The races are not supposed to work together. James actually told me this. Thankfully, James did not subscribe to that way of thinking. You see, he was the one who approached me in jail. He was the one who extended the helping hand to me, a White guy from a completely opposite background than him."

It was Vetia who spoke this time. She told me that when James was a boy, there was a new pastor at their church. The pastor was a White man, with a White family, in predominately Black South Dallas. Other White families followed. Long before James would go to prison and convert to Islam, he grew up in a Black church, worshipping with other races, listening to the gospels from a White preacher.

Damon West

However, it was another story she told that made me see God's hand in all of this. That boarding house their mother opened for Black families migrating to Dallas also became a boarding house for poor White families who could not afford to live in White neighborhoods. The house that James grew up in was also the house that White families lived in. James grew up playing with children from such a diverse background. Unheard of for that neighborhood in Dallas during the '50s and '60s.

A warm feeling came over me as she told me those stories. For I knew that, all those years ago, God had been working on a young James Baker, who would meet a very frightened and desperate Damon West in 2009. It all made perfect sense as to why he saw me for who I was—a person coming in need—as opposed to what I looked like.

I told the sisters I wanted to honor their brother by starting a scholarship in his name. "We'll call it The James Lynn Baker II—Be a Coffee Bean Scholarship. I'll put \$10,000 every year, for the rest of my life, into a trust, for a scholarship in your brother's name. And I would love for your family to independently pick the winner every year. We can start it at his old high school."

Back at Dallas Lincoln High School I concluded, telling Kevin, "And that...is why we are here today. I'm going to tell the seniors that one of them will win his scholarship this year."

Kevin thought about everything I told him, and, after a moment, he told me how proud he was of me for finding my friend and then finding his family to honor him. In his role as a newscaster, Kevin informs the community. He was, at this moment, granting me the healing power of forgiveness, a message he would broadcast.

This doesn't mean everyone should or ever will forgive me. No matter what I do, I am not *owed* that forgiveness. What it does

Six Dimes and a Nickel

mean is that as someone who makes living amends, I must work every day to be a person worthy of that forgiveness, whether it gets granted or not.

“My sponsor is always talking about integrity. He says it’s who you are when no one but God is watching you. When my attorney told me Muhammad had died, I knew the only way to honor him was to find his family,” I said finally to Kevin.

Of all the things that have happened since I was released, this was one of the most memorable. Just as James was an unlikely messenger for me, I too would become an unlikely messenger to the seniors in this audience. I could not ask for their forgiveness, but in my message, I could show how deeply I wanted to make amends.

Reflections

Here’s what I learned about amends. If I harm or wrong someone, I owe them an amends. This is to first allow them to move on from what I did to them. They don’t deserve the harm, but they absolutely deserve my accountability and amends. If they have built up a resentment against me, it is my prayer that my amends can help free them from that.

Second, it is there to allow me to move on from what I did. If I don’t make the amends that I owe, it is very likely I will form a resentment against myself—hate myself for what I did. If this resentment sets in, there is no telling the damage it can cause inside me. Like a poison, it will eat through my soul and erode my serenity.

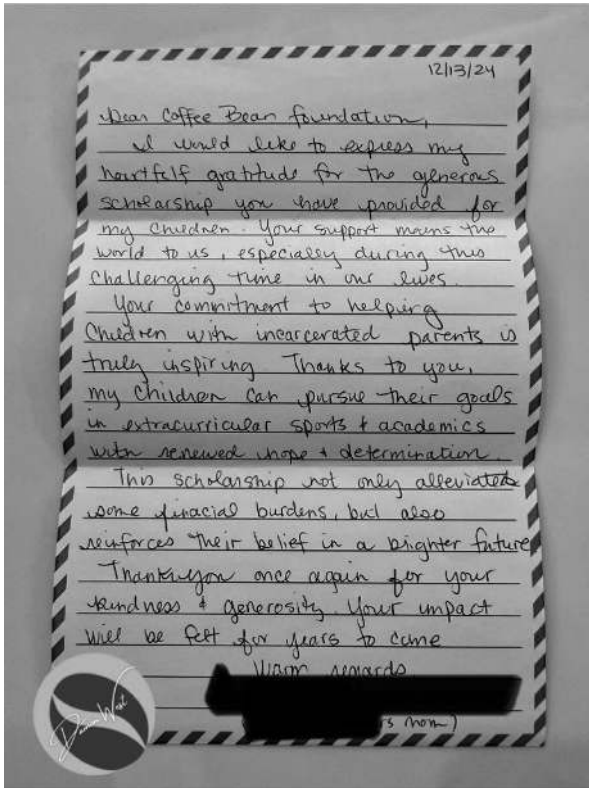
Resentments are like drinking poison and hoping the other person dies. And the opposite of resentment is forgiveness.

Damon West



Lucy Fato and me after my presentation at The House of Lords. The gentleman in the middle is Lord Tim Clement-Jones, our host and a Lord from The House of Lords.

Six Dimes and a Nickel



Letter from a mother, whose two sons are in the Coffee Bean CARES program because the boys' father is currently incarcerated. Her sons were informed of the scholarships from their father, which is helping to repair the parent-child bond.



My mugshot, from July 30, 2008. Photo courtesy of Dallas Police Department.

Damon West



With Coach Nick Saban, in his office, before speaking to the Alabama football team.



With Dabo, in his office, before speaking to the Clemson football team.

Six Dimes and a Nickel



My three dads. From left to right. My father—Bob West, me, “Ray,” and Joe Tortorice.

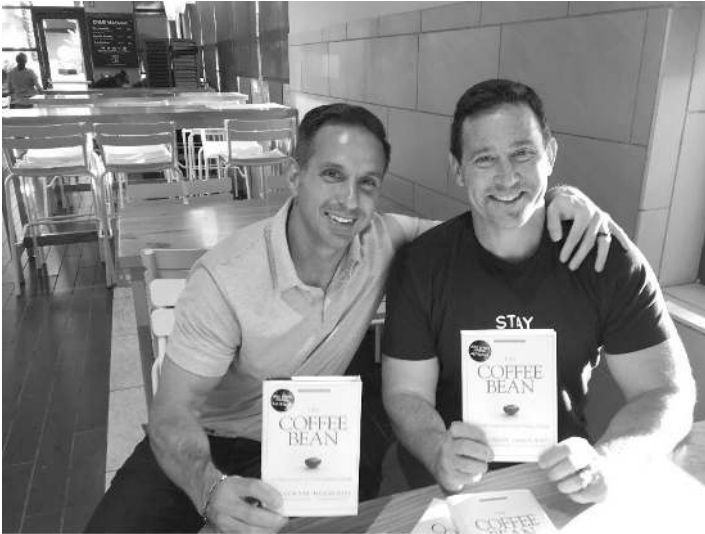


This is Muhammad. When I met him, decades later than this picture, in 2009, he was almost 60 years old. Photo courtesy of the Baker family.

Damon West



My TDCJ prison ID.



Jon Gordon and me in 2019. Right after The Coffee Bean came out. It was the mentoring, coaching, and friendship of Jon who propelled my career further and faster than anyone else.

Six Dimes and a Nickel



How it started. My first presentation after prison. Judge Brad Burnett is seated in the background. He escorted me on that day, in February 2016, to speak to the at-risk youth from Port Neches-Groves High School. In the first few years, most of my speaking-reps were in front of a mirror in my parents' spare bedroom.



How it's going. Today, I speak to audiences all over the world, sharing the message of the coffee bean and using my abilities as a storyteller to entertain, educate, and inspire. Photo courtesy of First United Bank.

Damon West



Ed Mylett and me at his home, in Ponte Vedra Beach, Florida. Ed has become a great friend and mentor, helping me grow as a man and as an entrepreneur.

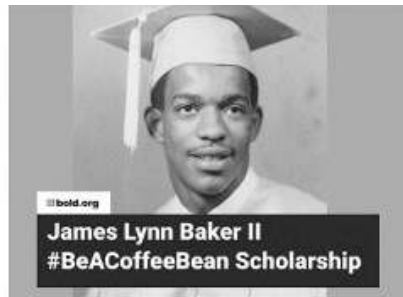


"Carlos" and me at prison visitation. Since my release in 2015, he and I have stayed in touch with regular phone calls and visits. He is, and forever will be, my brother.

Six Dimes and a Nickel



"Sabur" and me after I spoke to a group of currently incarcerated men at the Allred Unit, where he is serving his life-sentence. Like with Carlos, we have remained in touch since my release and he is also my brother for life.



\$10,000

OPEN

1 winner

\$10,000

The \$10,000 annual scholarship for James Lynn Baker II "Muhammad." Each year, I get to fund it and his family picks the winner.

Damon West



Vetia Smith and Vanessa Baker, two of James's sisters. This is from that interview I talked about in the book. You can see the pride they have for their brother, the Original Coffee Bean. Photo courtesy of WFAA.

CHAPTER 9

BUILD YOUR BRAND

Trust, Consistency, and Adding Value Are the Keys

The Backstory: 2011

Without a doubt, 2011 was one of the most pivotal years of my growth in prison. I could finally see where I wanted to go in life because I began to develop my vision of who I would become. I truly believed that, despite my flawed past and the poor choices I made, I could become a good person who was useful to other people. It was like being lost in a forest and finally finding a path out.

Mind you, this path still had me in prison. I couldn't project forward to speaking opportunities or traveling the world. My first steps would be to be useful to the people around me. The path in this case was one that was not heavily traveled because prison was not typically a place where you found positivity and fertile soil in which to grow. But you can bloom where you're planted, and you can create the energy you want to have around you.

When you begin to develop focus on your dream, you will see things that appear to be signs meant just for you. Not only will the right people start appearing, but you will also find the tools

you need for your journey. The tools for my new life were lying around that maximum-security prison, hidden in plain sight. Looking back, I now know my ability to focus was a direct result of my new mindset: prison as an opportunity.

That new mindset came just in time, too. In March, an inmate named David Puckett escaped from the most secure part (the supermax part) of our maximum-security prison. This triggered a lockdown which lasted over a month. It was my first experience of being locked in a cell for so long. I found out quickly that the walls have a way of closing in on you if you allow them. However, I chose to push back against the oppressive confinement and used the time as an opportunity to begin journaling. That journal would eventually become the basis for my book *The Change Agent*. With the chance to collect my thoughts on where I had been and where I wanted to go, I began writing down my goals and what I wanted to do with my life.

As you can imagine, this took a lot of imagination from inside of a maximum-security dungeon. However, I believed in myself, and I knew the power of belief is real. Had I not accomplished big goals in my past once I set my mind to it?

Still, despite my belief in me, I was dreaming in a place that ate dreams for breakfast. There was no place I had ever been that was more seemingly hopeless than living with the lifers. I was being a coffee bean, but some days it was difficult.

Until it wasn't.

If the power of belief in yourself is great, then the power that comes from others believing in you is even greater. This was certainly true in my case when one of my favorite teachers wrote to me that year in prison. Mr. Jehlen was my seventh-grade Texas History teacher. He was the teacher who first made learning fun.

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My time around him left a mark on me that would last forever. That's why I was so excited when I received his letter one night at mail call. In it, he reminded me of my ability to always bounce back, that I was a leader who could do anything I set my mind to. In that letter, he said those four words that we usually hear from a teacher, coach or parent: *I believe in you.*

Those four words gave me the jolt I needed. But there was something else in the letter I was desperately longing for: purpose. Mr. Jehlen suggested I share my story with others when I got out of prison, that my story could deliver hope to the hopeless. The old me would have rolled his eyes at that suggestion. *Of course, Mr. Jehlen. Once I'm out in sixty-five years I'll share my message far and wide.* But with my new outlook, I saw the hope that Mr. Jehlen had for me, and that hope bloomed and multiplied inside of me. For the next month, I brought that letter with me all over the prison. I even slept with it. It was my motivation and my roadmap to a redeemed life. The document that held the blueprint for turning my biggest liability into my greatest asset.

Now that I understood the mission, it was time for an honest reflection. What would my story be about? My journey at that point wasn't very inspiring. A guy who had it all, threw it all away for drugs and crime, got sentenced to life in prison. That was my brand. See that on a supermarket shelf and everyone will put a different one in their cart.

But if that was what I had to work with, then...what?

That *what* became the focus of my existence. What were the next chapters of my life going to look like? What impact could I make each day in prison? What kind of comeback story could I write with this time on my hands? How could I change my brand

and become the sort of person that positively influences those around him?

At this point in my sentence, I was already getting up every day and creating positive change as a coffee bean. I had developed some rules of being a coffee bean that I would check off each day. Rules like:

1. Using positive body language as a tool by always smiling.
2. Working out each day, spiritually, mentally, and physically.
3. Practicing servant leadership by helping raise other people around me to a different station in their life, especially through tutoring.

It occurred to me that I would have to up my game if I was going to inspire people once I got out, whenever that might be. That was the rub, too. I had just started serving a life sentence and my first opportunity for parole would not be until 2015. Realistically, few people with a life sentence made parole on their first try. Mentally, I had been telling myself I would pull at least a dime (ten years) on my sentence before I made parole. That would be sometime in 2018. Well, that gave me seven more years to become the greatest comeback story ever. The keys, I would discover, were living in the moment and working a program of recovery.

There was an inmate I met in prison who was a former Army ranger. In fact, everyone called him *Ranger*. This guy walked around impervious to the chaos and negativity around him. He was unshakable. When I saw him at chapel, I would always marvel at his composure and his attitude. I wanted what he had, so one day I asked him about it.

Six Dimes and a Nickel

“Hey, Ranger. How do you do that? How do you not allow anything to bother you?”

“I live in the moment,” he replied, abruptly.

Living in the moment, he explained, was being focused on whatever task was at hand, in whatever place you were in. When he went to breakfast in the chow hall, he was focused on getting through breakfast. Same thing with anything else throughout his day, like the rec yard or spending time in the dayroom. “Be where your feet are,” he explained.

The problem for so many people doing time, he went on, was that they were still trying to live in the free world. That drives people insane because they have no control over what happens out there. “Once you realize the free world is dead to you, and you fully immerse yourself into this world of prison, then you can live in each moment in here.”

It sounded good. Had I not been guilty of fantasizing about the free world? Those thoughts of the free world brought me hope. I asked him about this, using the character Andy Dufresne, from *The Shawshank Redemption*, as my example (every man in prison has seen *Shawshank*). Andy survived nineteen years in prison because he could envision himself on that beach, in Zihuatanejo, Mexico.

He thought about that for a second, and said, “West, this ain’t a movie. I’m not going to tell you hope is a dangerous thing. All I’m saying is you need to keep your hope in things that are obtainable, real.”

Ranger was what I would describe as pragmatic, like myself. He was trying not to echo the remarks of Red, from *Shawshank*, but his words sounded awfully close.

Hope—something every human being must have to not only survive but also thrive in life. Without it, the world becomes a dark and negative place, where fear is the only voice you hear and existence becomes the goal each day.

Ranger added, “You’re one of the lucky lifers, who actually sees parole this decade. Most of these guys’ parole officers’ parents haven’t even met yet.”

Wow! That really put it into perspective. The overwhelming majority of the lifers had to wait thirty calendar years before their first parole. I was one of the lucky ones because my crimes were non-aggravated, which meant there was no physical victim or violence. This put me in the very small percentage of lifers who become eligible for parole in less than ten years.

“Fair point. I get it, too. I’m sure I would find it more difficult to have a positive outlook if I was an aggravated lifer. I’d like to think I’d still be positive, though.”

“Why are you so positive all the time? How are you always smiling?”

I told Ranger about the coffee bean. He totally got it, too, as he was someone who kept a level head amid all the chaos. Everyone, even the carrots and eggs, understood the allegory.

“What keeps you going, Ranger?”

His answer caught me off guard because I figured he was going to tell me about another tactical tool he got from Ranger School. “Alcoholics Anonymous. That’s my program of recovery.”

A few of the guys who lived on my building went to those meetings on Wednesdays, so I was peripherally familiar with the class he was talking about. I shrugged and told him, “I dealt with addiction to drugs and alcohol years ago, but I’ve been clean and sober since the day I was arrested in 2008.”

Six Dimes and a Nickel

He chuckled, and said, “Yeah, I used to feel the same way about my addiction issues after my arrest and incarceration. Then, I got here, and the thoughts and cravings began. That’s when I knew I needed some help.”

I knew what he was talking about. Drugs and homemade wine (called hooch) were all over the place in prison. It never really bothered me though because I was done with that life. I was curious about something, so I asked, “How do you know if you’re an addict?”

“That’s easy. If you think about using, then you’re an addict.”

Well, I didn’t have that problem. The only thoughts I had about drugs or alcohol was that I was done after the destruction it caused in my life. We shook hands and went our separate ways.

That night, while I was lying in my bunk and reading my Bible, my cellmate, a Muslim guy named Malik, was doing his normal ritual of snorting cocaine and tweaking out. Malik was a good guy, and he was in the best physical shape of anyone I had met in prison. In those days, he just couldn’t resist coke. He was a low-level dealer who only sold enough to pay for his own habit.

I can tell you exactly what I was reading. It was the book of James. One of the shortest in the Bible, but one of my favorites because Jesus’s brother sounded a lot like him; it reminded me of the Gospels. Looking across my bunk, I could see Malik’s tray of cocaine and the rolled-up piece of paper he used as a straw. Then, the thought came like a thief in the night, ready to steal everything I had been trying to rebuild.

Do some coke, Damon. You used to love doing blow. Just one rail, for old time’s sake.

I sat straight up in my bunk. Where had that come from? Was it because of the conversation with Ranger that morning? I

realized I was sweating, and my breathing was off. As I tried to calm myself down and lay back down in my bunk, the thought occurred to me that living with Malik was a ticking time bomb. The problem was that this wasn't the Ritz Carlton. You can't just change cells if you don't like your cellmate.

After barely sleeping that night, I darted out of the cell for the rec yard in the morning. Ranger was outside doing his jumping jacks and push-ups. "I need to talk to you," I told him.

"Last night, something happened to me that has not happened in years. I had cravings for Malik's cocaine. Ranger, I'm still thinking about it today."

He stopped mid-push-up and hopped up. He shook my hand and said, "You're one of us: an addict. The good news is the solution to your problem is within your grasp. Come to an AA meeting with me. It's a way of living with all addictions, a new way of thinking. Actually, it would go together well with your coffee bean mindset."

The next week, I attended my first meeting. It was a group that met every Wednesday in the Chapel of Hope. Named The Spiritual Awakening of Sober Offenders, that program of recovery I began working in prison became the missing element for me to begin authoring my comeback story.

All it required was me finally abandoning the idea I had control over my addictions and becoming willing to live my life each day, guided by the four spiritual principles—*unselfishness, honesty, purity, and love*. If my thoughts and my actions did not line up with those four spiritual principles, then they were on the other side of the principles, the side where nothing good derived from. *Selfishness, self-seeking, self-want, self-desire, and self-delusion*.

Six Dimes and a Nickel

From that point on, I was on fire. Whether it was my parents, a warden, an officer, a chaplain volunteer, or the other inmates, people began seeing the brand I was building. More and more frequently, I began hearing that all-confirming comment: “You’re different. You don’t fit in here.”

What happened to me inside that maximum-security prison can only be described as a spiritual awakening. I do not think human beings are capable, on their own, of making the kind of changes I made. There must be a spiritual element to become the best versions of ourselves. For it is when we live in that spiritual realm that we can tap into another dimension of purpose.

By the time I got out and was ready to prove the Mr. Jehlens of my life correct, to believe in me, I would completely revamp my brand. I may not be everybody’s choice, but in that dungeon, I surrendered and turned myself into the sort of person that people were willing to take a chance on.

Reflections

You are a brand! And everything you do in life builds your brand. The question is, are you a good brand or a bad brand? I have, obviously, been both. So that tells you that if your brand is not where it needs to be right now, you can absolutely change it.

If you were to ask the people who were around me in prison, they would tell you I am the same person today that I was then. That’s because I understood my mission, as this is key to effective branding.

Damon West

Here are a few other keys you will need to build your brand.

1. *Focus on the mission.*
2. *Be authentic—be you.*
3. *Tell a story. No one else has your story.*
4. *Be consistent across all channels so people can interact with you.*
5. *Be prepared to fail. Failure is a teacher.*
6. *Create positive impact. This adds value to everyone and to you.*
7. *Believe in yourself!*

Lastly, never miss an opportunity to tell someone else you believe in them.

CHAPTER 10

YOU'RE MOST QUALIFIED TO HELP THE PERSON YOU ONCE WERE

Self-Reliance is Key

March 13, 2023

“Mr. Prescott, thank you for what you’re doing today. These men will truly be blessed by your presence and your message.”

That is what Director Carter said to Dallas Cowboys quarterback Dak Prescott. I stood next to him, amazed to be a part of this moment. Dak Prescott and I are friends, both quarterbacks (granted, I was very much a former QB...) and we were both there to share a positive message. We also both had limitless respect for Director Carter and his mission.

Director Carter is the director of the Chaplaincy and Volunteer Services Division (CVSD) in the Texas Department of Criminal Justice (TDCJ). His title meant he was over all the chapel programs in TDCJ. The biggest agency in the Texas state government—with over thirty-five thousand employees, in one hundred prisons, which housed 135,000 offenders serving their sentences—TDCJ is a massive operation. Not counting the Federal

Bureau of Prisons, TDCJ was one of the largest prison systems in America.

An operation that massive requires incredible leadership, which TDCJ had plenty of. The culture was created from the very top, by Director Bryan Collier. Under his guidance, the agency became one of the most progressive prison systems in America. Which surprises some people to learn because there are a lot of negative stereotypes regarding Texas. Every department in TDCJ was led by a division director who shared his vision and understood the mission: “provide public safety, promote positive change in offender behavior, reintegrate offenders into society, and assist victims of crime.”

Director Carter and I go way back. He was my final warden while I was serving life on the Stiles Unit. Out of habit, endearment, and respect for the relationship with which we began our journey together, I still privately refer to him as *Warden Carter*. He believed in me while I was in prison, and he believed in me after prison, becoming one of my biggest advocates in that big agency.

With his guidance, I was able to launch a curriculum in TDCJ—The Change Agent Prison Curriculum—that teaches incarcerated men to use the principles I use in my own life. As someone who was once where they are, I had a unique currency to spend with them.

Every four months, on the Wynne Prison Unit, we graduated a class of thirty-five men who completed the twenty-lesson course. Director Carter allowed me to design the graduation ceremonies. This included bringing in a guest speaker. I always tried to bring in someone the incarcerated men would recognize, so that they could see the belief in me that others have, and realize that one

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day, if they live by our shared principles, people will believe in them, too. On this date, my good friend Dak was the speaker.

For context, it's unprecedented that a starting QB for the Dallas Cowboys has ever entered a maximum-security prison in Texas. There were lots of conversations with people connected to the Cowboys to ensure that everyone felt comfortable with the visit. For Dak's part, it did not surprise me that he agreed to do it; he is always using his platform in life to help other people. He's a true servant leader.

In my second chance at life, I always prayed for opportunities to serve, so I did not question when they appeared. However, creating a prison curriculum was not something I would have ever thought of on my own, nor did I honestly feel qualified to do it.



There's a reason why the announcement before a flight tells you to put the oxygen mask on yourself before you put it on someone else. You must take care of yourself first before you can take care of anyone else.

Before finding recovery in prison, all my attempts to change were half-hearted and doomed to failure. It's not like I never knew I had a problem with alcohol and drugs, it's just that I was powerless to do anything about it. Like so many others who struggle with some form of addiction, I never treated the cause or the true nature of the defects of my character which made me want to put chemicals in. Instead, I would treat the symptoms, which always left me spiritually bankrupt.

There was a brief window of my life where I quit using drugs when I moved to Washington, DC, to work in the US Congress, back in 2000. At the time, I was fleeing a massive cocaine addic-

tion in Dallas, and I truly believed that changing cities and the people around me would “fix” my addiction problems.

But, wherever you go, there you are. You always take you with you. My move proved to be a Band-Aid on a broken leg. Still a raging alcoholic, who drank daily in DC, I eventually found a cocaine connection and was back figuring out how to pay my bills. In 2003, I moved to Austin to flee my habit once more. And, once more, I found myself snorting coke at after-parties in a capital city; this time, it was Texas’s capital.

Then, of course, came the meth. You already know how that story ended. I would never be a “functioning addict” again.

Once I found that program of recovery in prison, it made me see addiction differently. I understood the power of peers around you, who could help you become a better version of you, despite your past failures and mistakes. The men who attended the Wednesday meeting at the Stiles Unit, of The Spiritual Awakening of Sober Offenders, got through to me in a way that nothing else ever had before. They had been where I had been, and now they were showing me the way to serenity and a life where I could again be useful to others.

Still, however much I relied on the help of others to work my recovery, the person I needed to rely upon most was, and remains, myself. Only I can make my choices, only I am able to dig down to the poisoned seeds of my addiction and dig them out so that I can thrive and be able to start helping others rely on themselves to thrive as well.

That spiritual awakening inside of a dungeon is what allowed me to become the Face of Hope for others who are stuck inside

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of a seemingly hopeless world. Truth be told, it is a requirement in my program of recovery (the twelfth step) to help others who are struggling. Every morning, I pray to God for the same two things I prayed for each day in prison: *God, put in front of me what You need me to do today for You. And let me recognize it when I see it. Amen!*

In 2021, that prayer was presented to me in the form of Carmella Jones, a member of the Texas Board of Pardons and Parole. She suggested I develop a curriculum for inmates in Texas prisons because she believed I was the most qualified person to help incarcerated men and women become the best versions of themselves. By changing the way they think, with the principles in which I lived my life, my class could become a public safety priority if it could help reduce recidivism and positively transform prison culture, making it safer for both the incarcerated and the staff.

The mindset it takes to pull something like this off is not to think that you can “fix” someone or “change” someone. It’s more that with my rich history of terrible choices, combined with the growing evidence that I had turned my life around, I could help teach them the skills they would need to become more self-reliant. I can’t stop a person from drinking, from drugs, from violence, but I can help them develop a mindset in which they stop themselves. Admittedly, I did not feel qualified to create a curriculum. I didn’t even know where to begin, but Carmella was not someone who accepted excuses when she knew you could do it.

Thankfully, I knew a few brilliant curriculum writers. Lisa and Rex Spain were accustomed to creating curriculums for secondary schools in Texas. When I approached them, they were intrigued. There was no sugarcoating it, though. We would shoul-

der all the costs for this pilot program, and the time spent creating it would be a massive investment. "It's possible we will lose money on this. In fact, it's probable," I told them.

In the end, we all agreed we were standing on the doorstep of something special. This was a program that could change futures, by altering family trees who have experienced the curse of generational incarceration. On an even more existential plane, it could potentially save lives by changing someone's criminal mindset.

With our team assembled, we met with Director Carter and Carmella to get their blessings. They liked our proposal and even agreed to my request to have the class peer-led. "When I was in prison, there was always a barrier for some men to take advice or teaching from someone who was not an inmate. I believe this class needs to be taught by another inmate whom we train. Think about how strong that will be. A class created by a former inmate and taught by a current inmate. I don't know if it's ever been done before, but I know it will work," I explained, needlessly, because everyone concurred.

Next, we began creating our lessons. Because so many of the principles in my life were based on a twelve-step program of recovery, we started there. In no time, we had created twenty lessons. The only sticking point was the lesson on spirituality. Wanting to have this curriculum be accepted throughout the state, the laws regarding separation of church became an obstacle. We had to figure out a way around it. "Without a spiritual awakening, I don't believe human beings are capable of making the kind of changes realized in my life. It is critically important we have a lesson on the *spiritual workout*," I told the team.

We found a solution in how the twelve steps addressed this very issue. The founders of Alcoholics Anonymous realized that

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if you use the word *God*, then you could potentially alienate the alcoholic men and women who were not religious. Treating the alcoholics suffering from their addiction was more important. Besides, AA was about awakening people, not converting them. Their solution was to allow each person to choose their own Higher Power, then have that person turn their will and their lives over to that power, which was greater than they are, because they were powerless to stop drinking on their own.

“I am a Catholic,” I explained to the team. “My Higher Power is Christ. What I have seen, both in prison and out, is that so many addicts are not Christians. However, we all stay sober together in the program by respecting each other’s right to choose their Higher Power. I’ve seen people choose all kinds of things as their Higher Powers and never questioned it because they are sober. I believe this will work for our curriculum. We need to give the participants the freedom to choose their Higher Power.”

With that, the solution was simple. In the chapter on the spiritual workout, there was a line that said, “My Higher Power is _____” Once written in, the inmate could then turn their thoughts and their actions over to their Higher Power and get to work on that critical spiritual component.

Beyond the curriculum, Director Carter and his team gave me a lot of autonomy in creating the graduation ceremony. Being a former inmate, I knew what I would want if I were graduating from a class in prison. First, we would have all the graduates in caps and gowns. Many of these men had never worn a cap and gown. I wanted them to feel the weight of that success on their bodies.

Next, I requested that each man graduating be granted a special visit for that day, so they could invite their families to see

them succeeding. From my own experience, I know that I locked up my whole family when I committed the crimes that sent me to prison. The families of incarcerated individuals have seen all of the negative moments. I wanted them to be able to see this very positive moment.

While we were talking about witnessing success, I asked for, and was granted, the next cohort of men taking the class to be present at the graduation of their peers. They would sit across the aisle from them in the chapel where the graduation was held. I wanted those incoming participants to see what success looked like. To see what they, too, could have if they committed themselves to four months of a new way of thinking.

It was our colleague Brodie Townley, however, who had one of the coolest ideas. “When each graduate’s name is called out, let’s have a future student also stand, and then the two men meet in the aisle. The graduate will then handoff to the newcomer the workbook for the next class.”

“Oh my God! That’s brilliant,” I exclaimed. He was recreating a scene common on every prison unit in America: *the handoff*. Only, in prison the handoff is almost always something negative—drugs, weapons, a note with nefarious information and instructions. This handoff would be the opposite. One inmate would be passing the knowledge, the roadmap, to the other inmate.

Lastly, I wanted to cater a nice meal for the graduates, their families, the correctional staff, and the future students—knowing full well this would be an additional cost. Because good food, from the free world, is a motivator in prison, I wanted everyone there to understand that this was truly a celebration.

We graduated our first class in June of 2022. The graduates sat in their caps and gowns while their families and the other

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inmates watched them accept their certificates. Our speaker that day was Lunda Wells, the tight ends coach for the Dallas Cowboys. Carmella was there, as were Director Carter and so many from TDCJ. I cried like a baby when Carmella hugged me and said, “But, God! I’m so proud of you, Damon.”

I looked out at the first group to go through the program, and I felt immense pride in what they had accomplished. Finally, some of them were taking the first positive steps in their lives that they had taken in a very long time. I also felt pride because the program started out bigger than me and here were living pieces of evidence that it would continue to be bigger than any one person. Each one of the men graduating that day had the skills now to help themselves get through the challenges in life.

Honestly, I also felt proud of myself. The Damon of the past was someone who used and someone who took. The Damon of today, with the support and love of so many others, was the most qualified to help make sure the Damon of the past stayed in the past.



Dak was incredible when he spoke at graduation that day. He poured his heart out to those men with a speech he clearly worked hard on. As a special treat, the Dallas Cowboys provided us with autographed pictures of Dak. This was a compromise to keep one hundred inmates from rushing up to their franchise QB wanting an autograph. I was standing next to Dak in the receiving line when one of the graduates came up, received his diploma and his signed picture, shook Dak’s hand, stood up straight, and said, “Thank you. Mr. Prescott, for caring enough to come see us today. And thank you for this picture. I’m going to send it home

to my son. I've never been able to do anything for him since I came to prison. Today, you gave me the ability to be a great father and give him this gift."

I gasped as I tried, unsuccessfully, to hold back my tears. Dak's eyes began watering too.

Before leaving that day, I had a few minutes with Director Carter. We both took a deep breath and relaxed. Not just because of the enormous feat of having the starting QB for the Dallas Cowboys inside a Texas prison. No, that was on the surface. Our collective exhale was more than that. We both knew that what we witnessed was growth.

It was the realization that so many different stakeholders—a formerly incarcerated person, his former warden, the parole board that owns that formerly incarcerated person until 2073, the class participants, and the families of the incarcerated class participants—could work across that natural gulf between them all to create something with the potential to impact generations and change lives. It was truly something to marvel. We were finally living in the solution, instead of living in the problem.

Reflections

Ed Mylett said to me on his podcast, "You're most qualified to help the person you once were. These things that you think disqualify you are actually the great qualifiers so that you can change your own life and the lives of others."

It's one of the most profound things I've ever heard. It means that no matter what has happened in your past, none of it is wasted. There will always be someone out

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there who needs to hear how you navigated your adversity so that they can get to the other side of theirs.

If we all went out in life looking for the people we once were, found them, and gave them our example, what kind of world would that be? This is true in every facet of life. Our pasts are simply our lessons, which we learn from and teach other people with.

While we are out there looking for others to help, do not forget to take care of yourself. Too often, we neglect self-care and self-love. Leaders and team-players, especially, do this when they let themselves go (physically, emotionally and spiritually) in pursuit of their team goals. You can't take care of anyone else if you don't take care of yourself.

Lastly, I do not speak for Alcoholics Anonymous. It is simply the twelve-step program in which I work.

CHAPTER 11

VOLUNTARY ADVERSITY

Do Things You're Afraid of, So You Can Do Things You're Afraid Of

The Backstory: 2012

For me, 2012 was the year prison got real. I received notice that the appeal on my case was denied. I would not be returning to court, meaning my life sentence was permanent. On the part of prison where I lived—with the lifers—this was the reality nearly every man faced. For the majority of the men who had aggravated life sentences, it was the day they realized their life sentence effectively became a death sentence.

That day would begin like any other, giving no warning that your hope would be ripped away. First, a notice would come for you to go the mailroom. However, this notice would say *Legal Mail*, which was usually not good. On the life-sentence building, legal mail often meant divorce, formally losing custody of your kids, or news from the courts regarding your case. Since I had never been married and had no children, I knew it was my appeal; I just did not know what the letter would say.

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When I opened the letter and saw *Texas vs. West*, I held my breath as I processed the news my appeal was denied, and my sentence was final. It said my sentence would expire on July 30, 2073. I was pretty sure I would expire before that date.

The old me would have been defeated, while the new me began exploring my contingency plans, of which there was only one: file a writ of habeas corpus. The writ of habeas corpus is your last opportunity to fight your case and can only be filed once you have lost all of your appeals. If you lose in the courts on your writ, there is no other avenue out through the courts.

Besides having a lousy set of facts because I was guilty of everything I had been convicted of, there was one other obstacle in front of me—I had no money with which to hire an attorney for my writ. When I say I had no money, what I mean is that my family had no more money to spend on my legal defense, having already spent \$50,000 of their retirement on my case. This left me with two options: hire one of the jailhouse lawyers to write my writ or write it myself. Neither option held much promise of freedom. Pay some guy coffee, stamps, and pastries to get me out of prison or bet on me?

I had never written anything legal before and had no training in the law. Not to mention, I was scared to death because my life, literally, was on the line. That's when help arrived from an unlikely source.

One of the most interesting characters I met during my incarceration was a mobster from Dallas, named Jerry Thomas "JT" Goad. JT was old, bald, small in stature, with those caramel-colored, tinted glasses you see from 1970s-era casino mobster movies. Those glasses fit him well, because he was a mobster from the 1950s to 1970s era. He walked with a limp and had

a cool stride that you only see with the most confident of men in prison, as if he owned the place. Blacks, Whites, Hispanics—everyone gave this guy respect. I once heard him tell a gaggle of Crips and Bloods who were about to fight to go sit down and shut up, that they didn't even know what being a real gangster meant. They listened to him, too, because his reputation on the streets was ruthless.

When I first met him in prison, he had since given his life to Christ. Unlike the phonies who carried their Bibles and pretended to be good people (I referred to them as *hypoChristians*), JT practiced what he preached.

I regularly went by his cell to pick his brain about life. Not just prison life, but out-in-the-free-world life. The guy had seen a lot in his time. If he is to be believed, he had a pretty good idea who was really behind the assassination of John F. Kennedy because he knew the *exact* person who told Jack Ruby to kill Oswald. Not to mention, he told me he talked to Charles Harrelson (one of the alleged assassins and the actor Woody Harrelson's father), in Dallas, on November 21, 1963.

In 2012, I went to JT and told him I needed to pick his brain about something. No rush, just when he had a free moment. "West," he said, his old eyes smiling at me, "I have nothing but free time. Let's go for a walk. You know how I feel about talking out here."

I did. JT always stressed to me that in the penitentiary the walls have ears. Inmates were always watching and listening. He also thought the new cameras they installed could listen to conversations. He got up slowly, adjusted his glasses, and led me to his cell. His cellmate was there. JT spoke softly, telling him we needed the cell for a moment. The guy gathered his things and left.

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JT invited me over to the seat at the desk. Then he asked if I would like something to drink or eat. Once certain his company was taken care of, he sat on his bunk. He always carried himself with manners and class.

“What’s on your mind, West?”

I told him I needed to either find someone to write my writ or write it myself. Neither option looked good because I didn’t trust the jailhouse lawyers, and I did not trust myself. Every direction, I saw fear. “Someone’s going to have to do it. I’m running out of time to file this thing.”

“West, I’ve known for some time now who’s gonna write it. *You* are!”

He said I had as much chance of overturning my case as anyone else did. The truth was, no one ever won a pro-se writ, and if I managed to do so, I’d be the first he’s ever seen.

“Besides, you’re as smart as anyone I’ve ever met.” He smiled. “The street smarts, not so much, but we’re working on that.”

My smile was fleeting, half-hearted. I told JT I didn’t know anything about the law. Even though he may think I’m smart, I knew my own limits. “Writing an advanced legal brief is not in my wheelhouse. I couldn’t possibly do it. No way!”

He got up, put his hand on my shoulder, and said, “Come with me, West. Let’s go talk to the guy who is going to show you what all those books in the law library do.”

I followed him to the cell of a little old Black man from Galveston. His name was Mr. Winston. He and I had interacted a little. All our encounters were pleasant, too. Nice guy, who also appeared to be intelligent—a rare bird in this place. Always willing to help others, Winston had the respect of everybody on the pod. Not the same kind of respect JT commanded, but respect

nonetheless. JT earned his from the street, while Winston's was earned by character. *Character*. How rarely I get to use that word when describing one of my neighbors in there.

Like JT, he was in prison for murder. That didn't really bother me, though. In prison, you had to change your mind about who the good guys and bad guys were.

"Winston," JT began, "you know West, don't you?"

"Heck, yes, I know West. How are you, Mr. West?" Winston said as he pumped my hand. It was not lost on me that he used the salutation *Mr.* The guy was a class act.

"Mr. Winston, I am well. Please don't call me Mr. West. The only Mr. West I know is my father." I shook his hand back, exchanging the same affable smile and eye contact.

He laughed and told me to tell my father how much he loved reading his sports articles and listening to his sports radio show. He said my dad wrote like the sportswriters he grew up reading in New York, a style of writing that he said was sadly disappearing.

JT jumped back into the conversation at that point, telling Mr. Winston he wanted a personal favor. "West is my friend. He needs someone to show him around that law library. Someone to teach him what all those books mean. He's smart as a whip. Can you do this for me?"

While I was flattered by the rare gesture of JT asking for a personal favor on my behalf, I also felt a little awkward because Mr. Winston couldn't say no to JT.

Mr. Winston broke into a huge smile. "JT, it'd be my pleasure."

"Winston knows the score, and he thinks you can do this as well as or better than anyone in here. He's also a whiz with those law books."

"Mr. Winston," I asked, "do you really believe I can do this?"

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“Absolutely, West. You can do this. We will go to the law library and spend a few days going over all the reference books. After that you can ask me questions when you have them. Sound good?”

“West,” JT said, “*our* friend Winston likes that black bag coffee, the good stuff. Grab him a few bags next time you go to commissary.”

JT strolled away, leaving Mr. Winston and I alone. We made our arrangements to meet up at the law library. I had no idea what sort of world Mr. Winston was about to open to me.

A few days later, Mr. Winston and I were in the law library bright and early. We took advantage of the 4:00 a.m. sessions they were offering because there were fewer people there. He started me with the United States Constitution. We went over the amendments pertaining to due process. After the basics were covered, I read every book Mr. Winston put in front of me.

After a few days, he stared hard at me. “You possess a unique enough skill set for this. I feel confident that once you go through your trial transcripts and pick out the errors, you will have little difficulty forming your grounds. I’m excited to see what you produce, West. You don’t need me anymore. You’ve picked up the idea about the writ better than most of the men in here. Be that first pro-se victory for us.”

For the next two months, I spent eight hours a day of voluntary adversity in the law library. It was grueling work, mainly because it was all so foreign to me. Still, getting out of my comfort zone had become second nature after living in this environment for four years. I admitted my fear to myself—I was vulnerable and afraid to take on a challenge with real risk, to bet on myself when the stakes were so high. But with the belief JT had put in

me, and with Winstons's generous help, my fear didn't paralyze me—it motivated me. I had something to overcome, something to vanquish. I discovered I could do some pretty incredible things when my back was against the wall and my life was on the line. Despite all the failures of the thousands who came before me, I truly believed I could be the one to win a pro-se writ. Without that belief in myself, I do not think I could have completed such a mentally taxing exercise.

My final product from all the voluntary adversity was a writ laying out six grounds on which I attempted to prove ineffective assistance of counsel. My mother and I must have exchanged over one hundred phone calls and dozens of packages. I would send her my additions as I completed them, wait the requisite two to three days for them to get to her in the mail, then call her to go over them. She would then send me what she typed through the mail. The amount of work my mom put in was breathtaking. I know I consumed her life for those two months, but she never complained.

After the writ was turned in, I felt a jolt of confidence that was only comparable to the thrill I got from competing in sports. A year that began like all was lost became a year that reinforced a saying my father told me when I was younger. He told me, "Do things you're afraid of, so you can do things you're afraid of."

Reflections

How right my father was. By doing things I feared, I was able to do more things I feared. Facing fears took their power away. Most fears, I have found, were in my head. Which meant they were not real but only appeared real because your mind is a powerful thing.

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However, you can control your thoughts. Your thinking is everything, too.

Two critical takeaways I have learned from facing your fears:

- 1) It's never as bad as you think it's going to be.*
- 2) You're always capable of more than you think you are.*

Do not allow overthinking to get in the way of overcoming.

CHAPTER 12

CONTROL THE CONTROLLABLES

Invest Your Time in Things You Can Actually Impact

June 6, 2023

“West, do you have any idea how many travel permits you’ve received since you got out of prison?” Ms. Braggs asked me, while she scrolled the mouse on her computer.

I’ve been blessed with an incredible parole officer. Ms. Braggs, who I call *Braggs* for short, is probably close to thirty years old. She’s a Black woman, about 5’5”, powerfully built, with a big heart. Tough on the outside and caring on the inside.

On the night I earned a master’s in criminal justice, I looked up into the audience from the dais to wave to my family. I saw Ms. Braggs and her girlfriend sitting with my family. They were all together, excitedly waving back at me. That showing of support told me everything I needed to know about Braggs.

Besides my wife and Ray, Braggs is the person who knows most about me. It’s existential she knows everything about my life because my life is, literally, in her hands. I don’t mean this strictly in a controlling or authoritative way (although she does have the

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power to arrest me and send me back to prison); rather, I mean in a protective way. The better she knows me as a client (the name for an ex-offender on parole), and everything that happens in my life, the more armed she can be with the facts to vouch for me if someone ever tried to falsely accuse me of something in an attempt to violate my parole.

We were having our monthly parole meeting, where I pee in a cup, answer her questions, and pick up my travel permits (I must receive permission from Texas to leave Texas). Pretty standard and boring stuff. Boring is good when you're on parole.

Responding to Braggs's question, I said, "I have no idea what the exact number is, but I would estimate it's probably close to four hundred. I've been on the road since 2017."

"That's pretty close to the actual number," she confirmed, looking up from her computer screen. Braggs has told me more than once that I am probably one of the highest-profile parolees in Texas. She doesn't tell me this to inflate my ego, either. I've always received that comment to mean: *There's a lot of people watching you. You can't even stub your toe.*

My father tells me something similar when anything big happens in my life, except he says, "The bullseye on your back just got bigger. Not everyone wants to see you succeed. The initial feeling you get when you see someone succeeding tells you how you feel about that person. And there's going to be a lot of people who won't feel good about your wins."

There are people who think I should have served the entire sixty-five years in prison. This is mind-boggling to me. With a limited mindset like that about rehabilitation, you would need to build thousands more prisons in America to house all the people with whom you're angry.

Putting the professor hat on tells me anger was the issue with my lengthy sentence. While earning my master's in criminal justice, I learned there are one of two reasons (or both) that juries give out lengthy sentences. Juries are either afraid of a defendant or mad at them. My jury was the latter, as I never physically hurt anyone or showed a propensity towards violence. I don't blame them for being angry, either. The guy they sentenced to life in prison was an arrogant, smug drug addict who, up until his sentencing, did not think the rules applied to him.

Thankfully, I killed that guy in prison when I had my spiritual awakening.

"Braggs, I know the permits are a lot of work for one client, so just know how grateful I am for your hard work in getting them done."

It's true. Travel permits are very time-consuming. Both for her and for me. Each month, when I pick them up, I take a picture in front of the parole office and post it on social media. I'm smiling big in each picture because I'm sincerely so grateful I *get to* be on parole the rest of my life and travel like this. Where a normal person would view being on parole as oppressive, I see it as a privilege. The alternative is serving my sentence in prison.

Perspective is everything.

Each time I see Braggs, I try to bring positivity into her day. Every person in the carceral system has a tough job. I like to try to show her the potential of a client she oversees, so that she knows her job matters. I value her praise, too, because she is on my side, and feeling like I'm justifying that backing is important. Especially in that environment, little wins matter so much. On this visit, I shared with Braggs the letter General Ken Kamper, a two-star general, wrote for my parole file. It blew my mind.

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June 2, 2023

My name is Ken Kamper, and I'm a Major General in the United States Army. I've served in our Army for the last 34 years since graduating from West Point in 1989.

I first met Damon in 2020 as we were grappling with the problem of suicide at Fort Sill. Fort Sill, historically, has averaged 2–5 suicides a year for the last decade+. We were looking for someone who might be able to inspire our Soldiers, and even their family members, with a story of how to develop and build resiliency as a way to, in a positive way, work through the inevitable adversities of life.

Damon's "coffee bean" message resonated greatly to our Soldiers at Fort Sill—so much so, that we embarked on a long-term plan to bring Damon to Fort Sill for 2–3 days every other month in order to immerse him in to all of our formations. On any given day, we've got about 14,000 service members at Ft. Sill—our goal was to have each of them hear Damon's story, his message, his lessons learned, and to adopt the "be the coffee bean" mentality. For the first time in over a decade, Fort Sill had zero suicides in 2022, and in fact, went 23 months without a suicide—something simply remarkable for which Damon was an invaluable part of achieving. I personally shared what Damon was doing with us at Fort

Damon West

Sill with all of the Army's other 2-star commanding generals.

I've watched Damon grow, learn, and expand in his approach to touch many, many others in a positive way with his books, with his presentations, and with his infectious energy and work ethic to do something good. Damon's been over to my house on multiple occasions for dinner. He's gotten to know my kids. I've simply been impressed over the past couple years to see Damon truly determined to make a positive difference in our country, to help people of all walks of life. Damon has, and continues to inspire people to overcome the situations of adversity they find themselves in by looking for the good, the positive, and to inspire others positively even in the midst of tough circumstances.

I've come to trust Damon implicitly. I trust his personal integrity. I trust his ability to positively influence our Soldiers and their families. I trust Damon greatly.

KENNETH L. KAMPER

Major General, US Army

"West, what are you telling those soldiers to have such an impact?" Braggs asked me.

Besides the allegory of the coffee bean, I knew the part of my story that impacted the soldiers most. It's something the Army taught, only they taught it a different way. I was able to teach it through storytelling and tapping into a spiritual reservoir, using my personal experience as a backdrop.

Six Dimes and a Nickel

“Controlling the controllables. Knowing what’s on my line,” I responded.

“What’s that mean, *on your line?*” she asked.

“I can’t believe I’ve never shared this with you. I learned it in recovery from my sponsor, Ray. Back when I was in prison.”



Life in prison, although extremely difficult at times, became easier for me once I finally let go of the things I couldn’t control, which were most things. At a twelve-step meeting, I received a clearer understanding of what few things I truly control. One morning, Ray asked me to recite the Serenity Prayer, and then tell the group what the prayer meant to me. From rote memory, I recited:

“God, grant me the serenity to accept the things I cannot change, the courage to change the things I can, and the wisdom to know the difference.”

Then I spouted off what I thought it meant, something about struggles in life and picking your battles. Ray told me very abruptly that I was wrong, and to sit down. I felt I was handled roughly, but my skin was hard enough that I could mask my emotion.

Ray then went to the chalkboard and drew a line from left to right, all the way across the board. “This,” he said, “represents God’s line. Don’t think of this line being just the width of a chalkboard. This line is more like from one horizon of the Earth to the other. It’s infinitely long. On this line are all the things you can’t touch, Damon. Those things are everything from the first part of the prayer, ‘*grant me the serenity to accept the things I cannot change.*’ If you touch things on God’s line, you will have problems. Period.”

Ray held his thumb and index finger about an inch apart and erased a small part out of "God's line." "This line right here, inside this inch I erased, is your line, Damon. In it are the things God gives you to work on. Do you know what's on your line?"

Not quite sure, but following his progression, I said, "Things I can change?"

"That's right, Damon. It's the second part of the prayer, '*the courage to change the things I can.*' Let me save you the suspense on what's inside your line. There are only four things you can change in this world, four things you control," he explained, holding up his fingers in the air. Counting them off, he recited, "What you think, what you say, what you feel and, most importantly, what you do. That's it."

He wasn't finished. "Damon, the last part of the prayer is the most important for us addicts. You see, we think we control everything. We have these big egos that tell us we can do whatever we want. When we drink or use drugs, we become the giants of our dreams. The last line says, '*and the wisdom to know the difference.*' This means knowing the difference between that," he said, pointing at the long line, God's line, "and that." He pointed at the little one-inch line, my line.

He put the chalk down and looked me in the eyes. "Damon, if you only control what you think, say, feel, or do, then why are you constantly worried about the other things you cannot control? Give those things back to God. They're His anyway. Work on yourself and use your life to do His will. Everything else will take care of itself. You won't believe how great your life will become."

Ray's diagram really hit home with me. When I encounter something that is beyond my control, beyond what I think, say, feel, or do, I say to myself, "Not on my line." I sometimes worry

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and obsess, but I try to check myself and ask God to take away my anxieties.



“Braggs, do you remember me telling you about the rules I have imposed on myself because I’m on parole for life?”

“Yes!” She exclaimed. “I’ve shared some of these with other clients. Write them down on this paper, please. That way I can share them all.”

So, I grabbed a pen and paper and wrote down My Rules:

1. If possible, I am never alone—in a car, at a dinner, in a room, etc.—with a woman who is not my wife or that I do not know well. I’m not afraid of being tempted. Rather, I don’t ever want to put myself in a situation where it’s another woman’s word against mine.
2. If I’m on an elevator alone, and a woman or a child gets on the elevator alone as well, I get off the elevator. It doesn’t matter which floor. I’ll find another elevator or take the stairs.
3. I am never alone around minors. When I’m speaking at school, I never use hallway bathrooms where boys could be in the bathroom. I always use the teachers’ lounge bathroom. With no one else in the bathroom, there is zero chance of being falsely accused of saying or doing something improper or illegal.
4. When I take pictures with women or children, I try to always remember to close my fists and show those closed fists in the picture. If I’m prepared for the photo op, I’ll

have something in my hand, like a book, bottle of water, or my phone. This way, no one can accuse me of touching them inappropriately behind their backs.

5. When I'm in a store, most of the times when I grab something off a shelf, I buy it. I also always get a paper receipt.
6. I never help people on the side of the road because I don't know what their story is. In prison, I heard this guy tell a story about a time he helped someone on the side of the road when that person ran out of gas. As he was helping push the car, a police car pulled up to render aid. The cop ran the VIN and the car was stolen. Then he ran the IDs of both men pushing the stolen car. Two parolees pushing a stolen car meant that both men went to prison for stealing that car. No one believed this guy was innocent.
7. I do not allow people in my car who I do not know well. If I am ever pulled over, I must be certain that my passengers do not have drugs or anything illegal on them.
8. When I travel, I spend the majority of my free time alone in my hotel room, with the door locked. I take as many meals as possible in my room. I never met a person who got in trouble, sober, alone in a locked hotel room.
9. When I'm on the road, I locate and attend local twelve-step meetings in towns all over America. My program of recovery is the most important thing in my life; anything I put in front of it, I will lose. I need my meetings.
10. Documentation beats conversation. With fingerprints and DNA in the FBI known-criminal database, I don't want my fingerprints or DNA anywhere I was not documented

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to be. A plane, my hotel, my rental car, a restaurant, a place I'm speaking, a place I'm invited to—these places are all OK. Basically, I try not to be anywhere when there is not a documented reason for me to be there. You never know where a future crime will be committed.

"Damn," she said, in a low voice. "You really do control the controllables."

"I have to be a master of what is on my line. You never know when someone wants more than your word, and I will never again receive the benefit of doubt. Nor could I take the stand in my defense at a trial because a jury would never believe me. Punishment never stops, so eliminating the need for the benefit of doubt is paramount to my desire to live outside of a prison."

"West, keep working your program and following your rules. It's working."

Before I got up to leave our session, I asked Braggs the question I always ended with: "Are there any of your clients I can talk to, to serve them and help them on their journey coming out of prison?"

She laughed and said, "I got a lot of clients that you can help, but you can't be in two places at once. You belong out there," she said, pointing towards the window. "Get out of my office and go change the world, coffee bean," she said with a smile.

Walking out of parole, I am always reminded that I live on a razor's edge, where there is no room for errors. Not only that; failure is not an option. If I failed and went back to prison, I would take so many more people with me this time. As the Face of Hope, I know that what's going on in my life is greater than me. Even before General Kamper's letter, I knew that this life is

not about me—I'm just blessed to be the vessel for a greater story being told.

No worries, I am in a program of recovery, and I am a coffee bean. And, as long as I'm a coffee bean, I have a life of choice as opposed to a life of compulsion. The only way I'm going into prison is through the front gate, as a visitor and an agent of change.

Reflections

This is one of the most difficult principles to apply in my life. So often, I want to control things which are beyond my control. This causes frustration and it wastes time (the most precious resource).

When I step off my line, I give myself grace because the last thing I need to do is waste more time being mad at myself because I failed to stay focused on the controllables. Give yourself grace. Remember, it's spiritual progress, not spiritual perfection.

When it comes to the rules I live by, I do not think my rules are that uncommon for most people. Yes, there is more of an existential threat I face because I have already had my second chance in life (there will never be a third). However, this is where discipline comes into play. Any person who wants to be great has to be disciplined.

Without discipline, it will be difficult to achieve your goals. Lack of discipline can lead to inconsistency, procrastination, and, ultimately, failure. The good news is that being disciplined is on your line.

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Lastly, what's on your line is the ability to follow through on what you say you will do. Whether it's a promise to someone else or a promise to yourself, be a doer. In life, you either find an excuse or you find a way.

CHAPTER 13

STAY IN YOUR LANE

Run Your Own Race

October 27, 2023

“You should only do the things you feel called to and qualified to do.”

Jon Gordon is someone whose advice I always take seriously. No one person is more responsible for the success I’ve had in life as a speaker and an author than Jon. Because he has already paved the road I am travelling on professionally, I always seek his counsel when it comes to my platform. He is my coach.

Everyone needs coaches and mentors. This is something I believe and practice in my own life. Jon is one of several peers I turn to, depending on the circumstances, who help guide my decision making. These are people with whom I have spent ample time; they know and understand my goals and, therefore, can mentor me to the best possible outcome in alignment with those goals. Sometimes, an outside voice is critical to cancel out the noise in your head.

This day, I was telling Jon about the multiple requests I was getting from people for *me* to become a personal coach, or life

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coach. They were lucrative offers, to say the least, but Jon could sense my apprehension on the topic.

“Here’s the deal, Jon. I don’t really know that I’m qualified to coach someone else. I think that the ‘personal coaching’ space is littered with hucksters and cons who are not qualified to help people. Many of those ‘coaches’ are only doing it as a hustle to enrich themselves.”

In many ways, prison taught me so much about spotting the fakes, the cons. In there, your survival is dependent upon learning how to read people and understand human behavior. Out here, in the free world, I am able to spot these grifters pretty quickly. Most, though not all, I can catch once they open their mouths. For a formerly incarcerated person, it’s almost an unfair advantage, as these free-world scammers are often amateurs compared to some of the ones you meet in a maximum-security prison.

All one had to do was open Instagram or Facebook and look at the myriad people who called themselves coaches. Typically, the telltale signs of scam artists were the ones who lead with bling (expensive and flashy things), or who make *promises* of what they can do in your life. I tend to be suspicious of anyone, in any profession, who promises you an outcome. In prison, we call these con games “selling dreams.”

I’m more open to someone who can *show*—through their own experiences—how they got to a desired goal or destination in their own lives; this requires transparency. If someone is unwilling to be transparent, they are probably inauthentic. Inauthentic people will *never* lead you in the correct direction because they are constitutionally incapable of doing so.

Another thing that usually tips me off to a potential con is when people try to lure you in by your faith. History is littered

with con artists who have preyed on the faith of others as their angle to get to people. Believers in Christ, in particular, I have found, have always been very susceptible to this. Many of my brothers and sisters in Christ are overly trusting of people who profess their faith in Christ *publicly*. As if, once you say it out loud, it must be true. The victims of these cons, the good and decent people who stand on their faith, expose this Achilles' heel to their hearts, their bank accounts, and their votes!

A profession of faith—saying Jesus's name out loud or praying publicly where *everyone* can see you—means less to me than your *integrity of character*. So, if you're a Christian that is into professing your faith publicly, I want to *see* you practice love, empathy, forgiveness, grace, charity, mercy, humility, patience, tolerance for others who believe differently than you, and compassion. Show me Jesus's core values that appear in red ink in the Gospels of the New Testament. And when you find fault in another, I want you to remember the words in red: "*let he without sin cast the first stone.*"

I don't need to just hear about your belief in Christ. Show me! Seeing is believing. Often, I cannot hear what you are saying because your actions speak so loudly. The same standard has been true for me in my own life, when assessing who I purport to be compared to who I am in my actions. The two must align, lest people see the old Damon (the one I buried in a maximum-security prison) instead of the Damon today (who is living in recovery).

To be fair, there are some good coaches out there. Men and women who have overcome personal and professional adversity to develop a program or platform that others can learn and grow from. Many of these respectable coaches use faith as a core pillar

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of their platforms. In these examples—the good coaches—they demonstrate the necessity of faith and a moral code to guide their decision making. They demonstrate how their faith and spiritual beliefs have shepherded their actions because a spiritual component is *paramount* for any serious personal growth. The differences between the charlatan coaches and the real coaches is often their authenticity, their character, their qualifications, and their results. These real coaches are much more than their profession of faith. These men and women are the ones from whom I seek guidance.

In my opinion, you can never go wrong if you use spirituality as a guide to making the correct decisions. In my life, I am guided by the four spiritual principles my sponsor taught me, straight from the Big Book of AA: unselfishness, honesty, purity, and love. If the choices I wish to make do not line up with all four of these principles, then I must say no.

Am I perfect at using this spiritual tool? Absolutely not! I'm not infallible. I'm a human who makes errors daily. That's OK, too, because I'm not seeking spiritual perfection; rather, I'm always seeking spiritual progress.

After plugging in the prospect of coaching into this spiritual matrix, my decision was easy. "At this time in my life, it's not my lane, Jon. My lane and my time are committed to speaking and writing books. That's where I can add value. I do not think I can add value to someone's life by coaching them. And, if I can't add value, then it's not for me. Your advice, as always, is spot on. Thanks, brother," I said to Jon as I hung up the phone.

I do not feel called to be a coach right now; maybe one day I will feel differently—feel called to do that. Until then, I will stay in my lane. The call with Jon reminded me about the importance

of staying in my lane. It was a hard lesson to learn, one which almost cost me everything.

The Backstory: 2013

My friend, Wild Bill, gave me my prison nickname: Mayor West. He said he called me that because I knew everyone on the unit and everyone knew me. When I went around, shaking everyone's hand, he said I looked like I was the mayor of Stiles prison. I actually grew fond of the nickname.

Wild Bill's real name is Bill Seelye. He was an oil-and-gas guy who fell out of Collin County, and was serving ninety-nine years for theft, securities fraud, and money laundering. Physically, his appearance was imposing, as he was a very big, bald-headed white guy. Despite what you're probably thinking from his description, he was not affiliated with any of the White gangs. He was an independent, like me.

Of all the lifers I met in there, he and I probably had the most in common. He was a broker at one time, and I worked for UBS. We both went to college, and we both ended up in a maximum-security serving life. We even received our charges around the same time in 2008.

Aside from the past similarities, the important thing was that we were both on the same path regarding doing our time. Both of us viewed prison as an opportunity, as we both dived into working a twelve-step program of recovery. We also enrolled in every educational and chapel class we could, and we both wanted nothing to do with the prison culture. This made us odd ducks to the general population, but great influences on each other.

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Occasionally, there was a hiccup in doing time. Like, when I got sent to solitary confinement (the hole) for a month because I got into a fight. The fight was stupid, too. Basically, I uncharacteristically got into someone else's business. In prison terms, I *got out of my lane*. I was terrified of the potential damage I did to my parole chances because a major disciplinary on your record would automatically offset your parole vote for an extra year.

However, an incredibly compassionate and commonsense warden, named Warden Darren Wallace, saved my hide by cutting me a break. As the head warden, he knew me well enough to know I was not a troublemaker; he also knew I was up for parole in a few years. "You have so much potential, and I truly believe a month in the hole and fear of losing your parole has been an effective punishment for your infraction. I want to see you succeed in life, Mayor West," he said, calling me by my prison nickname. Then, he made the case disappear from my file. I could not believe my good fortune.

Because of him overriding my inability to stay in my own lane, solitary ended up being like a reset. It was the first time I had my own cell, so it gave me a chance to really drown out the noise and listen to God. Because I thought I would serve at least a dime (ten years), I called that period of imprisonment *halftime*. Once halftime was over, I went back to living with the lifers. Back to my normal routine.

That year, I got the news that every man in prison wanted to receive. I had been granted an evidentiary hearing on my writ of habeas corpus. It did not mean I was going to overturn my case, but it did mean I had some action, and the court wanted to gather more evidence. The court, as in Judge Snipes.

Because I had avoided disciplinary trouble for that fight, I was immediately ready for the prison bus. I thought about Judge Snipes a lot on the four-hour prison bus ride from Huntsville to Dallas County jail. I still felt the search warrant central to my case lacked probable cause. More than that, I felt he hung me out to dry with his inflammatory comments. If only I could have gotten him to recuse himself at the beginning of all of this.

Alas, he never recused himself. Long ago, I accepted responsibility for the crimes I committed, but there was still a resentment for Snipes that I had not resolved. To my disappointment, Snipes did not even bother to show up for the evidentiary hearing. Instead, he appointed a magistrate (someone to act as judge in his place), named April Smith. Magistrate Smith was very professional.

The hearing was a one-sided grilling of Ed Sigel, my former lead counsel from my original organized-crime trial. Chip Lewis—one of the best defense attorneys in Texas, appointed and paid for by Mr. Walter Umphrey—was representing me. Chip had Ed on the stand for hours. I sat at the table, handcuffed, listening to Ed say some of the most outrageous things. The district attorney in Dallas, seeing they were losing the case, eventually gave up on trying to save Ed during cross-examination. When Karen Lambert, my co-counsel from my trial, took the stand and affirmed everything we were alleging about Ed's lack of effectiveness during punishment, the prosecutors had no choice but to concede. The only time I have ever seen a more one-sided hearing was my own trial, where I was, of course, guilty as hell.

Magistrate Smith indicated we had won the hearing. Chip told me as much on the way out of the courtroom. The likelihood that my six dimes and a nickel would be reduced to a lesser

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sentence, somewhere in the neighborhood of twenty years (two dimes), looked really good.

By the end of 2013, I was transported on another prison bus from Dallas County jail and back onto the Stiles Unit. I was back at *home*, in my job at Unit Supply, going to my recovery meetings with Wild Bill. With the ease of a student going back to school after summer recess, I got into my routine of doing my time. I looked back on that year in prison as being one of the most educational, for I never got out of my lane again.

Reflections

Staying in your lane can sound like it stifles growth. It can sound like putting on blinders and only narrowing your focus to a small window. At first, it may even be that very thing, holding you in place. But that's how you initially discover what your lane is. Figuring out what you are good at, enjoy, and most important, can provide value to the lives of other people is the thing you should be doing. At that point, whatever is outside of your lane is a distraction at best, or the wrong path. Once you have it in your bones, though, that you are doing what you know you should be doing, growth can become exponential.

Your lane will be free of clutter. This means you will remove people, places, and things that do not add value to your life.

When you find your lane, you will develop situational awareness. True situational awareness is when you pay attention to everyone and everything around you. It derives from both a sense of safety and a sense of service.

Damon West

Your antennae will become more sensitive to things that are both meant for you and not meant for you. You will read rooms you are in, better helping you to discover the opportunities to serve and the relationships with the right people.

The same traits and habits that make you can break you. If your drive to succeed lacks focus, proportion, and humility, then your intentions will be misplaced and your ego will never be right-sized.

Lastly, keep negative people out of your lane. My sponsor, Ray, says, "Stay away from negative people; they have a problem for every solution."

CHAPTER 14

TAKE TOUGH STANCES

Hold Your Ground and Never Compromise Your Core Values

August 6, 2023

“He was a gentleman who always said what needed to be said. He always did what needed to be done. I remember when he put me on the cover of the sports magazine here. It was the first time a Black person had ever been on it. But he felt, at that particular time, it was time to do it. And I knew what it meant for him to do that, and how much his family would go through for what he was doing. They were going to take some of the wrath for it, too. He knew it, and they knew it.”

Joe Washington Jr. flew in from Baltimore to eulogize my father. Little Joe, as he was known in his playing days, was family, even though we were not blood related. He and my father had a lifelong friendship that was forged in the fires of civil rights in 1971. My father, a young sportswriter who moved to Texas from Missouri, was just a few years older than Joe when he put Joe on the cover of a Southeast Texas preseason football magazine cover. The audacity of my father, for putting a Black man on the cover,

triggered a barrage of vandalism to my parents' home as well as their vehicles. It also filled up a shoebox of hate-inspired letters.

When I was a boy, my father made me read all the hate mail. Every vile, nasty, negative word imaginable was used to describe my father (and my mother). His lesson in instructing me to read those was to witness the capacity of small-minded humans to display the worst of their tribalized instincts. He found a way to turn those negative ramblings of bigots, racists, and xenophobes into a teachable moment. Taking the power out of the hands of bigots and putting it back into the brave act that sparked the uproar, he said, "I want you to see what it looks like to take a stand and do the right thing because, sometimes, taking a stand and doing the right thing means you're going to stand alone."

I could not believe my father was dead. We found out in June that he had stage four colon cancer. He died seven weeks later, on July 28, 2023. I knew he was gone when I got the call from my mother at 5:00 a.m. because she never calls at that time. She was crying, her voice cracking, when she said, "He's gone, Damon. Your father just went to be with Jesus."

She was with him in his room, at MD Anderson, in Houston, which was ninety miles away from me in Southeast Texas. Through my own tears, I told her, "I'm coming right now to get you, Mom."

On that lonely drive that morning to pick up my mother, I replayed my father's life from my perspective. Many of my memories were of him when I was a kid wanting to play sports. I was a not-so-good athlete, and often one of the last kids picked. He would come home after work and play whatever sport I was trying to get better at, often with little progress being made. This taught me about patience.

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As I neared my preteen years, my little league coach, John Bass, saw something in me that no one else had. He said I had the best eye-hand coordination of any athlete he'd ever coached. He told my father his vision for me, but it required us being all in. More practices before school, after school, on weekends, and so on. My dad and I jumped at the opportunity. What happened next seemed like a dream. Almost overnight—within one year—I became one of the best baseball players for my age group in the city.

Then, I picked up a football and found out I had a cannon for an arm. My father used his contacts within the college and pro sports world to get me around some of the best athletes in the world. He believed that if I could touch my dream, that dream would become more real. He was correct, too. Together, he and I created a blue-chip quarterback where a mediocre athlete once stood. He was so amazing at nurturing my sports dreams. I could not have been blessed with a better father when it came to sports.

But those memories weren't the most lasting I had of my father. They still aren't. When I think of him, my thoughts drift to the non-sports stuff, the important lessons my father taught me about life. Especially the lessons about taking tough stances.



Reading the hate mail was my first memory of him taking tough stances. He explained to me the story behind one of his most controversial acts. He was twenty-six, new to the newsroom in Port Arthur, and a new publisher had been brought to run the local paper. Bill Maddox had served in the press operations for some of the most defining civil rights events in the '60s, and he brought a pugnacious, socially progressive attitude to how he intended to

cover the news. Every year, the best prospect in Texas would get the cover treatment, only to this point, those athletes had been unanimously white. Joe Washington Jr. was not. But he was the top prospect, expected to run roughshod through defenses. Bill asked his sports editor if he'd be comfortable putting Joe on the cover. That editor, using a word my father never said, informed Bill that he wouldn't. So Bill fired him, then turned to my father. "Bob? How about you?"

My father had no such problems. He wasn't naïve—he knew what this would stir up. He also knew what it would mean for him personally and professionally. But to my father, doing what was right wasn't a tough stance at all. It was to everyone else, but to him, putting the best athlete on the cover, regardless of the color of his skin, was how he could live without compromising his values.

When my father helped break the color barrier of the sports pages in Port Arthur, Texas, he found that he had a platform to help give a voice to the voiceless, the "little guy." To him, that was a responsibility journalists had—to follow the facts and be on the right side of history. Through his honest and sometimes hard-hitting writing, he harnessed what he referred to as "the power of the pen." He had the power to amplify a view or a message into people's lives, the local barber shops, the companies and refineries in the community and, mainly, around the place he felt that most change occurred: the kitchen table.

Moreover, the power of the pen also gave him the last word. So, if you were foolish enough to write him a letter which espoused ignorance, prejudice, or small-mindedness, he would help the world see you for who you were by publishing your worst inner thoughts. He would leave the incorrect grammar in place, too, so

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that your ignorance could be accentuated. Then, he would get the last word. You could write another letter in reply or tell your friends how Bob West did not correctly convey your thoughts, but your rebuttal would be lost to the public conversation, limited to your small network of your echo chamber.

Through this, he taught his three sons that ever-important lesson about hitting bullies back. Most bullies, he would explain, cry foul when you hit back.

This was all before social media, of course, where every person now has the power of the pen—a development my father always viewed with some skepticism. “Social media is helpful for knowing who people really are and what they truly feel in their hearts. No one has anywhere to hide, and that includes the most powerful entities. Even though I don’t necessarily think every Archie Bunker in America *needs* a megaphone, there has to be a public square where every voice and view—especially the ones you disagree with—can be freely shared. That’s true freedom of speech. Social media is that public square now,” he told me once.

As much as my father loathed ignorance, he viewed cancel culture with equal disdain. How many times in his career did people try to cancel him? Those stories were endless, but no one could cancel him. “America was different back then. The media was different back then. We could have difficult conversations and take unpopular stances without fear of losing everything. We used to make movies that dealt with all of these topics so people could process it and discuss it. You couldn’t make a movie like *Blazing Saddles* or have a TV show like *All in the Family* today. People are too sensitive. Political correctness has run amok. Like an unused muscle, traditional media has atrophied,” he lamented,

when discussing the way cancel culture and political correctness destroyed people's ability to take tough stances.

My mind drifted to later in life, when my father dealt with having a son in prison. That first visit my father had with me at Stiles was difficult. It was obvious from my physical condition that I had been in some fights. Despite my bumps and bruises, I tried to put on the most positive outward demeanor and dismissed any concerns they had for my safety. "It's just normal prison stuff," I told them, as I waived my hand dismissively.

When my mom got up to get more food and drinks from the vending machine, he reminded me to always stand up for myself and to not give into the White hate groups in prison. "You keep standing alone because you're right and they're wrong. There's no place in our lives for a racist. Do not give in under any circumstances."

A few weeks later, at visitation, he could see prison was taking a toll on me. Knowing how much I always loved sports, he shifted the conversation to that once-happy place, inquiring as to what sports I was playing on the rec yard. "None." I told him.

Away from my mom, I confided in him that I was fighting the Black gangs at this point and that I was on a very dangerous island. The rec yard was too intimidating because every sport was segregated by the color of your skin. Just as Muhammad warned me, race was king in prison. He mulled this over in his mind. For a guy who spent his career as a sportswriter, breaking racial barriers in sports, this had to be anathema to him. As he was hugging me when visitation ended, he looked me in the eyes, and said, "Sports is the great uniter. It brings people together like nothing else can."

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About six weeks into prison, on a Monday morning, I woke up full of despair, in a seemingly hopeless world. I was mired in an almost daily battle with the Black gangs who, in concert with the White gangs, wanted me to go be with my own race, where I belonged. Fear was the loudest voice in my head during those dark first few months. The only way to get that voice of fear out of my head was to quit listening to myself and start talking to myself.

Which is exactly what I did. That morning, I talked myself into using the only thing I had not used to earn respect while in prison: my athletic ability. Specifically, I was going to the basketball court, which the Blacks ran and where no Whiteboys were allowed. Despite the danger of the situation, my father's words were ringing in my ears. *Sports are the great uniter*. I was going to go take the toughest stance of my life to that point.

It made sense. On the way to the rec yard, I thought about all those Friday night lights I played under growing up in Texas. You could see people in the stands, from all different backgrounds and races, hugging each other, slapping each other on the back, high-fiving, even crying together. You didn't always see that in other places in society. Heck, we Americans can even self-segregate our religions.

Before there was Martin Luther King Jr., there was Jackie Robinson. Before you integrated lunch counters in the south, you integrated locker rooms. My father broke the color barrier on sports pages in my part of Texas. Sports were the melting pot, and it would be the thing that could either make me whole or break me trying.

It was the most brutal basketball I had ever played, often being nine-on-one, instead of five-on-five; my own teammates didn't

want me out there. Not many fouls are called in prison basketball, and I got knocked down many times that first game. The next morning, bruised, but less despairing than the day before, I went right back to the court, to much the same result. Nevertheless, I kept showing up every day, fighting through sports for my right to exist. After six difficult days of playing basketball, my gamble on myself finally paid off. The Blacks told me I had earned their respect on the court.

I remember being giddy with anticipation for my next visit. My father, I knew, would be so proud. He did not disappoint, either. When I told him the basketball-court story, I received the first “atta-boy” in a long time. It felt great, too.

As the years went on in prison, my father got to see me turn it all around and become a better man. When I got out, I lived with him and my mother, giving him a front-row seat to what he thought of as one of the greatest comeback stories ever. Being a sports guy, he loved the underdog journey. One of the greatest moments I got to share with him after prison was the day I paid my mother and him back the \$50,000 they cashed in from their retirement to pay for my legal defense. It was the first, and only, time I saw my father cry.

Ironically, it was the transformation in my life that finally made my father an outward believer in Christ, as my father was most private about his faith. Growing up, he was always present with us in mass every Sunday, but that was a requirement. My mother, a devout Catholic, made marriage to her conditional on his being involved in raising us in the Church. He never converted, though, choosing to remain a non-practicing Baptist.

However, for him, there was no denying the hand of God in my life. He could find no other way to explain my rebirth after

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prison and the impact my life had on others. He would often call me and talk about the things God was doing in my life. A few weeks before his death, I asked him about his faith journey. He confirmed that my life changed his, making his relationship with Christ stronger than ever.

He revealed to me why he kept his faith private throughout his life. Ever the wordsmith, his sharp response made a lasting impact. “Damon, I’ve always believed in Christ, but it was always the hypocritical-*Christians* that kept me from going all-in publicly. Every battle I fought in civil rights was against people who claimed to be ‘God-fearing.’ At every turn, they cloaked themselves in their faith while justifying injustice. Why on earth would I publicly throw in my lot with a group like that when I can have a meaningful, private relationship with Christ?”

That stuck with me as well. It was difficult to argue with and it also resembled what Muhammad once told me, that *religion* was a manmade concept, while *spirituality* was your conscious connection to whatever you called God. My father had that spiritual connection to Christ and did not need the trappings of a public, religious label.

To my father, blindly following the pack was the opposite of taking a tough stance. To him, regardless of how you label yourself, living fearlessly with a strong moral code was the harder road, but ultimately the more rewarding one. As a Christian, and as a human being, my father never had trouble looking the man in the mirror in the eye. It wasn’t until I turned my life around, to where I could do the same, did I start to feel I was walking in his shoes.

On the drive back from the hospital where my father had died, my mother and I talked a lot. She has always been very good at compartmentalizing pain to get through the immediate situation, so we began planning his funeral and notifying everyone about my father's passing. As we expected, the news traveled fast, and the outpouring of support was overwhelming.

Growing up as his son, I had a pretty good idea of what a legendary and gigantic figure he was for sports in Southeast Texas. However, his funeral revealed stories and connections I never knew existed. Hundreds of people showed up to pay their respects. The main themes I heard from everyone that day were how much he did to serve people in our community, the impact he had on sports in our area and, like Little Joe eulogized, the tough stances he took in pursuit of being on the right side of history.

As with anything, picking your battles is key. Sometimes, however, your battles pick you. My father, living by his principles, was always ready for those battles.

Reflections

My father was a leader, who taught me so much about leadership with how he lived his life. Leaders take tough stances. Leading is only easy when everyone agrees with you. Often, it is a lonely place. True leadership requires character, integrity, the courage to say tough truths, poise under pressure, and a willingness to fight for what you believe.

It is impossible to be a great leader without empathy. Empathy is the hallmark of being human. If a person

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lacks this then he/she can never truly feel with you. If he/she cannot feel with you, then they will never take the time to truly know you or represent your core values.

My father understood that people, for the most part, want to be led. And, in the absence of good leadership, people would follow the wrong leader. Like a man dying of thirst in the desert who sees a mirage and mistakes it for an oasis. If that man is thirsty enough and desperate enough, he will drink the sand—and the sand will kill him! This is what happens to us on the inside when we consume the wrong spiritual and mental food.

Build a scorecard for what a good leader looks like. Run any person who asks you to follow them—whether it be your vote, your faith, your bank account, or any aspect of life—through that scorecard. If they don't align with the qualities (the values you deem important), then run—don't walk—away from them.

Run yourself through that scorecard, too. If you don't practice the traits of what you would follow, then make the changes to become that type of leader. That power to change is what is on your line.

Good leaders are:

- 1) Authentic.*
- 2) Accountable.*
- 3) Vulnerable.*
- 4) Accessible.*
- 5) Listeners and communicators.*

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- 6) *Servants.*
- 7) *Readers.*
- 8) *Humble and open to the best ideas.*
- 9) *Engaging.*
- 10) *Empathetic.*
- 11) *Uniters.*
- 12) *Motivators, who inspire others to be better.*
- 13) *Resilient and persistent.*
- 14) *Coffee Beans.*

Remember, if you sacrifice your core values, then you will lose everything in the end. No amount of short-term gain is worth your purpose and your mission.

CHAPTER 15

WORK A PERSONAL INVENTORY

Clear the Clutter in Your Life

The Backstory: 2014

The year began with a truly bittersweet event. In January, my former cellmate and good friend, Carlos, was transferred off the Stiles Unit. It was rare that lifers transferred off a maximum-security unit because there were really no programs a lifer could get into until they had served a decade of their sentence. However, Carlos was accepted into the Field Minister program, which recruited men with aggravated life sentences. It was one of the highest honors to be chosen for this program, too. He was transferred to the Darrington Unit, where he would earn a four-year seminary bachelor's degree in theology. Once graduated from the program, TDCJ would send him to one of their prisons, where he would become an Inmate Chaplain (Field Minister).

In my mind, I always envisioned myself saying goodbye to him because I was eligible for parole a few decades before he was. Nevertheless, I was happy for him, and I was proud of the man he had become. Like with my journey through prison, Carlos had a spiritual awakening. Now he was truly living in his purpose.

Speaking of spiritual growth, in 2014, I attended a life-changing retreat in prison. A faith-based group of men came into the prison for a four-day retreat of food, fellowship, and fun. The food part is how the volunteers lured in the dozens of inmates. If you're going to go fishing, you need the correct bait. It turned out gumbo, spaghetti, bread pudding, pizza, ice cream, and doughnuts lured us in.

Looking around the gymnasium at the other retreatants, I saw men of every faith, race, ethnicity, and criminal background. There were Muslims, Jews, Buddhists, even pagans. Murderers, rapists, robbers, child molesters, arsonists, thieves (like me), and every crime imaginable were allowed to be part of the fellowship and share in that spiritual glow for four days and three nights. It was like we all escaped from prison and went to Heaven. They lured these men in by their stomachs and came away with their souls.

On the first day of the retreat, many of the inmates were standoffish. Some even boldly telling the volunteers they were only there for the food, to which the volunteers heaped more food on their plates. As the days went on, with fellowshiping, table-sharing personal stories, and singing, there was a thawing from inmates.

However, on the final night, I witnessed the single greatest act of humility I have ever seen. Picture this scene: In a maximum-security prison gymnasium, dozens of inmates sit in chairs spread out all over the gym in a horseshoe formation. The lights are out, relaxing music is playing. None of the inmates know why they are there. Then, on the center of the basketball court, a place where countless brutal beatings had happened over the years, three men appear in clothes meant to evoke biblical times. They are sitting

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in chairs while another man, also dressed in biblical clothes, is at their feet. This man is unmistakable by his hair and beard; it is Jesus. The room goes deathly quiet.

As all of us inmates watched, the man dressed as Jesus washed the bare feet of the three “disciples” in the chairs. Then, the lights in the gym came on and the nearly forty volunteers came out from behind us. Some were carrying bus tubs, while others were carrying water pitchers and towels. Then, one by one, the volunteers went up to each inmate, removed their shoes and socks, and washed their feet.

For a little added context, touching another man’s feet in a maximum-security prison can get you killed. Not that night, though. In prison, crying was perceived as weakness. However, it was hard to enforce that code when everyone was doing it. There was not a dry eye in the room as each inmate experienced the most selfless act of service. The Holy Spirit broke every man in the room. It was amazing to witness. After the volunteers were done washing the inmates’ feet, the inmates told the volunteers to sit in the chair so they could perform the same act of humility and service on them.

It was one of the most profound experiences of my life. I received a clarity of thought that shut out all other noise, leaving me only with a renewed sense of peace and of purpose.

Participating in that retreat came at just the right time for me. I was going to need all the spiritual guidance I could get after the news I received from my attorney regarding my writ of habeas corpus. I had recently learned that Judge Snipes was playing games with my case. *Playing games* in the sense that he was violating the law to make sure I could not be granted a new sen-

tencing trial, which is what we won from our evidentiary hearing the previous year.

My new counsel, Chip Lewis, had been advocating for me in the way I'd hope for. But Judge Snipes was still on the bench, still holding my fate in his hands, and still taking an intense interest in keeping me behind bars.

Snipes, Chip discovered, was willing to violate the law by apparently lying to the Court of Criminal Appeals to ensure that I did not receive any relief. Snipes revealed his deep personal bias towards me in conversations with the Magistrate he appointed, April Smith. Magistrate Smith, so shocked by this unprecedented and unethical move by Snipes, contacted my counsel, Chip.

I wish I could tell you I was surprised when I read Chip's motion to recuse Judge Snipes from my trial. Keep in mind, the Applicant referred to in the motion is **Me**.

Judge Snipes' actions violated the law, specifically Chapter 54 of the Texas Government Code, and his own order. He failed to review Magistrate Smith's actions—but more importantly he failed to even consider the evidence in the Applicant's writ, evidence that convinced his own Magistrate that the Applicant deserved a new punishment hearing, before passing judgment and signing the State's proposed findings almost as soon as they were filed.

Judge Snipes Informed Magistrate Smith of his Explicit Bias Against the Applicant.

*Judge Snipes informed her that no matter what she had learned or resolved he would not review it, **and would simply deny relief no matter what.** Judge Snipes' bias*

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is driven home by the fact that **he did not read the record of the hearing** or allow the Magistrate to file her findings before making his decision to sign the State's findings the day after they filed them. Judge Snipes' use of all caps and exclamation marks in his email back to the State is very telling of the **deep personal bias he has against the Applicant** and subject matter in this case.

After her conversation with Judge Snipes, Magistrate Smith called writ counsel and informed writ counsel... the trial judge, Michael Snipes, should be recused from presiding over this case because **his impartiality can reasonably be questioned; he has demonstrated a personal bias and prejudice concerning the subject matter, the Applicant, and the matter in controversy; he has improperly expressed an opinion concerning the merits of the matter in controversy; and he has refused to follow the law.**

...The Applicant's Motion to Recuse Trial Court Judge Michael Snipes, and after due consideration, said motion is hereby **GRANTED**.

IT IS THEREFORE ORDERED, ADJUDGED, AND DECREED that Judge Michael Snipes hereby **recuses himself** with respect to the above-captioned matter and **therefore is disqualified from proceeding as Trial Court Judge in this matter.**

In April of 2014, Judge Mike Snipes, a sitting criminal district court judge in Texas, accused in the motion that he "refused to follow the law," voluntarily signed Chip's motion to recuse

himself from my case. This made him the only judge I had ever heard of to get *caught* and disqualified for not following the law to deny due process to a criminal defendant in post-conviction. From the beginning of my case, in 2008, I argued to my trial counsel that Snipes was biased, especially given how we used to hang out together, the warrant he signed to search my home that lacked probable cause, and the comments he made about me on record as being the “Hannibal Lecter of burglaries.”

After Snipes’s recusal, my case was transferred to another judge, who took the findings from Magistrate Smith and agreed to send the recommendation to the Court of Criminal Appeals that I had, in fact, proved my case deserved a new sentencing trial. The district attorney of Dallas, seeing what happened to Snipes, got out of the way and did not oppose it this time.

With Snipes’s bias outed publicly, I was finally *vindicated*!

A few days after receiving the recusal news, I ran into JT and Mr. Winston down at the chapel, where I told them what happened. It was Mr. Winston who spoke first. “It makes one wonder how many times Snipes has done the same thing and gotten away with it. If you don’t have Chip—a high powered, Houston-based attorney who could care less about burning a relationship with Snipes in Dallas—there is little chance that a defendant in prison could stop someone like Snipes from abusing his absolute power on The Bench. It’s one of the flaws of the criminal justice system.”

I heard everything Mr. Winston was saying. I also heard what he was not saying. So, I addressed both. “No doubt, Mr. Winston. It’s not lost on me that there are discrepancies in the criminal justice system—along the lines of race, socio-economics, education, and family dynamics—that feed people into courtrooms of biased judges, like Snipes. I was fortunate my family had the connections

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to get Chip. My eyes have definitely been opened to some of those inherent flaws in the system.”

“West, the truth is Snipes was covering up his own mess. He had to lie to the Court of Criminal Appeals. It is truly refreshing to see Chip call out Snipes’s unlawful actions and hold him accountable. Snipes covered up an illegal warrant he signed, which had no probable cause. Then, he severely prejudiced the jury with his incendiary and biased commentaries, as well as his rulings from his all-powerful position on The Bench. A judge holds tremendous sway with jurors. Few would think to question the integrity or legitimacy of the person society has entrusted to weigh facts and evidence. There can be no doubt, the jury *does not* sentence you to life in prison for property crimes were it not for Snipes putting his thumb on The Scales of Justice!” Mr. Winston said, with a look of disgust on his face.

Then JT jumped in. “I tell you, West. I’ve seen it all in Dallas, so it doesn’t surprise me. Back in the 60s, we had a bunch of Dallas cops on the take. We had a few judges on the take, too. Snipes is par for the course, if you ask me. Here’s what I think you should do...” he paused long enough for Mr. Winston and me to look at each other while we waited for him to finish his sentence. JT was used to owning the floor. “I think you should forgive him and move on. It’s the Christian thing to do.”

I was not sure what his old reformed-mobster mind was thinking. I shook my head in refusal. “No way! I came to the chapel to talk to Ray about it,” I told them, regarding my meeting with the AA volunteer in the chapel that day. “This thing has me so off balance. I just don’t understand why Snipes did it.”

Without hesitation, JT said, “*Because he can.* That’s the only reason any person in power needs to do anything.”

JT was a wise old man. His answer made sense, too. About that time, Ray came into the chapel. I shook Mr. Winston and JT's hands and told them I'd see them later. Ray could see something was bothering me. "What's up, Damon? You look disturbed."

Ray was sharp, but you had to be sharp if you're bringing an AA meeting into a maximum-security prison; the guy gets lied to more than the police do. "I've got some stuff on my mind. Got a minute?"

He put his arm around me, and we walked over to the chalkboard where no one else could hear us. "Talk to me," he said, in his thick, Boston accent.

I told him everything about the Snipes situation, from when I met him in the late '90s until he signed his own recusal. "I'm so angry with him, Ray. I was right the whole time. I can't even think straight, I'm so mad."

"Must be nice to be able to sit up on your throne and judge people. Where's your humility, Damon?" he said, as his smile faded into a look of disapproval.

"What do you mean, Ray? I didn't do anything to Snipes. I'm the victim here."

"Forgiveness is a two-way street, Damon. How many people have you wronged that forgave you? You have to be able to forgive equally. That's what we do in recovery. We keep our side of the street clean."

"But I'm not ready to let go of this!"

"Then you need to work a personal inventory to get rid of this resentment. Otherwise, I guarantee you will lose your recovery over this and probably get drunk or high."

"That sounds extreme, Ray. I'm pissed. But I am not thinking about using."

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He reminded me that resentments are the number one reason why people relapse and that fear, in its many forms, is the primary force behind our resentments. Resentments are like drinking poison and hoping the other person dies. He wagered Snipes didn't know or care about the way I felt. "He's living rent free inside your head right now. Come on, let's get him out and run him through your personal inventory," Ray said, as he picked up the piece of chalk.

A personal inventory is one of the main tools in a program of recovery. The Big Book of AA says, "A business which takes no regular inventory usually goes broke. Taking a commercial inventory is a fact-finding process." The same is true for us humans. If we do not take a regular inventory, we can find ourselves bankrupt spiritually and emotionally.

In the program of recovery, we believe there are three basic instincts which control most (if not all) human behaviors. Our ***social instinct*** (self-esteem, need for community, to belong), our ***security instinct*** (your ambitions, your financial earning ability) and our ***sex instinct*** (not promiscuity, but our need to having intimate relationships—including sexual, which when used the correct way is a very natural and beautiful thing).

Ray drew three columns on the board, one for each instinct. He asked the same question each time. Did Snipes affect this instinct, and how? As we went through the inventory, it became apparent as to why I resented Snipes so much.

"Yes to all three, Ray." I ran through my inventory. "Because I'm going to always be an ex-con who got a life sentence. It affects my social instinct because I'll never be accepted in society. Same for my security instinct because, with my background, no one will

ever hire me for any job that pays well. Yes, to sex instinct, too. No one will ever want to get into a relationship with me.”

As I made my case for each column, Ray put a check mark in all three. Admittedly, I felt smugly justified. I had just proven my case for my resentment to Snipes. Ray could see the satisfaction on my face.

Then, he pulled out the rug from underneath me. “There is one more column I forgot to mention on your inventory, Damon.” Ray then drew a fourth column. In it he wrote: ***What role do I play?***

The voice in my head said *Oh no!* I felt the grip on my resentment slipping away, and I did not like it one bit. In this honest and fearless inventory, Ray gave me the chalk to write the role in which I played with Snipes. As I wrote out my role, my righteous indignation slipped away with each stroke on the board.

I was a drug addict, who broke the law, and became a serial burglar and thief. I became the leader of an organized crime ring that stole my victims’ property and their sense of security in a selfish pursuit of meth. I violated the social contract, which meant that I had to pay a price for my actions. That debt is paid in a courtroom, which is where I landed after my arrest. The door of that courtroom read: “Criminal District Court Seven, the Honorable Michael Snipes presiding.”

Having worked personal inventories with countless alcoholics and addicts, Ray understood the gravity of this moment. He knew that I finally accepted *total* accountability for *all* my actions. Moreover, he knew I was finally free, provided I worked

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my inventory each time I had a resentment against a person, an institution, an event in life, or any situation. This was my path to freedom.

In recovery, there's an axiom under which we live: *whenever I'm disturbed, there's something wrong with me*. I play a role in all of my problems with others. The role I play is what I'm searching for when I work my personal inventory because it is the only thing I can fix, the only thing I can control, and the only thing about my problem that I can change.

"Damon, this entire situation is your fault. You did all of those things that brought you into his courtroom. Had you not played your role, Snipes has no power to do what he did."

All my anger was removed. With it, my fears that were attached to the anger were also removed. In their place was acceptance and peace. "I get it. I truly do. Thank you for sharing this valuable tool with me. I feel like a huge weight has been lifted," I told Ray, sincerely.

"All we can do in life is keep our side of the street clean. You can't worry about what Snipes or anyone else does with their side of the street. You will never know why Snipes acted the way he did. Who knows, he could have personal struggles he's dealing with or suffer from the same *malady* we do? The opposite of resentment is forgiveness. Pray for Snipes, forgive him, and move on."

As if I needed any more confirmation, Ray and JT both delivered the same message: forgive. One man was a reformed murderer who represented my Christian faith, and the other man was a recovering alcoholic and drug addict who represented my program of recovery. Faith and recovery, the two most important pillars in my life, aligned perfectly.

Damon West

From then on, I plugged every resentment I had into my personal inventory. One by one, I discovered the role I played in each. And, one by one, I removed all resentments from my life. I discovered a freedom unlike anything I had ever experienced. I had no enemies. This did not mean I could not be someone else's enemy, only that I chose to no longer carry around resentments, fear and hate inside me. It was a spiritual goal, to keep my side of the street clean.

I was confident, if I worked my program of recovery, I could find serenity and remain sober.

Reflections

There are many places in which my principles overlap with the tenets of AA. The principles of each aren't based in science the way advising someone to eat green vegetables for eye health is. Instead, my principles are ways in which I've kept myself sober, handled conflict and adversity, and improved myself in many ways. More so, not living by these principles led me down dark paths. Working an inventory isn't a guarantee that you'll come away with clarity of thought or that your situation in life will improve. What I can say with certainty is that it has made me a calmer, happier, more clear-headed person, and before I take that inventory, my head is closer to that territory that used to lead me to bad choices.

That, to me, is the genius of the twelve steps, and what I aspire for my principles to also be—guidance for people in the throes of addiction, but also just sound advice for anyone trying to live their best self.

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I heard someone once say at a twelve-step meeting that one of the most important roles in society was a sanitation worker. Without sanitation workers, our streets would literally be filled with trash. All of society would break down as a result because a civilized society cannot exist with trash in its streets. In your life, you are your own sanitation worker. If you don't clear out your personal, spiritual, and emotional trash, you will also break down.

CHAPTER 16

REMEMBER WHEN YOU SUCCEEDED

Take Time to Celebrate the Wins

December 10, 2023

“We don’t use the word *try* because that word means nothing. You’re either going to do it or you’re not. Pay attention to the people who use that word often. They are full of excuses. All that word does is give people a way out. It’s a *powerless* word!”

My good friend, Randy Glenn, is passionate about life in general. It’s one of the things I love most about him. Full speed no matter what he’s doing. We met when he brought me in to speak to his company, Extreme Exteriors, in Abilene, Texas. Since then, he has referred me to dozens of other business owners to speak about the resilient mindset of being a coffee bean.

We hit it off as friends right away. What I think drew me to him was his pull-himself-up-by-the-bootstraps back story and his no-excuses attitude for everything in life. From my very privileged upbringing, I used every excuse under the sun to avoid accountability. Once everything was gone, I had to rely on grit, resilience, and self-will to get through life, and since then I’m drawn to others who do the same.

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Whenever I pass through Abilene, I always stay at his home. His wife, Mikea, and daughter, Lanier, have become like family with my family. On this night, we were talking about business and life. I was telling Mikea and him that I was writing another book, but I was having difficulty getting motivated. Hence the conversation about the word *try*.

“Time is my problem. I have too much on my plate,” I replied.

“Then maybe you need to remove some things from your plate,” Randy offered. “Start saying no to other things that do not meet your goals. You must understand, when you say *yes* to something, you’re saying *no* to a lot of other things. That’s why people don’t get anything done in life. They’re too busy *trying* to do everything.”

I had no idea *try* was such a loaded word, but had I not heard something similar in my youth? It reminded me of when Yoda said to a young Luke Skywalker, “Do or do not; there is no try.”

“You’re right, of course. I just have to figure out how to get it done with my intense speaking schedule,” I said, looking around the room for acceptance of my answer. Which, of course, there was none.

I would put my travel schedule up against anyone else’s, as the majority of my life is spent on the road. By my estimation, I’m on the road, giving keynote speeches, almost three hundred days of the year. Do not misunderstand this as a complaint, either. Especially from where I came from—serving life in a maximum-security prison—I cannot believe I *get* to have this much impact and do this for a living. But still, it made for a not-so-ideal atmosphere for writing.

For me, writing is a process. Except for *The Locker Room*, all four of my previous books I’ve written were mostly done from

my home, where I would wake up in the same place each morning (I write better and am more creative in the mornings), drink the same coffee, write at the same desk...you get the picture. Writing on planes and in hotel rooms has always proven to be difficult because I struggle with getting into the same mindset I was in when I put the pen down the previous day. That lack of continuity and clarity in my writing, I told them, was my excuse for not writing another book.

As a business owner, Randy saw my dilemma as an issue of needs versus wants. My main business in life was my speaking. It provided me with the resources to do all the other things in life, like take care of my family, run my foundation, create other family businesses, and volunteer in prisons. Did I really need another book?

It was Mikea, however, who asked the question. "You're killing me with the suspense. What's the new book about?"

"Yeah," Randy said. "Fit it on a bumper sticker." Gotta love Randy's phrases.

"I'm making it a hybrid memoir and self-help book. Like *The Change Agent* and *How to Be a Coffee Bean* combined." I explained to her how each chapter will be about a principle in which I live and then I'll tell the story behind the principle. "I have been struggling with getting motivated to do it. *I need help*," I admitted, saying the three hardest words for a human to utter out loud.

Sometimes, the motivators need motivation.

Mikea thought about that for a second. "Well, the good news is that you've done it before so you know it can be done. And you did it with a lot less resources than you have now. How did you get *The Change Agent* published so quickly after prison?"

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That's when the proverbial lightbulb went on in my head. Sometimes, we just needed to be reminded of a time when we approached tough tasks differently because we *had to*. A time when we first began our journey and there was no other option but to get it done. A time when we succeeded.



While I was in prison, I kept a diary. It wasn't something I wrote in every day—only on the days I felt inspired to write. By the time I walked out of that dungeon, after all of those years, I had filled up several composition books.

When I got out of prison, in 2015, I began building my new life. I had a job, lived in my parents' spare bedroom, went to my recovery meetings, and started speaking locally around Southeast Texas. I even had a few friends who were waiting for me when I returned home from prison. Aaron Davis, Gabe Abshire, Chris Swanson, and Brian Guidry—all childhood friends—have no idea how much their love and acceptance of me meant after all the mistakes I had made. Rebuilding a life that you've burned to the ground will reveal who is truly in your corner.

Sometime in 2017, I began playing with the idea of writing a book. I started converting those journal pages into a Word document. It was a slow go, but I had nothing but time on my hands.

Then, a guy named Jeff Boyd changed my life with a phone call. Jeff and I were good friends going back to our fraternity days in Lambda Chi Alpha at North Texas. He was one of those friends who stayed in my corner and would communicate with me while I was in prison. So much so that the day I returned home from prison, I discovered that he had shipped a bunch of clothes to my parents' house so that I would have a wardrobe waiting on me.

In this post-prison conversation, I told him I was going to begin writing a book using some of my old diary entries. He was intrigued and asked if I could email him some of the entries I had transcribed. So I sent him what I had.

A few weeks later, I received an email from a guy named Alex Glass. Alex was a friend of Jeff's and a literary agent in Manhattan. Jeff had shared my diary with him. Alex was intrigued and wanted to know more about my ideas for a book based on my diary. I told him, "Honestly, I don't know exactly what the book would look like. All I know is that I need to go live out some better chapters because the story I have to tell today is not compelling. I haven't earned back my place in society yet after all the mistakes I made, but I absolutely will."

I told Alex about my twelve-step program of recovery. What solidified our friendship and future working relationship was that he, too, was in recovery. Every person I have ever met who truly worked a program was a good person who made good choices. We all apply the same four spiritual principles, from the Big Book, to every decision we make: unselfishness, honesty, purity, and love.

Alex told me to continue living my story, and when I was ready, he would find a publisher for my book. We stayed in touch, as I would update him on things that would happen. "Keep writing," he would always tell me.

In 2018, Alex began walking me through writing a book proposal. It was such a complex and frustrating process. I think the correct word would actually be that it *intimidated* me. So much of what went into a proposal exposed my weaknesses and made me feel like an imposter. When we got to the part about my social media presence, it was laughable. "Fill in the stuff you can, Damon. It will be OK," he would assure me.

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Picture this scene. I am still living in my parents' spare bedroom during this time. My girlfriend (and future wife), Kendell, is sitting up in my bed with her laptop open, while I'm at a makeshift table next to her (I moved in a seat from the dining room so I could write on my nightstand). We are going through my social media platforms, looking for any post or video that had a lot of likes or views. The really exciting posts were when one actually got a thousand views. I remember there were even a few posts that got, like, eight hundred likes. We would high-five on those. In the moments when your dream is bigger than your current situation, you take time to celebrate the wins wherever you can.

The proposal was a total bust. After about a dozen rejections by publishers, I began accepting the fact that it wouldn't happen. Then, Alex called with the news. "We got a yes. Post Hill Press, a division of Simon & Schuster, will publish it. Congratulations, Damon. You did it."

"We did it, Alex. This was a team win. Thank you for believing in me."

In March of 2019, *The Change Agent* came out and it did incredibly well. My fears about being judged for my past mistakes were *mostly* unfounded, as the response to it was overwhelmingly positive. So many people, I would discover, were looking for inspiration.

I also learned that a robust speaking platform was a great way to sell books. Back then, I would drive with books to sell from the back of my car, and I would ship books in checked luggage on flights. It was a constant grind, which I thoroughly enjoyed.

The Change Agent also opened a lot of people's eyes to the realities of life in a maximum-security prison. From members of

the Texas Parole Board to people living in other countries, I kept receiving feedback about how informative the book was.

Speaking of the parole board, in the book I talked about the lead voter on my parole vote that got me out of prison, Lynn Ruzicka. Lynn read it and reached out to me. No longer a parole voter, Lynn was teaching criminal justice at the University of Houston Downtown (UHD). In August of 2019, she invited me to speak to her college class. I jumped at the opportunity because, selfishly, I just wanted to hug Lynn for voting me out of prison after only seven years on a life sentence.

After my presentation that day, I was approached by a man from the back of the classroom. He introduced himself as Dr. Michael Cavanaugh. He was the professor in charge of hiring adjunct faculty at UHD. "Lynn tells me you recently graduated with a master's in criminal justice. Is that true?" he asked.

"Yes, sir. I graduated a few months ago. Graduated with all As," I said proudly, leaving out the fact that my undergraduate degree from North Texas, exactly twenty years prior, was about a 1.85 GPA. I was obviously in different places in life when I got each degree.

Then, Dr. Cavanaugh shocked me with what he asked. "How would you like to teach our prisons class at UHD? I can't think of a more qualified person on the planet."

In 2020, I became an adjunct professor of criminal justice at University of Houston Downtown. I made sure every student received a complimentary copy of *The Change Agent* so that they would have access to the stories within it. The term papers they would write about it were incredibly insightful, too.

In the years since, *The Change Agent* has spread like wildfire in prisons all over America. Incarcerated men and women, and

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their families, reach out to me to tell me about the impact it has had on them.

We don't remember our first accomplishments. Most of us learn to walk forgetting that up until that point we only knew how to crawl. Remembering, though, that you have succeeded in the past can often be the most powerful tool you have to getting beyond *try* and onward to *do*.

Results don't lie, and success leaves clues. Case in point, the book you are reading right now was born from the conversation and the principle in this chapter.

Reflections

With every book, I do come back to the feeling of being an imposter. There are people who are supremely confident in all that they do, and more power to them. I'm not like that. I still get butterflies before a keynote. I still stare at a blank page and it stares back at me.

What remembering past success does for me is it gets me past those anxieties faster, helps me focus on the job at hand. By the time my next thought of being an imposter comes back up, I've already finished another chapter, or my keynote is done and people from the audience are coming up to me and telling me how the coffee bean message has helped them in their lives.

That's another vital part of remembering your past successes—listen to the people when they tell you that you've done well. If you're trying your best, and putting in the work, then you're not an imposter, you're just preparing for your next accomplishment.

Lastly, your world is shaped by your experiences and the expectations you put on the outcome. Managing expectations—in your goals and in other people—is all about being realistic, to avoid disappointment or frustration. Set up principles for managing your expectations. Here are a few of mine.

- 1) Understand limitations—This can be resources, ability, or time. Operate from a place of reality.*
- 2) Set achievable goals—Ambiguity is your enemy. Be specific on what you want to achieve.*
- 3) Be amendable to change—Always be flexible. If your original process isn't working, then reevaluate. Be flexible.*

CHAPTER 17

HAVE FAITH OVER FEAR

Trust the Process

The Backstory: 2015 (Part 1)

I have observed in my own life that the closer I get to a breakthrough moment, the more adversity comes my way. Sometimes, it feels as though I am under attack from a dark, spiritual force that wants to prevent me from achieving a goal. This adversity is what I was feeling in 2015, the year I made parole.

Parole is the dream of every man and woman who has ever done time. It's your chance to get out. Your chance to start a new life outside of the prison walls. Your poor choices landed you there; parole is the opportunity to get out and make better choices.

A denial would mean my next opportunity for parole would be the subsequent year. This one-year set-off could become a constant loop you get stuck in, however. I saw guys in prison who had ten or more set-offs. Almost to a man, those guys lost hope long ago.

Admittedly, with the length of my sentence, and the hopeless, broken men walking around me each day, it was difficult to be

all-in on my first parole. *Hopeful* for the best but expecting the worst was where my family and I were as we approached the first parole vote.

And, while hope is essential, it is not a strategy. Preparing for parole was something I began doing when I walked into prison because a successful reentry begins that day. The brand I built was that of an honorable man, a man who owned his past mistakes, was truly remorseful, and worked to become the best version of himself. A man who helped others. A man who worked a program of recovery one day at a time. Spiritually, mentally, and physically, I was ready to stand before parole and ask for a second chance.

My mother and I worked tirelessly to prepare a parole packet to show the parole board all of the changes I had been able to make. She and I would talk for hours on the prison phone and then we would rely on the Postal Service to courier our ideas back and forth. I must have reviewed a hundred parole packets from other men in prison before I came up with a format and design that was an amalgamation of the best ones.

The heavy lifting done, all that was left to do was wait for my name to be called. That happened on March 25, 2015. I was working in the chapel that day when Chaplain Vontz came in with a huge grin on his face and said, “West, they just called your name on the radio. The parole board is here to interview you.”

What should have been music to my ears was more like a punch in the stomach because I felt like I wanted to throw up. Fear engulfed me in that moment. It was like when I used to have butterflies before a football game, only worse. My entire future was going to be decided in one interview, the biggest of my life. After I processed what he told me, I took a few deep breaths and said a prayer before I gathered my things for the parole meeting.

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This calmed me down, as it put the interview outcome into its proper place—not on my line.

Faith over fear. Let God do His thing, and I would focus on the words that came out of my mouth. When I entered the cramped office, I saw a woman sitting behind a desk with a stack of files next to her. In front of her was a copy of my parole packet. I closed the door behind me and waited for her to give me permission to sit in the chair directly in front of the desk. “Ms. Smith” introduced herself. We did not shake hands.

“Ms. Smith, thank you for seeing me today. I hope I can satisfactorily answer all of your questions.”

“I hope so, too, Mr. West,” she replied.

She told me she had been doing this for many years and never in that time had she seen a file like mine. She noted I possessed both a unique set of circumstances in my case and a unique support system.

We talked about my crime first, the details of my case, and my thoughts about the things I had done. She commented on the fact that I had received way too much time for my crime. I had not expected that. It did not diminish the responsibility and guilt I felt for the things I had done, though.

“Ms. Smith, there is not a day that goes by that I don’t think about the pain, hurt, suffering, and loss I have caused so many. I take full responsibility for my crimes and all the collateral damage that resulted from it. The addict who committed those crimes is not the man you are speaking with today because I’m in recovery,” I told her.

She admitted she didn’t see many people like me. I told her I understood I was very fortunate, that my family and my support group were unbelievable. As an example, I told her my parents

had visited me more than 150 times. Friends and other family members, I added, had made more than 50 additional visits.

"There's no way I'm responsible for the changes I've made. God has carried me through this whole experience. I know He will continue to do so as long as I am humble and serve others."

"You've certainly done well in here," she acknowledged, flipping through my packet. "I see you've taken a ton of correspondence Bible classes, taken the HVAC trade, cognitive intervention, and every chapel program you could." She even mentioned that I tutored inmates and taught them how to read and write. As she started to close my file, she paused and asked, "Mr. West, if you could be anything in life, tell me what that would be in just one word?"

"Useful! I just want to be useful."

I learned that word from working my program of recovery. Once we become useful in recovery, we are no longer the useless person who lives in their addiction. Besides, at the core of being human, everyone really wants two things: to belong and to be loved.

She told me my file would be sent to Huntsville for a vote and that I would have an answer as soon as the voters got to my file. Then she smiled, concluded my interview, and said, "Good luck."

On May 1, a little over a month later, my mother revealed to me on a phone call that I had made parole. The nightmare was finally over. I was going home. First, however, I had to make it off the Stiles Unit safely. You see, once the inmates find out you've made parole, this is the opportunity for anyone who has ever had a problem with you to play the spoiler in your life. A person with a parole vote cannot get into a fight because a fight is a major

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case. A major case is automatic cause to revoke your parole before you ever get out of prison.

I had been accepted to a drug treatment program, which would send me to a minimum-security pre-release facility for the last six months of prison. The prison bus would pick me up in exactly two weeks. That meant for the final two weeks of prison at Stiles, I could not go to the chow hall, the rec yard, or anywhere else where someone with a grudge could find me. The only place I went to was the chapel for work and back to my pod. Rationing the commissary food in my locker, I finally made it to May 15 when my transport bus arrived.

The guard came to my bunk to escort me off the Stiles Unit forever. Admittedly, the guard and I were still on point, as the threat to me would not be officially over until I was in the transport area. As we walked from the dorms, I tried to soak it all in. I thought to myself as I looked around, *How did you survive, Damon?* It was a rhetorical question because I knew God carried me through there just as He carried me through all of the toughest times in life. When we got in front of the chow hall and crossed over to B-side of the prison (the more dangerous side where I once lived with the lifers), I saw an inmate running at me. At first it startled both the guard and me, until I saw who it was.

Sabur, my former cellmate, was on a full sprint and calling my name. I asked the tense guard if I could go say goodbye to my brother. He told me to “make it quick.” Sabur and I embraced, and I could see tears in his eyes, which made me tear up too. “Man, West, I’m so happy for you. I’m happy for your family. I just need to know something before you get on that bus.”

“What is it, Sabur?”

“When you get out, are you going to talk about what you saw in here? The stuff we talked about in here?”

I knew what he was talking about. I had learned so much from Sabur about race, disparities in the system, and social justice. Having never been Black, it was impossible for me to understand why prison was so disproportionately Black. He taught me about a different America than the one I grew up in. And I could not unsee what I saw.

I looked at my brother, and said, “Sabur, I will. When I get on my feet and establish myself, you know I will.”

What he said next caught me off-guard. “Good! Sometimes, they lock up the *right* guy.”

I stuttered for the correct response and finally said, “What do you mean by that?”

“Look at you, West. White, middle-class, well-spoken, highly educated, with two parents waiting for you out there.” He waved his hand in the direction of the gate, the direction of freedom. “*People will listen to you.* You were chosen for all of this. Don’t forget us.”

We hugged and I told him like I told my other friends that I would reach out as soon as I touched down in the free world. Then, I caught up to the guard, went to the transport area, stripped out of my prison clothes, put on a white jumpsuit and got shackled before getting on my transport to the In Prison Therapeutic Community (IPTC) at the Kyle Prison Unit in Kyle, Texas.

As the prison transport pulled away from Stiles, I remember a nervous excitement. My clock was ticking backwards. In exactly six months, I would be a free man. That thought of being free also gave me some anxiety, especially regarding my fear of being alone the rest of my life. I had such a low self-worth.

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Reflections

I first heard the phrase “faith over fear” from Jon Gordon. Jon says fear and faith have more in common than the letter F they begin with. He says fear and faith both believe in a future that has not happened.

Fear was the negative future, while faith was the positive future. You have free will, so you are free to choose in whichever future you want. Jon always tells me to choose faith over fear.

Fear played a large part in my downfall as well as my redemption. When I was an addict and criminal, a big part of the underlying cause of both was a fear. I feared that people could see through me, that I was an imposter, so I masked that fear with the bravado that cocaine provides. On a primal level, I was afraid of what would happen when I ran out of drugs and had to still live my life, so I stayed high as much as I could.

Fear got me into prison, where real fear for my safety took over. But in recommitting myself to my faith, I not only overcame fear, I turned it to my advantage.

Now my fears came from a place of purpose, where I felt fearful that I would not be able to be as useful in this life as I hoped to be. I feared not being able to connect to people as deeply as I knew possible. Whereas before the fear only bred more fear, more insecurity, and worse decisions, now fear turned into reassurance that I could connect, I was being useful. Fear turned into a desire to keep moving forward, through adversity, to my better self.

Damon West



The Change Agent Prison Curriculum won the Governor's Award for Most Innovative Program in TDCJ. Pictured with me are the cocreators and my partners, Lisa and Rex Spain.



The first graduating class of The Change Agent Prison Curriculum was on June 27, 2022. In the front row, fourth from left, wearing a suit is Chaplain Amobi. Next to me, wearing a suit, is Director Carter. On the second row, far right, in white, is Raymond Ramirez, our currently incarcerated facilitator and one of the most valuable members of our team.

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"Mr. Winston" in a picture taken decades before I met him in prison. Photo courtesy of Mr. Winston's family.



Jerry Thomas "JT" Goad in a pic from the early '60s, during his Dallas mob days. Photo courtesy of JT's family.

Damon West



Speaking to soldiers at Fort Sill. For two years, I did engagements with the US Army, where I not only shared my message and story, but I would also do full-immersion training with them in the mornings. I did just about every exercise imaginable, including combat training.



Picking up my monthly travel permits. Because I was sentenced to 65 years in prison, I will serve the balance of that sentence—until 2073—on parole. Each month, I take a picture of me smiling at the parole office, showing my gratitude that I “get to” be on parole—as opposed to still being in prison.

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My mom and dad came to visit me over 150 times while I was in prison. Visitation is where I was able to repair the relationship I so damaged with them, by showing the man I was becoming inside those prison walls. This pic was from 2013.



My mom took this picture of me when I walked out of prison on November 16, 2015. A day I will never forget.

Damon West



Sunny morning at Dallas SWAT headquarters, donating gear to the angels who “rescued” me in 2008. The packs they carry have the white “Be a Coffee Bean” patch on them.



Of all the hats I wear in life, being a husband to Kendell and a stepfather to Clara are the two best.

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Director Christopher Carter. By far, one of the best leaders I've ever met—in any profession. I could not do what I do in the Texas Department of Criminal Justice without him believing in me. Eternally grateful to this man, whom I still call “Warden Carter.”

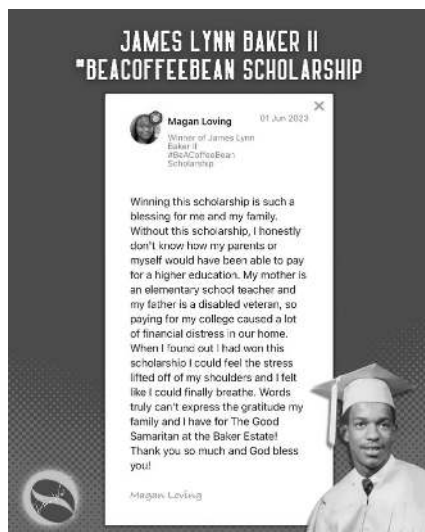


Smuggling hope to the currently incarcerated men in a Texas level-five maximum-security prison. Just like the prison where I did my time. Photo courtesy of TDCJ.

Damon West



Elf on the Shelf Day in the Hughes Unit maximum security prison. Easily one of the most emotional days I've ever spent inside a prison chapel. The kids getting the elves from their dads isn't just a core memory in their lives—it's a core memory for me as well. Photo courtesy of TDCJ.



A thank you letter from one of the Be a Coffee Bean Scholarship winners.

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Full circle moment. Introducing Dak Prescott and his wife, Sarah Jane “SJ” Prescott, to Vanessa Baker at Dak’s foundation gala. Dak and Sarah Jane have always been so supportive of my mission, so it was great to connect them to the sister of the man who first shared the coffee bean with me. Vanessa is a former Dallas Cowboys Cheerleader (DCC). Her sister, Vonciel, was on the first DCC squad in 1972. Photo courtesy of Jeremiah Jhass.



Kendell and I sponsor a 12U youth baseball team, in Lexington, SC. The team is called “Be a Coffee Bean.”

The coach of the team, and a father of one of the players, Alan Day, wrote me this about the team: “The field between the chalk lines is that pot of boiling water, and these boys change the environment by how they play and respond. The bottle of coffee beans is in the dugout for every game and each player was given a bean to put in their gear bag, just like Abe in the book. This is how we start every game: Lord’s Prayer followed by the chant.”

CHAPTER 18

PLAY THE TAPE OUT UNTIL THE END

The Long Game in Life

May 1, 2024

For years, I have been trying to connect with the men and women of the elite Dallas SWAT, to thank them for saving my life when they arrested me on July 30, 2008. As I have said to anyone who will listen, they didn't just *arrest* me that day, they *rescued* me that day. It's one of those goals in life that took longer than I expected. But, with all things, God's timing was perfect.

On a September morning, in 2023, fifteen years after they brought justice to me—I walked into Dallas Police headquarters so I could tell them my story. I began by saying “Thank you for saving my life.” Then, I told them about the guy they arrested that day—a bad guy, who was addicted to meth and became the ringleader of a crew that created victims all over Dallas. A guy who needed justice brought to him, which is what they did when they came in through the windows of that apartment on Holland Avenue.

I told them about meeting Muhammad in Dallas County jail, the message of the coffee bean he gave me, and what I've been able to do with that message—both in prison and after prison.

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I went over the incredible doors which have been opened to me to create positive change all over the world. Ultimately, I wanted them to see an example of someone who went through the criminal justice system, turned it around, and became a better person as a result. That way, they could see a small piece of proof in me that their jobs mattered.

When I told them about obtaining a master's in criminal justice, and becoming a professor at UHD, teaching Prisons in America, I got an approving chuckle out of the room. I think that was the tipping point where they realized this transformation in front of them was real.

One of the things I shared with them was that I always told my classes that law enforcement is one of the most important and most difficult jobs in this country. In fact, it's one of the only professions where almost every interaction starts off on negative footing; when people see a badge and a gun, they typically become closed off. We ask police officers to wear too many hats. We ask them to enforce laws, be a crisis counselor, a drug and alcohol counselor, a marriage counselor, and more. Life-and-death decisions are made in a matter of seconds in their extremely stressful jobs. And it was always the few bad cops that society focused on.

I always told my classes that society should do more to ensure the police have the resources to do all those jobs we ask of them. Moreover, it was asinine to say *defund the police*. That slogan was the poorest and most ignorant messaging I had ever heard. I lived in a world where there are no police; it's called prison.

In the end, I told SWAT I had been extremely blessed in this new life—the path they helped put me on—and that I wanted to share some of that with them. In an effort to *fund the police*, I purchased around \$20,000 of specific, new equipment they were

needing, so that they could have the resources to save other people and then go home safely to their families.

It's that last point that ties the Dallas Police most closely to my new life and my recovery. In a program of recovery, we're instructed to make a list of the people we have wronged through our addiction, and to make amends to them whenever possible, except when doing so would injure them. Every time the SWAT team puts on their gear and kicks down a door, they are putting their lives at risk. They use overwhelming force, not because of criminals like me who weren't violent, but for the ones who are, and they can't tell the difference often until it's too late. By thanking them, by sharing my story with them, and by supporting their work, my aim is to make amends for the day I put them all at risk.

It's also to not forget those who helped set me on the right path. That's the *long game*. It's not the first person who must be thanked, nor the last. It's everyone who has selflessly contributed to redeeming me and helping me become a person who lives with integrity. It's a long game, and even if they didn't know it when they were tossing a flashbang grenade into my apartment, they were a part of it.

Addicts in recovery have a keen understanding of the long game. I've never met one who couldn't tell you how long he or she was sober, but staying that way meant working the program. There's no such thing as passive sobriety for an addict. This is a lesson I learned quickly after prison.



It was December of 2016, and I had been out of prison for thirteen months. My friend and his wife invited me to a Christmas party that evening. Since getting out of prison, I had been in many

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situations where people were drinking around me and there were never any issues. Besides, Ray had a plan. In fact, he made sponsoring me conditional on following his plan. He said, “If you ever have a *thought* about drinking or doing drugs, promise me you will call me immediately.”

At the Christmas party that night, I was standing with my friend and his wife. We were casually talking when my friend’s wife was handed a glass of red wine. When the merlot glass passed in front of me, I remembered the smell of the wine penetrating my senses deeply. Once the wine was in her hand, I was transfixed on the glass, watching it go up to her mouth with each sip. The obsession with her glass of wine was so overpowering that I was no longer hearing the conversation around me. In fact, the only thing I heard was the voice in my head saying, *Get a glass of wine, Damon. Look how hard you’ve worked. You deserve to enjoy just this one glass tonight.*

When I snapped out of the trance, I remember hearing the noise of the party as if the volume had been turned up to the max. My breathing was off, and I began to sweat. My friend asked me if I was OK. “Yeah, yeah. I’m fine. Hey, listen. I need to get going. Thank you for inviting me tonight.” I shook his hand and took off. When I got into my car, I realized I was trembling. What in the hell just happened in there? I had never experienced something like that around alcohol. Well, I knew what to do and who could help, so I called Ray, just as I promised I would do if I ever thought about using again.

Ray answered with a question. “Hey, Damon. Everything OK?”

I told him everything was not OK, then I shared with him what I experienced. He started laughing through the phone. My first emotion was anger. “What are you laughing at, Ray? I almost blew my sobriety tonight.”

“Damon, you’re an alcoholic and an addict. You’re going to have these thoughts the rest of your life. Your brain has this thing called *euphoric recall*. It’s a defense mechanism to protect you from bad thoughts. Makes you only remember the good times, not the bad. Did you ever have fun when you were out there drinking and doing drugs? I sure did.”

To be honest, there were some good times in there. But I didn’t buy into the concept of euphoric recall. I had plenty of bad thoughts around my addiction, as evidenced by the fact I stole for drugs and went to prison.

He told me I had been out of prison long enough that I forgot how bad it was, which seemed odd because it had only been a year. “That’s why you have a program of recovery, Damon. It gives you tools so that you can live with your addictions and have a normal life. Your first tool was to call somebody. Congratulations on using your first tool. The next tool is to *play the tape out to the end*. To see where this decision to have one glass of wine will actually take you.”

Addiction, he said, was a three-part process. It began with a thought, which then became an obsession occupying space in our heads, until it became something physical, when we actually gave into the obsession and used again. Thought, obsession, physical.

“We gotta get the thought out of your head,” he stated. “For playing the tape out, I want you to imagine you’re back at the party. Now I want you to imagine you’re drinking the wine. You drinking it?”

I settled into my driver’s seat with my eyes closed and envisioned myself back at the party. This time, I gave into the craving I escaped ten minutes prior, and “drank” the wine. “I’m drinking it,” I told Ray.

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“Good. Now that you’re drinking again, what was your drink when you were in your addiction?”

Without hesitation, I said, “Bourbon. I loved bourbon.”

“Well, get a glass of bourbon now. Why are you drinking wine if you like bourbon?”

I wanted to say *because you told me to*. What I said instead was, “OK, I’m sipping my bourbon.”

“Now, Damon. Let’s get to the good stuff. What drugs did you do while you were boozing on your bourbon?”

Boozing? Who says *boozing* anymore?

“Cocaine. Bourbon and cocaine went together well,” I responded.

“Yes, they certainly do. Now, I want you to imagine you’re snorting coke,” he said.

To the uninitiated in the world of addiction, this conversation might sound like it’s taking a strange turn. To us addicts, this is how recovery works. People who have the same shared misery with drugs and alcohol share their experience, and through that they share strength and hope.

“OK,” I replied. “I’m snorting it.”

“Now that you’re doing drugs again, Damon. What was your drug of choice? What was the drug in your story that did you in?”

“Meth,” I answered, with a little more excitement than I expected. Probably a result of my mind beginning to get high and release endorphins at the thought of doing meth. I was feeling the anticipation I used to feel before I got high, but there was no meth around. OK, I was coming around on euphoric recall.

“That’s right! Meth. You were a meth head. Now, smoke your meth. That’s what the wine, the bourbon, and the cocaine were telling you. You didn’t want to drink wine tonight; you wanted to

smoke meth. The good stuff. That's what gave you the best high. Are you smoking it?"

I was looking at myself in my rearview mirror. My eyes were wide and I was sweating in a parked car, with the engine off in the month of December. I envisioned myself smoking that glass pipe again. "Yes. I'm smoking the meth."

"Tell me, Damon. How's parole going for you now that you're getting called in for a drug test?"

Damn! Immediately, the euphoric feeling ended, and the mood crashed. I stammered, saying, "Umm, I didn't think about parole."

Ray was on a roll now. "Addicts don't think about things like that. Our freedoms, our families, our jobs, other people. We give up our goals to meet our behaviors. You just gave up yours. What did parole say would happen if you violated your agreement?"

"I'm going back to prison. Probably for the rest of my life."

"Where are you now in your mind, Damon?"

"On the prison bus, chained to another human being. I just destroyed my life and my family again."

He spared no mercy. "Yes, you have. Those bus rides are awful, and you will be starving by the time you finally get to prison. Imagine yourself going to the chow hall. Tell me, Damon, what was the worst meal you ever ate in prison?"

No contest. I blurted out, "Pork noodle casserole." I didn't even know what was in that stuff. No one did.

"Now, see yourself going through the chow line, getting a big tray of pork noodle casserole. Have a seat at one of those metal tables and wash your pork noodle casserole down with that glass of wine you were wanting to have tonight. Because that's where that glass of wine will take you. Back to the chow hall *eating pork noodle casserole*."

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That hit me hard.

“You got it?” he asked.

“Yeah, yeah, I do. I totally get it. I see where the thought of the wine eventually took me.”

“Good. Once again, the program works but only if you work it. Keep working your recovery. Now, go back into that party and have a good time with your friends now that you’ve gotten the thought out of your head and played the tape out to the end. Call me anytime you need me,” he said, as he hung up the phone before I could say anything else.

I went back to the party.

No tool in recovery better illustrates why addicts must have a program of recovery. While we can take advice and support from family, from religious leaders, even from strangers, the steel bars holding up our sobriety are other addicts. Were I to have this conversation with my priest, he would have told me what he was taught to teach: pray. And prayer is great! I do it every day! But in moments of need, when an addict is trying to justify in their heads why it doesn’t always need to be the man takes a drink, the drink takes a drink, the drink takes the man, we need to hear from someone else who has been through the same hell and come back from it. That person isn’t telling us to pray, that person is jumping back down into the hole we are in and then helping us to build a ladder out. It’s why recovery and faith work parallel with one another to keep us sober.

Or, in other words, my priest has helped me through many a trial in my life, but my priest has never tasted pork noodle casserole. Other addicts have. I need both voices to keep playing the long game. Many times, people reach out to me and tell me that their loved one has “conquered” addiction because of their

faith in Christ. I caution them that if faith in Christ alone were enough to conquer addiction, there would be no addicts who are Christians!

Reflections

Playing the tape out until the end is an important practice in just about everything you do. Having the ability to see the results of a decision, past the point of the initial decision, is critical to success. Another way of looking at this principle is telling yourself, "If I do this, then _____ will happen."

Write it out, if necessary. Sometimes, writing out the long game is a great way to visualize the successes or failures—or both—that will be your outcome of a decision.

Not every principle fits neatly with every other principle. The concept of playing the long game in life and playing the tape out to the end in your thoughts doesn't go with what I learned from Ranger, who lived in the moment and taught me to "be where your feet are." In your house, one tool isn't going to fix everything. You need different tools for different tasks.

How I've come to reconcile when principles seem to clash is to bring in a third principle of remembering when I succeeded. I've developed healthier thought patterns to recognize where my head is at and what's needed to get it clear and focused. In that respect, I'm living in the moment, even if I'm also projecting myself forward mentally to get myself right.

CHAPTER 19

FINISH STRONG AND GET PHYSICAL

Healthy Body, Healthy Mind

The Backstory: 2015 (Part 2)

Having played sports all my life, I often dipped into my well of experiences from sports to interpret life. I would describe the final six months of prison not as the fourth quarter, but as a two-minute drill at the end of the fourth quarter. However, in this final two minutes, I was not trying to come from behind; rather, I was ahead, but I had to hold onto the ball and manage the clock well.

The Kyle Unit was a minimum-security prison with a fence you could easily climb over. However, no one was escaping because we had all just made parole and were on the way out in six months. Life on the Kyle Unit was a unique experience. No longer living in maximum-security prison, I, along with every man in there, had to make a serious course correction in dealing with day-to-day life. This was less of a drug-treatment program and more of a behavior-modification program. Its purpose, I had determined, was to detox us from prison and the abnormal thinking one must do to survive in such a place.

Upon arrival there, I was immediately taken to an orientation class. Right off the bat, each of us learned our release dates. Mine was November 16, 2015. You could feel the tension leave the room when each man was armed with the knowledge that this was really happening. Prison was finally over. Hearing my expiration date called out was a bit surreal. Each man had his ticket punched with only six months to go.

Once everyone had their release dates, the counselor got serious. He passed out a list of cardinal rules. These rules, if violated, would immediately revoke your parole and send you back to prison. On the top of this list was “No Fighting.” One of the other rules was no gang activity. Then the counselor told us one of the rules was to report any offenses you saw other offenders make, big or small. My jaw dropped. Snitching, as they called it in prison, was not only encouraged here, it was expected. A peer-driven prison environment where the inmates alerted the authorities on each other, much the way you would do in a civilized society, was about as aggressive of a detox program as there was. In maximum-security prison, I saw men who wore scars from their ears to their mouths for snitching. The scars said, *“What you’re hearing, you’re telling.”*

Back on Stiles, violence, or the threat of violence, was the glue that held prison together. This was true for maximum security. Here at Kyle, I’d learned the only force greater than violence was *freedom*. Freedom—or the threat of losing your freedom—is the most powerful motivator. It was the classic carrot (everyone here had an exit date) and stick (if you violated a serious enough rule, you’d lose your parole and go back to real prison) approach. For most men, it worked.

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That threat of losing your freedom had flipped the natural order. For example, the level of disrespect inmates showed towards each other at Kyle was difficult to measure. The smallest man in size or courage had now become equal to the deadliest man. The little guys—the preyed upon, the timid, the weak—now had power and stature they had no doubt prayed for when doing their time on more serious units. Their newfound currency was equal for once, and they appeared to be cashing in at every opportunity.

After living in an environment where the slightest accidental contact could be viewed as a declaration of war, it had been a crash course in humility to be bumped into, talked down to, and even called out by inmates you would have taken to the showers and beat mere months ago. Thankfully, I had a program of recovery that was predicated upon humility and grace.

I approached the In Prison Therapeutic Community (IPTC) at the Kyle Unit with the same focused intensity as the years I spent at Stiles. Because I had made physical fitness a pillar of my life years before, I was on track to walk out of prison in the best physical shape of my life. The real physical-fitness journey began for me at the same time I began working my program of recovery. Working through the Big Book of AA, I discovered the authors did not emphasize the importance of taking care of your physical body through regular exercise. So, I used my body as my gym. I understood the existential need to exercise and, if possible, train with weights. And, for the first time since I had been in prison, I was on a unit that actually had weights.

Throughout my prison experience, I ate as clean as possible in there because food is, basically, fuel. I wanted to put the best possible, the cleanest fuel in my body. Because my family

provided financial assistance to me in prison, I was one of the fortunate ones who could supplement my diet with healthier food options from commissary. My diet was low calories, low sugar, low carb, vegetables, and whatever protein I could get my hands on. I practiced eating to not be hungry, as opposed to eating to be full. My relationship with food began to change. I realized that hunger was a thought. If I could replace that thought of hunger with some other thought, then I did not eat as much.

In my opinion, to truly live in recovery, you must take care of your physical health, as well as your spiritual, emotional, and mental health. I continued to work my twelve steps. The only high I would feel there were the stakes with which these final six months represented. I wanted to thrive and finish strong. How much better of a man could I become with this last bit of time on the clock?

Of course, as I stated before, the closer you get to a goal, the more adversity comes your way. However, being a coffee bean taught me two things about adversity. First is that you're capable of way more than you *think* you are. Next is that adversity is never as bad as you *think* it will be. Many times in life, we allow *overthinking* to get in the way of *overcoming*. How you think matters more than just about anything else because your thoughts control your actions. And your voice—whether in your head or talking to yourself out loud—is the voice you will hear most your entire life.

On the evening of November 15, 2015, my final night in prison, I laid in my bunk, unable to sleep. This nervous anticipation was not like the one I felt when I left Stiles. This was more excitement. The excitement only a truly free man can feel. I survived prison because I could see myself in a better place. A

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place where my program of recovery allowed me to work through all my fears, resentments, doubts, and problems. A place where I took control of my physical health and actually allowed the prison experience to preserve me, getting in the best shape of my life. I finally became that better man my mother made me promise I would be.

Leaving prison is just like you see in the movies. They dress you in free-world clothes, escort you to the front gate, open the gate, and then you take the biggest step of your life into the free world. On November 16, I took that giant step. I could see my parents waving from the parking lot.

What happened next is a story I have mainly shared only with faith-based audiences. As I took off running for my parents in the parking lot, a voice in my head said, “Stop!” Which I did. Then, the voice said, “Turn around.” I obeyed, because I knew that voice was Christ talking to me. Just as He had spoken to me in the shower of Dallas County jail the day I was sentenced to life in prison. He spoke to me for years inside those prison walls. He was now speaking to me seconds after my release.

As I looked at the fence and barbed wire around the guard gate, the voice said to me, “Damon, I put you through all of this for a reason. You are going to work for me now. I am going to give you one of the most incredible redemption stories. It’s how I show I’m real. In return, you will honor Me by always showing up when I call you. *Use the gifts I’m giving you to help others.* You are a vessel. The minute it becomes about you, this is where you will be coming back to because I can find another vessel. Let’s get to work!”

As I turned around and ran to my parents in the parking lot, I could envision the game clock ticking down to 0:00. It was over. We *won!* I was finally going home. When I got to the car,

my mom asked why I stopped. My mother is a very spiritual person, so she understood the conversation in my head and told me, "Listen to God!"

Seven years, three months, and eighteen days after Dallas SWAT rescued me on July 30, 2008. I had emerged the best version of me. Prison was a spiritual awakening. Now that the change was made in me, I was ready to go change the world. Like a coffee bean.

On the car ride home, in the backseat of my parents' car, looking out the window, that familiar, almost comfortable voice of fear was in my head, whispering thoughts in my ear. Again, it was that same thought about being alone. I thought: *Who would possibly love me after all this? And, if I could find a person who could see past all my baggage and mistakes to love me, what would her family think of me?*

Looking back on that day, I'm reminded of the Yiddish saying, *Man plans, and God laughs.*

Reflections

One of the many things people in recovery get back is a sense of autonomy over their bodies. When you remove drugs and alcohol from the bloodstream, you eventually get back the natural ebb and flow of how your body feels. I see numerous people in recovery rediscovering running, or lifting weights, or team sports. Exercise provides a sense of accomplishment, a refuge from stress, and all the endorphins a person needs.

Regular exercise, strength and conditioning training, and eating healthy is great living advice for every person—not just people in recovery. You only get one body in this life.

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If you're not as physically healthy as you want to be, make the change now. It all starts with one small step, one decision and one day to change your life. Try not to think about the end results; those can be intimidating thoughts. Focus on today. Start with creating goals each day that you can hit. Remember, keeping the promises to yourself builds confidence.

One of the best pieces of advice I've ever heard about diet and food is that it basically comes down to math. As in, calorie math. Taking in less calories than I burned off has always been the math that worked for me in order to get to a desired weight and physical appearance. However, I personally do not believe all calories are equal, so I weigh that into the equation, too.

There is no "one size fits all" when it comes to your physical health. Find the physical program that works for you and get physical!

CHAPTER 20

RHYTHM VS. BALANCE

You Can Have It All in Life

May 24, 2024

“Damon, it’s time you took a break and brought your beautiful girls out to the lake with us. I follow you on social media. It makes me tired seeing all the days you’re on the road.”

Traci Horton is one of those friends who has no problem speaking up and saying what’s on her mind. She has the biggest heart and loves seeing her friends succeed. I met Traci, her husband, Randy, and their son, Matthew, right before the pandemic. Since then, our families have become close.

At one point, I was able to help Matthew get into his twelve-step program of recovery, in which he has flourished. He’s become like a little brother to me. Watching his spiritual journey inspires me. But that’s how the program works. We help each other by being examples of living in recovery.

Traci and Randy have done a lot for our family, too. A few years ago, Kendell set out on her own entrepreneurial journey. She walked away from being a nurse practitioner and started two different, female-owned companies with her mother, Sherri. One

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is a construction and development company, and the other is a dirt and materials company. Both are based in Southeast Texas, where we live.

It's been really neat to watch Kendell and her family build true family businesses. Kendell's brother, Trent, is the COO for both. Trent's wife, Jenna, runs the website, marketing, and social media outreach. On the weekends, Kendell's father, Stewart (a brilliant engineer), jumps in to help.

Kendell's capacity to get things done blows me away. Starting and growing a company is extremely difficult. I have been to countless family dinners where I watch them all get around the kitchen table to figure out payroll and the myriad obstacles business owners must overcome. However, Kendell wants to build something that is generational, something we can pass on to her daughter, Clara, and her cousins to one day operate.

Just as Kendell has supported my dreams, I support hers. When she and her family began this entrepreneurial journey, I went all in to see where any of my relationships could help them grow. Traci Horton was one of those relationships. Her last name might seem recognizable to anyone that pays attention to home building, as D.R. Horton is one of the premier home builders in America. D.R. Horton was also one of my clients I have worked with for years doing speaking engagements and leadership development. Without a doubt, one of the best corporate cultures with whom I've had the honor of working.

Traci is a woman of strong faith, who believes (like I do) that nothing happens by chance. Like Einstein famously said, "God does not play dice." When Kendell began building her company, Traci immediately saw that as an opportunity to serve and help her build her dream. Since then, Kendell's company has enjoyed a wonderful working relationship with D.R. Horton.

“When was the last time your girls and you took a vacation?” Traci asked.

It was a fair question. Typically, Kendell, Clara, and I go on vacation in July and December because those are the only two months of the year that I have a few weeks off on the speaking circuit. This past December, we skipped our family vacation because we were nearing the end of the building process for our dream home.

“You got me on that one, Traci. We haven’t had a vacation together in a while,” I admitted. “When are you thinking about for the lake house?”

“Early summer,” Traci fired back.

That was going to be difficult, I explained to her. Not just because of speaking, but also because Clara is one of the most active kids I’ve ever met. Her competition dance schedule keeps us on the go with wherever her team is dancing in America.

“Damon, of all the incredible things that have happened in your life since prison, your little family is *by far* the biggest blessing from God. You need more balance in your life.”

Truer words have never been spoken! Kendell and Clara are absolutely a *God Thing*, something that can only be explained on a spiritual level. However, the balance thing was not correct. I knew I could never find *balance*.

But I could find *rhythm*.



When I walked out of prison, I was a forty-year-old man, living in my parents’ spare bedroom, on parole for life, with a good job, making about \$30,000 a year. While this did not make for a good dating profile (I was never on any dating aps, not with a profile

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like that), it was an extreme upgrade from serving life in a maximum-security prison, in a 10'x12' cell, with another man in the cell and a personal toilet two feet away from our bunks. Position determines perspective.

To be candid, dating after prison was not a pleasant experience. After the better part of a decade on the inside, I was socially awkward, to say the least. Moreover, I was uncomfortable in my own skin due to the shame and the stigma that comes with being a formerly incarcerated person. Constantly, I would remind myself that I put myself in this situation with the choices I made, and only I could get myself out of it with the choices I would make.

One day, after work, I met Ray for a sponsor meeting and informed him I felt like I was ready to start dating. He told me I was not ready. "What, are you going to tell me I've got to wait twelve months, or get a plant or pet first?" I asked, throwing back a few of the responses I had heard other guys' sponsors tell them.

"No," he responded calmly. "I'm *not* telling you that you have to wait twelve months; I'm telling you that you have to finish working these twelve steps of the program."

He explained to me that at the completion of the twelve steps I would be a person who was worthy of being in a relationship. "Relationships," he continued, "are a two-way street. As an addict, you've been on a one-lane highway." He was correct, of course. Addiction is the most selfish thing a person can do.

"Besides, once you get through the steps, you will have a matrix to plug your potential partner into, so you can see if she is a good person who is worthy of *you*. You are just as deserving of all the best things in life. Don't ever forget *your* worth."

Three years later, I met Kendell Romero through a mutual friend. She was a single mother to her then-six-year-old daughter,

Clara, and she worked as a nurse practitioner in rheumatology at Christus St. Elizabeth, in Beaumont. Kendell was eleven years younger than me and had an incredible life she was building. The last thing I thought she would want to do is add a formerly incarcerated man, on parole forever into her incredibly normal life.

But—we fell in love, and she did add me into her life. One of the things I will always remember is how patient she was with my awkwardness. Another thing is how quickly she introduced me to her parents. Within a month of dating, I gave one of my most important retellings of my story, and the lessons I learned from my mistakes. Her father, Stewart, broke the silence that night, in her parents' living room. "Well, you've obviously made a lot of poor decisions, but you also paid one hell of a price. Tell you what, treat my daughter well and we will be just fine," he said as he shook my hand.

Several months after we were dating, Kendell was ready to introduce me to Clara. The conversation before meeting her was not what I was expecting but also one I would never forget. "When you're around Clara, always remember that your role in her life is never going to be the role of her father. She has a wonderful father, who loves her, and she adores him. This means you are not allowed to act like her father. If she is with us, I'll handle the parenting duties, like telling her what to do and if she needs disciplining. You get to play the fun roles. Be her friend, make her a priority, be a role model to her, and let her come to you."

She paused and then continued. "If you're going to be in Clara's life, your role would be as a *stepfather*. The word 'step' is important, too. Sometimes it will mean you *step in*, you *step out*, you *step back*, or *step aside*. Being a stepparent is a beautiful thing. But it will only confuse Clara if you get outside of your role because her dad has earned that role."

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She asked me if I had any questions. I did not. She was very clear.

Kendell's coaching was spot-on. Having never been a father or stepfather before, I would never have known my place in Clara's world if she hadn't told me what my lane was. I found my supporting role to be very fulfilling, too. There were still things we got to do together that my father did with me, like teaching Clara how to ride a bike.

Having grown up with brothers, I experienced things I never knew. Clara would put makeup on me and paint my nails. We would watch her Disney shows. We would play all kinds of games, both in the house and outside. At her pace, we grew our friendship and started becoming a family.

At first it was practical that Kendell and I were not married because I still lived with my parents. Eventually, I grew tired of Kendell having to say hello to my parents every time she came over to see me, so we bought a home together. It was a cute little two-bedroom garden home, where the energy was perfect. We began making memories as a family.

A family. It was hard to believe that I had a family after where I had been just a few years before. In 2019, I saw an opportunity to ask Kendell to marry me. It was the occasion of my master's graduation ceremony that gave me the idea. With so much of both her family and mine coming into town, I broached the idea to Kendell. "Look, you know I want to *officially* be your husband and Clara's stepdad. Let's have a small ceremony here, at our house the Saturday after I graduate."

"I honestly don't know if Clara would want that. Everything is great the way it is. We both love you, and that's really what matters," she countered.

“But I think she would be on board, I really do,” I pleaded.

“OK,” she relented. “If you get Clara on board then I’ll be on board. You have to ask her, though.”

I really did not want to bring this up to Clara because there was a chance she would say no, which held the potential to make things awkward. But I really wanted to marry Kendell, so my path went right through a now-seven-year-old girl.

That evening, while playing outside with Clara, I took my shot. “Hey, Clara. Got a question for you. What if I asked your mom to marry me and I became your stepdad?”

To my surprise, she jumped up excitedly and said, “I’ve been wanting this for so long! I’ll go get mom and we can ask her right now.”

Then, she took off inside the house looking for her mom. I was pleasantly shocked by her reaction, but I had no time to think about it because this little, determined seven-year-old was about to bring her mother outside for a marriage proposal I was unprepared for. I had no time to rehearse what to say, nor a ring with which to propose. In fact, all I had on me was my phone. Thinking quickly, I propped my phone up on the back of Kendell’s vehicle to record the moment. I couldn’t lose, since Kendell told me I had to get Clara’s approval, right?

In a video that has since gone viral on social media, Clara brought out her mother and said, “Me and Damon want to ask you something and we both want to do this.”

She pointed to me, and I gave her a look that said, *What do I say next?* Giggling, she said to us both, “Say it! Just say it! He’s so nervous. This is what he wants to say.”

Following my cheerleader and coach, I got on one knee and asked Kendell to marry me. Before Kendell could respond,

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Clara jumped up and down, screaming out to her mother, “Say yes! Say yes!”

We were married on May 18, 2019. Ten years, to the day, from when I was sentenced to life in prison. Or as Kendell playfully said, “You went from one life sentence to another.”

At the small wedding in our home, Kendell and Clara both stood at the “altar,” which was our living room. Surrounded by family and friends, I said my vows to both Kendell and Clara. In Clara’s vows, I talked about how great her father was and how blessed she was to have a dad like him. I reminded her that I would always love her and be there for her, now as her stepfather, in a supportive role as a friend and role model.

Early on in our family life, it was pretty normal. I worked at Provost Umphrey Law Firm and would travel to speak a few days each week. Balance was easily attainable. After the initial lockdown of COVID, however, our lives changed rapidly. With the world becoming a pot of boiling water, my story and message became so sought after that I was on the road twenty to twenty-five days most months. Companies, organizations, school districts, and sports teams were lining up to hear the timely message of the coffee bean.

There was no more balance. It’s impossible to find balance when you’re away 80 percent of the year. Ever grateful for my incredible opportunity to speak and impact the world, I was in a rut because I missed my family. I turned to the one person who could understand my situation because he had already walked in my shoes: Jon Gordon. More than my coauthor and mentor, Jon was also my best friend. He always had the best advice, too.

That day, Jon shared with me what he discovered long ago on the speaking circuit. “You’ll never be able to find balance, but you can find a *rhythm* to life.”

Rhythm, he explained, was being fully in the moment of whatever I was doing. Suddenly I was back listening to Ranger tell me to be where my feet are. If I was on the road, speaking, then I was focused on that so that I could be the best at my craft and impact others. When I was at home, I was focused on my family to the fullest, so that my impact and presence could be felt there. He encouraged me to put my phone away as much as possible as soon as I got home. This would allow me to capitalize on every minute at home.

He encouraged me to plan family vacations during those times of the year when the speaking circuit slows down for everyone, and to fill those precious weeks up with memories to carry us through each year.

It was a breakthrough moment for our family. From then on, we understood that if we wanted to accomplish our hopes and goals in life, it was OK to not have balance; we would have rhythm in life. With more opportunities to work professionally as a speaker, we had more resources. This gave me the ability to fly out to all of Clara's dance competitions so that I could support her and be present for her activities.

My rapid growth in the world of speaking, and several more successful books being published, also afforded us the opportunity for Kendell to step away from working full-time as a nurse practitioner. This is when Kendell became an entrepreneur. For the first nine years of Clara's life, Kendell—like millions of working moms—juggled working full-time and being there for her child's school activities, extra-curriculars, and everything else.

In the summer of 2021, Kendell and Clara had their first of many summers together. The rhythm we embraced in life was paying off. Seeing the relationship grow between Kendell and

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Clara was all the motivation I needed to grind on the road. I truly feel like God put the three of us together because we all play our role in completing each other. Being a husband and stepfather are the two greatest hats I get to wear in life.

Reflections

How many times in your life have you felt like you must pick one thing over another? Family over career, or vice versa? Fitness over family, or vice versa? The list is endless, and the struggle is real.

The truth is, you can apply rhythm over balance to just about anything in life. But there is a catch. Once you commit to this philosophy, you must be able to adhere to the time-rules you create for each facet. There are healthy places in life where you can cut corners, but time is definitely not one of those. Time is the most precious resource you have. Once it is gone, it is gone for good. All the money in the world will not buy one more second of time.

Anything worthwhile is going to require sacrifice. My life is primarily on the road now. This separation from my family and my home, to do my life's work, is the zero-sum reality my friend, Randy Glenn, talks about—any time you say yes to something, you're saying no to everything else. This acceptance has allowed me to become a vessel for positivity in other people's lives, turning my life sentence into my life lessons.

It has also allowed me to become a better husband and stepfather. Spend your time wisely. Spend your life wisely. Find your rhythm and watch your life take off.

CHAPTER 21

USE YOUR PLATFORM FOR GOOD

It's Never About You

October 28, 2024

In early 2024, I met Chanda Bell, the woman who founded the Elf on the Shelf with her mother. Her story was incredible. From selling elves out of the trunk of her car to the elf becoming a global phenomenon with its own Netflix show, her entrepreneurial journey had it all. I joked when I met her that I did not know if I wanted to shake her hand or run away from her, having had more than one stressful night over the years, not remembering whether Kendell or I had hidden Clara's elf, Trixie.

It surprised me that she knew who I was. She told me during the pandemic, her company (LumiStella), like so many others, was dealing with existential adversity. From supply chain issues to people not being out in stores, they were trying to navigate the troubled business waters that sank so many other companies.

"We used *The Coffee Bean* as one of our books to get us through," she said. That message was their reminder that they could turn their pot of boiling water into a pot of coffee.

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She, of course, had no idea about my backstory and where the coffee bean message came from. “I first heard it from a guy I was locked up with in county jail. Right before I went to prison to serve my life sentence,” I explained to her.

The talk of her company and my message gave me an idea. I told her about the Be a Coffee Bean Foundation, whose purpose is to provide children of incarcerated parents with funds to participate in the extracurricular activity of their choice. Aside from the obvious benefits of at-risk kids being involved in positive activities, it also helped repair the parent-child bond that is broken or frayed when the parent goes to prison. “Here’s my ask: Would LumiStella please donate two hundred elves to my foundation, for me to give to children of incarcerated parents in the Texas prison system?”

She agreed to do it and a few months later, two hundred Elf on the Shelf boxes appeared on my doorstep. Kendell and I stored them in the cabinets of our home, excitedly waiting for the day our foundation could begin giving elves to children whose parents are in prison. I went to work planning our Christmas in October giveaway with the Texas Department of Criminal Justice. My first call was to Director Carter. He loved the idea and brought in Director Bobby Lumpkin, TDCJ-CID director, and Dr. Amanda Hernandez, director of communications for TDCJ.

We came up with three prisons (two female and one male) where we would do the elf giveaway. The prison visits were spearheaded by the unit chaplains, and the events were held on weekends. The inmates who qualified were able to invite their children, along with the parent, guardian, or custodian who cared for their child.

Altogether, over one hundred inmates—from women’s and men’s prisons—were able to invite their children, and the children’s guardians from the free world, to participate in this first-of-its-kind program. One of my favorite parts was when, after reading their child the book about the elf, the incarcerated parent helped name their kid’s elf.

This day, I was meeting with Director Carter and Susan Hawk (former Dallas County District Attorney – where I was sentenced), telling them about the elf giveaway in TDCJ. “Prison is hard on families. Christmas is especially a tough time on families where a parent is incarcerated. If this works out like I think it will, there will be a lot of very different, very happy conversations this holiday season in TDCJ. On phone calls, visits, and letters, incarcerated parents will be asking their kids where their elf was hiding, an elf they named together.”

“Damon, that’s going to create core memories in those kid’s lives,” Susan said.

“Kids can’t pick their parents. But they naturally want to love their parents, even when they are incarcerated. It’s all about repairing the parent-child bond. Watching those kids’ excitement as they got their Elf on the Shelf from their fathers and mothers was priceless.”

Susan was quiet as she soaked it all in. Director Carter broke the silence. “You already know this, West, but you’re making a big difference with all you do.”

Man, that always felt good coming from him. Even though we were the same age, I looked up to him so much. When I was in prison, he treated me the same as he does now. Like a human. I told Susan the story about the first time I saw him after prison.

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“I had been out of prison less than a week and was with my mom at a grocery store in Port Arthur, called HEB. We turned the corner with our basket and there he was. Warden Carter was shopping with his wife. My mom could not keep up with me as I ran to him. Right before I got to him, I stopped and asked him if I could hug him. In prison, you can’t have physical contact with the officers.”

Director Carter was laughing, and he finished the story. “I told Damon that it was OK. That he wasn’t in prison anymore.”

Susan jumped in and said, “I just love your mom. Having read *The Change Agent* before I met her, I just put her on a pedestal. She was so strong and never gave up on you.”

No doubt. I would not be where I am today without my mom. I owe my life to her.

Susan shifted subjects, asking me what the biggest takeaway I’ve learned from my life *after* incarceration. She always asked probing questions. No doubt, her curiosity came from the fact she was a parole attorney—meaning she represented clients (currently incarcerated individuals who were eligible for parole) at their parole hearings. And she was a really good one, too. As far as I know, she is the only former district attorney who ever crossed over to do parole work.

Without hesitation, I told her, “Finding Muhammad. What I discovered when I found him was beyond my wildest imagination.”



Since *The Change Agent* was published, there have been frequent questions I received from readers all over the world. The most frequent one—Did I ever find Muhammad?—was also one of the most important ones to answer. Muhammad saved my life. He

sought me out in county jail in 2009 to arm me for an existential threat to my life with one of the most powerful allegories, which explained the power inside me to change the world around me. Not only that, he coached me up on how to survive the extreme adversity I was going to face when I got to prison. Without this specific encounter, I do not come back as the man I am today. Period!

What happened after prison—with the explosion of the coffee bean message around the world—is a collateral consequence of his encounter with me as well. He transferred a message to me that I, in turn, was able to transfer to others. The impact I have, and the life I enjoy, is directly tied to Muhammad.

By every metric I have now become a redeemed man. Sober, a husband, a stepfather, a good son and brother, a philanthropist, a successful entrepreneur, an adjunct-college professor, and the face of hope for countless others. I am forever grateful Muhammad listened to his Higher Power and not the Penitentiary Code that was the natural barrier for two men of different races, ages, religions, and from two different Americas. He used his platform and his life experiences to serve me.

After I found out he died of a drug overdose, it was imperative I find his surviving family. Initially, I believed my purpose was so that I could find a way to honor my friend, who saved my life with his coffee bean allegory. To me, that purpose was fulfilled in the form of the scholarship I created with his family, which carries on his legacy of impact with young people in need of money for college.

However, after getting to know his family—understanding more about their lives with him, the struggles they dealt with while loving and living with an addict who stole for drugs—I

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learned there was another purpose for both him finding me in Dallas County Jail and me finding him after I was released from prison.

What I discovered was much deeper: I had to find him so that I could *redeem him*.

Muhammad, like every human being, was worthy of redemption. Before his disease of addiction got the best of him, he was a wonderful son, a loving brother, a committed father, and a brilliant mathematician. But, because of his addictions, he—like all of us addicts—gave up his goals in exchange for his behaviors.

When Kevin Reece did that WFAA story, about me finding Muhammad and creating the scholarship to honor him, I saw the hesitancy of Muhammad's sisters to be a part of the story. Finally, they revealed to me why. They told me the man whom I met in county jail—that helpful servant who saved my life—was very far removed from the man they knew, who struggled his entire adult life with addiction, crime, and repeated incarceration.

I answered his sisters' concerns with a string of *I* statements. "I believe that this story, and the legacy created from this scholarship, will change the way the world sees your brother. I believe in redemption stories because I am one. I believe part of the reason he met me in county jail was that I could one day come back and redeem him."

If you want to see the power of that belief, the power of his redemption story, go to YouTube and search for "Former Uptown Burglar finds the Coffee Bean." Watch Kevin's story and see how proud his sisters are when they talk about their brother. His family, and the world at large, now sees James Lynn Baker II, "Muhammad," as a man whose life had great purpose. A complete reversal from the way he left this world on May 9, 2017.

Everyone, no matter their past mistakes, has the power to impact at least one person if they use their platforms for good. Whether you call it God, Higher Power, Irony, The Universe, Karma, or any other deity, the pendulum always swings its way back to you. If you're a good and positive person, then this will be a blessing. If you're not, then this will be a lesson. My life has obviously been both.

Reflections

Early on in this book, I said: When you go to prison, you take a lot of people with you. The victims of your crimes, your family and friends who believed in you, and the taxpayers who fund it.

I'd like to add to that. When you choose to make a change in life, and maintain that change with uncompromising principles, you also take a lot of people with you. My life is proof of that. Because so much has been given to me, and so many have helped me along the way, I feel it is incumbent upon me to return those same gifts back to the world.

To some people, I will forever be a drug addict and ex-con who committed crimes and went to prison; there will always be skeptics. That's OK, too. Everyone is entitled to their opinions, and other people's opinions of me are none of my business. I have long ago accepted responsibility for my actions, and, wherever possible, have sought to make amends. For those amends I cannot make—because to do so could harm the other party or myself—I will continue making Living Amends for the rest of my life.

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I do not measure my life by what other people think of me, material things, or likes on social media; rather, I measure my life the same way my first mentor, Joe Tortorice, measured his: How much can I put back into the Stream of Life each day and how much did I use my gifts to impact the world around me?

Remember, more of the pie for someone else does not mean less of the pie for you. Share your gifts and your talents with the world. The platform you have in life can become your gift to the world.

My good friend, Fred Eppright, says: "We call this life a journey. If we are really on a journey, then we must leave something behind in our place. We have to be going somewhere. If not, we are simply wandering with no purpose. Seeking ourselves."

EPILOGUE

TURN DARKNESS INTO LIGHT

December 23, 2024

“Mom, it’s time. We’re ready for you and will be waiting out front,” I said as I hung up the phone with my mother.

I was standing in the kitchen with Kendell. We had been preparing for this day since my father died last year. Before my father passed away, he told me, “Take care of your mom.” I promised him I would. Now, his last wish, and my promise to fulfill it, were finally a reality.

After his passing, she lived alone for the first time in her life. She never complained, but I knew she was lonely. Having lived in prison, I understood loneliness on a whole different level. I never forgot it was my mom who saved me while I was in that lonely, dark place. She was the one who turned darkness into light for me.

I also remembered visiting those senior citizens centers as my first service-work project out of prison. The institutional feeling in some of those places reminded me of prison. A place where you are never alone but always lonely. Now, I had the opportunity to pull my mom out of a lonely, dark place.

Her new house on our property was finally completed. In a few minutes, she would take the keys to a new, fully furnished

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home, and begin the final phase of her life with Kendell, Clara, and I as her neighbors. We were just as excited as her.

“Damon, why don’t you go meet your mom by yourself. I feel like this moment is something that needs to be between a mother and her son,” Kendell said to me.

I protested. “But you are just as much a part of this as me. Without you guiding the project, it would never have gotten done.”

“Damon, listen to me. I’m a mother. You go meet your mom for this special moment.” There was no more conversation to be had. She was not asking me.

As I made the walk out of our front door and down our road from our home to my mother’s new home, I thought back to another walk down a long walkway that my mom used to make nearly every weekend. The walk from the Stiles Unit guard gate to the visitation room.

How many times did she make that walk when I was locked up? That number is documented. There were about 150 visits over the years I was at Stiles. Half of those were on bad knees; the other half were on her replacement knees. Nothing could stop my mother from seeing me. That’s what a mother’s love is like. It’s why Mother’s Day, every year, is the busiest visitation day in prisons all over America. Ironically, because my mother could visit me often (my parents lived ten miles away), Mother’s Day weekend was the only weekend I never got visits. “Let’s leave that visitation table open for other mothers to see their sons,” my mom would tell me every year I was incarcerated.

Speaking of prison, the home Kendell and I built is about four miles from the Stiles Unit. I jog by Stiles all the time. Sometimes, I can see guys on the rec yards. I always wave. Sometimes they wave back. More than once, the perimeter guard has come by to

see what I was doing. Once they see it is me, they usually wave and keep going. If it's a guard who worked there when I was locked up, they often pull the perimeter car over to catch up with me. We swap stories about when I did my time there and then talk about our lives today.

To the outside observer, living so close to the prison I served a life sentence in may seem morbid or odd, but I wouldn't have it any other way. Ever since I walked out of Stiles, I have continuously gone back there. Going back in brings those men hope and it helps keep me sober. Besides, I promised those guys I would be back. In prison, and in life, your word is your bond. Nothing erodes trust faster than not doing what you say you will do. I have stayed true to my word and earned the nickname "the Smuggler of Hope" along the way. I earned that nickname the same as how I earned being called "the Uptown Burglar"—through my actions. I wear this one with pride.

Stiles will always have a certain power over me, but not in the way you might be thinking. For example, every time I pass it on the highway, I always notice it and look over at the guard towers that once kept me in. I don't think I'll ever *not* notice it. To not notice it would be strange. I don't have entirely negative thoughts when I reflect on Stiles. Did I face a lot of trauma and suffer from depression in there? Sure! Prison can be a hopeless place, and I experienced that seemingly hopeless world while in there. However, it will forever be the training ground where I learned about how much a person can change, how much the human spirit is capable of when we turn our lives and our will over to a Higher Power.

It's where I had my spiritual awakening and found my program of recovery. Where I learned about prayer (talking to God)

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and meditation (listening to God). Once I finally surrendered to Christ, I grew more in those years inside Stiles than my first thirty-three years on Earth.

The sound of tires crunching on gravel snapped me back into the present. It was my mom's car turning onto my road—her road now, too. I rushed over to get her door and help her out of the car. I noticed Watson was in the backseat. Watson was my father's English bulldog. I say he was *my father's dog* because the two of them were inseparable.

When my father passed away, Melancon's Funeral Home was thoughtful enough to allow us to take Watson there to see my father's lifeless body. Watson walked right up to his body, sniffed his face, and then smelled all over his body. He walked from one side of the gurney to the other before finally sitting in front of my father. We stayed back, quietly, allowing Watson to say his good-byes to his best friend. I almost felt like I was violating Watson's space by witnessing the moment. After about a minute, Watson got up and walked toward my mother and me. He was telling us he was ready to go home.

After I got my mom out of her car, I opened the back door and got Watson out. Tears started trickling down my face. My mom asked what was wrong. "Seeing you and Watson made me think of dad. I wish he could have been here to see this."

My mom hugged me in an embrace that only a mother knows how to give and said, "He can see it, Damon."

Standing a little straighter, I replied to her, "I'm so grateful he got to see me turn it around before he passed."

"We are both so proud of you, Damon. You're better than what we could have ever hoped for when we talked outside the courtroom the day you were sentenced."

Since she brought it up, I did have a question for her about that conversation. “Where did that come from that day? Your words. Where did they come from?”

“The Holy Spirit,” she said, without hesitation. “I’m a nurse, so I view everything through that lens. What I saw right after your trial was my son bleeding out on a gurney. I went into triage mode. In triage, you throw everything at the problem to save the patient’s life. Those words—telling you to not join a gang or get the tattoos—are what came to me from Christ.”

My mother has always been a woman of strong faith. All of my life, she led with her faith. Faith over fear. Especially those years in prison, her faith rose above the crisis I created in our family. She was the glue that held it all together. Her faith allowed her to love me unconditionally, give me back to Christ, and forgive me for all I had done.

The speaking and book world had provided me with so much abundance. But, because of my program of recovery, and that conversation with Christ the day I finally walked out of prison, I understood that those blessings came with spiritual strings attached. It was not intended to be all for me. Rather, I had to find ways to spread those blessings around. In AA, there is a saying which perfectly encompasses this: *You have to give it away to keep it.*

“I’m so grateful to Kendell and you for doing this. Dad and I worked hard all our lives, but we never had the financial ability to build a new home,” she said as we got out and walked around up the ramp to her door. “Thank you for blessing me. I love you.”

I told her I loved her too. We hugged and then I gave her the keys to her new home. She cried, which made me cry. What son would not give anything to be able to take care of his mom and make her proud?

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I might be one of the luckiest men alive to have been blessed twice with a family who loves me so much. First, when I was born to my incredible parents and, second, when I married my amazing wife. My first family loved me because of blood, I was born to them; my second family, the one I found, loved me because they chose to.

“I would not be the man I am without you. I’m grateful to be in a position to take care of you after all you’ve done and sacrificed to take care of me. If anyone has earned it, it’s you, Mom. Kendell, Clara, and I are so excited that you will be here with us. You never had a daughter; now, you have a daughter-in-law and a granddaughter next door. You’ll get to see Clara grow up, and she will get to know you even better than she does now.”

As we walked around her house, my mom asked me something she had never asked before. “When you were in prison, could you envision any of this?”

That was a good question. “I never imagined the life I have today, no. But that didn’t mean I didn’t see myself in a better place. I guess the best way to describe it is that I saw myself outside of prison, sober, with Dad and you. Everything else that happened—keeps happening—is beyond my wildest imagination.”

Reflections

A continuous theme throughout my journey is that I am simply a vessel. I am Catholic, so I will see Christ’s hand in these things that have happened in my life. You, however, are free to interpret this, and the events in my life, any way you choose. That’s the beauty of living in a world where you have the freedom to think for yourself.

Damon West

Freedom is the most powerful motivator, too. After giving away my freedom and then regaining it, I can tell you that a physical prison is not the worst form of prison. Mental, emotional, and spiritual prisons are far worse and more common. I meet more people out here, in the free world, who are locked up than I ever did while I served time in a maximum-security prison. More people are imprisoned by their things, their thoughts and their prejudices, than by steel bars, barbed wire, and concrete combined!

When I began this book, I asked the question from James Clear: If someone took control of your life tomorrow, what's the first thing they would change?

Whatever your answer is to that question, it is my hope the principles and stories in this book have helped you take action, make that change, and begin the lifelong journey of becoming the best version of you. You're capable of more than you think you are.

No matter how great the obstacles, remember that it's a life lesson, not a life sentence. Even in my case, when it really is a life sentence—six dimes and a nickel—it was always just opportunities in adversity, and the lessons I learned, for me to become the best version of me.

Go be the best version of you. Be a Coffee Bean!

I would love to hear from you. Please contact me through my website at www.damonwest.org. If you're incarcerated, you can write me at PO Box 1451, Nederland, TX 77627.

BONUS CHAPTER

JT'S STORY

Why Jack Ruby Killed Lee Harvey Oswald

Did you think I was going to drop all those hints about JT's days in the Dallas mob and just leave you hanging? Not a chance. I couldn't include it as part of my story because his story is separate from mine. This bonus chapter is about some of the stories JT shared with me. Stories that did not show up in the March 2025 final release of all the remaining JFK files. He made me promise not to reveal this stuff until he was dead, which happened on February 21, 2023, when he passed away peacefully in prison one day shy of his 78th birthday.

Many secrets died with him, as he told me, since he was one of the last people from his era still alive. Ironically, he attributed serving life in prison as the only reason he was alive. A blessing because he found Christ in prison, which saved his soul. I do not know how much of what he told me is true. I'm hoping someone reading this can check the veracity of it all.

JT was, without a doubt, the most interesting person I met in prison. He was charming, witty, funny, scary, and went around

professing the healing Power of Christ. Vastly different than the guy who started out in the early 60s, “running girls, guns, and drugs for the mob,” JT was more like a father figure to many of us in there. He took a specific interest in me, initially, because I was an organized crime guy from Dallas. He told me, “Guys like us gotta stick together.” I didn’t complain because this aligned me with one of the most respected lifers in The Joint. Another one of the angels on my path.

As JT and I grew closer, he began telling me stories of his crime days in Dallas. He told me of his interactions with characters like Joe and Sam Campisi. “They were heavy mob-connected guys who loan-sharked, ran numbers, and dealt heroin at The Egyptian Lounge, an Italian restaurant on Mockingbird that served as a front for their mob-business dealings.”

He told me they had no fear of law enforcement. “So many cops were on the take back then that the mob ran around with impunity. We owned the streets of Dallas,” JT said.

One specific story, in that vein of cops on the take, was about Officer J.D. Tippit, the Dallas police officer Lee Harvey Oswald shot and killed in the Oak Cliff neighborhood of Dallas about 45 minutes after JFK was killed on November 22, 1963. JT told me, “Tippit was one of our best cops. We could count on him for anything.”

JT told me a story from before the JFK assassination, when his crew was burglarizing a Florsheim Shoe warehouse in Dallas. “Tippit pulled up in his patrol car with lights and sirens blaring. My guys scattered, but I didn’t because I recognized Tippit behind the wheel. So, I walked up to the driver’s window of the patrol car, made a little small talk with Tippit, then I asked him what size shoe he wore. He told me the size and I yelled out to my guys

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to load up his car with as many shoes as possible in his size. Must have been fifty boxes of shoes. After his car was loaded, we shook hands, and he drove off. This time, no lights or sirens.”

JT told me why he thought Oswald killed Tippit. “Tippit was sent to kill Oswald that day to tie up the loose end, so he went to where Oswald was staying in Oak Cliff. Why do you think Tippit knew the exact place where Oswald would be?” JT asked, with an eyebrow raised.

When I asked him about the JFK assassination, he corrected me and said, “You mean the JFK hit.” JT told me it was the mob who killed JFK, specifically, the Chicago mob who ordered it. Days before the “hit,” JT said he was instructed to “get all the girls off the streets because something big is going down.”

JT told me that Oswald was not the only shooter. In fact, he personally knew *at least one of the other shooters*: Charles Harrelson, a well-known hitman and the father of the actor, Woody Harrelson. JT said he talked to Charles at a Dallas bar the day before JFK was killed. “Charley told me he was in Dallas on business. That told me all I needed to know, because Charley’s business was killing people.”

Turns out, it would not be the only time JT was with Charles Harrelson before an assassination. “Charley was in my club, in Cherokee County, in 1979, right before he hit the federal judge in San Antonio.”

Lastly, is the story JT told me about why Jack Ruby killed Lee Harvey Oswald. I have never heard this story anywhere else, so I asked JT to write it all down; I did not want to leave out any details when I retold the story one day. Now that he has passed away, it is time to share his letter. Hopefully, someone reading

this can look into it and find out if JT was, in fact, telling the truth or if he was just telling tall tales from a prison cell.

The letter truly makes one wonder if one of Ruby's Carousel Club burlesque girls, who overheard the Chicago mob order Ruby to kill Oswald, did in fact "hang herself with her stretch pants" in Dallas City Jail (on Harwood Street) a day before Ruby—a local mob-backed strip club owner—walked into the basement of Dallas Police Headquarters and carried out the hit?

I will say one final thing about JT. Despite his life of crime, and the many murders he admitted to, he was a good man when I met him. No one walked the talk of being a Christian more than him. Proof that redemption is possible for anyone willing to surrender to a spiritual awakening. Regardless of whether these stories prove to be true, I will always love him for how he treated me.

Rest in peace, JT.

23.

1963, J.E.K. It was after Lee Harvey Oswald was arrested, on the killing of The President.

I was back operating out of the Town and Country Motel. The girls were working and the drugs were being delivered to their proper locations, business as usual.

Kay and I were living on Gaston Ave. as mentioned. I usually called Kay around 5:00 to 6:00 A.M. Tell her I was on my way home. Because we always ate breakfast together, give a little time together, extra from front lane of my business and the club business or night life, but on this particular morning. She called me at the Motel, instead of me calling her. She said when will you be home? I said, why what's up? She said Sue Love just called me, said she had a major problem and she had no-one else to turn to, but us.

I told Kay I will be home by 6:00 A.M.

I will let her know, I said ok. J.T.

Yeah? Sue is really upset and said she was scared also. I will be there ^{by} 6:00 A.M.

I thought probably big time. Bookie. She was married to, threatening her again - after their break-up, or maybe he had beat her up again.

So I told Dale & Joe Lee to close up -
Turn Over On Back PG # 24.

24.

shop, for Harold to stay there. We always kept someone on duty at the Motel.

I got to the Apartment maybe 10 minutes before Sue. I went to the back lot bar, she came in smoking a cigarette and said do you mind. I guess not, then she lit a fresh cigarette off that one, hands shaking like a leaf on a tree in the wind. She started spitting out the problem. I, said Sue slow down calm down. Kay brings her a drink. Scotch on the rocks. She downed it. Kay poured her another. I said might as well pour me one, also. Kay says I will finish cooking Breakfast, left Sue and I alone.

I said slow this time Sue, she took a hard hit off second glass of scotch and said you know Sandy White, I said Yes, you introduced her to me at Theater Lounge, and I've seen her act at Ruby's Club couple of times. When Vinsons and I went there. Spoke to her both times, talked to her maybe 2 minutes one time, just casual conversation, I mentioned you and Kay.

Well J.T. she is the one with the major problem, and I need you to help her. She is a very close

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25.

- friend of mine, like family really. OK if I can, what's her problem. J.T. I will never forget you doing this never.

Sue lets hear it. Well you know all the strippers have to be out of the building at Ruby's Club by 1:00 A.M. during the week and 2:00 A.M. on Saturday nights, one hour after closing. ~~That's right~~

Ruby really gets upset. If you don't have your stuff together and be gone.

Why is that? Because so the girls say. He conducts all his business after hours, you ^{know} out of town mafia associates the heroin thing with Joe Civello, stuff like that.

Anyway Sandy was fixing to marry this older guy, a Air Plane Pilot and quit Burlesque Stage. So she stayed over the hour limit by quite some time, trying to get all her costumes, dresser ect, together or packed up. She said she looked at her watch and thought man it is that late. So she just grabbed her overnight bag, decided to slip out. She said she opened the door and could hear ~~some~~ Ruby talking to someone and door to his # office was cracked about 18 inches. PG. 26.

Turn Over In BACK ➔

26.

She had to go right by there. She had on ~~tennis shoes~~ tennis shoes, her stretch pants. As you know the stairs ~~to~~ to Rubys Club, its straight up and very high up. At the bottom of the stairs the door has a door closer at the top and it pulls ~~the~~ the door to and it locks back by itself.

You know how the bar across the door ~~like~~ school houses have. You push on the bar and it unlocks the door. Yes I know what you are saying. Sandy said she knew if she could get by Rubys office. She could sneak out, catch a cab. She eased up to Rubys office, and said Rubys voice was very loud and the other person raised his voice louder, talking back to Ruby in anger. The other person was Frank Costello makes less N.Y. & Chicago. Sandy's interpretation of their conversation. Jack you will do this.

I already told you Frank get someone else. No Jack, you will go to city jail and shoot and kill Oswald. When they transfer him. It is all setup.

You have no choice Jack. The Mob has been taking care of you for 25 years, so you

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will do it or we will kill everything
dear to you, even that little mutt of a
weanier dog you have and so proud of, and
then you don't even want to know what
we will do to you before we kill you.

Why me Frank, because our contacts
there know you. Look Jack we gonna
handle this just fast the best we can.

Sandy then knew she was even in
deeper trouble. She eased by the door,
but a shadow or noise gave her away,
she bolted down the stairs ran out
on the street about 100 feet was
Cal sitting at the curb with inside
light on and a Calbie reading a paper.

She jumped in front seat and
screamed for him to take off. He
did but Ruby and Costello were pulling
guns running trying to catch her.

Sandy had seen Frank Costello
before in the club, with the horion
King Pin Joe Civello.

Sandy has not went back to her
apartment or anywhere else. She is
staying with or at Air Plane Pilot's
Place. No one has ever met him
and he has never been in Ruby Club.
Turn Off Car Box # 26

28.

never meet anyone connected to her lifestyle. No one knows where he lives. But J.T. been couple of strangers asking all the girls at every strip joint in town. If they have seen Sandy.

Sue I have no idea how I can help her. J.T. all she needs is a ride to Waco, Tex. She has a step-sister there they are close, but her sister is very straight person, and no one would ever connect them together no one knows about her step-sister. Sandy has ~~lot~~ money saved. She will pay you. Sue I don't need the money. Let her boyfriend take her. No she does not want him to know where she is. He was gonna marry her, but that's history. He is so in love with her he would never quit trying to marry her.

Sandy says she just wants to lay low couple months then go to Atlanta, Georgia with new identity. Sandy White is not her real name anyway.

Sue, Vinson would have a fit, me doing this. J.T. he does not have to. Vinson, Please J.T. help her. Let me think a minute. I thought man, Ruley, Joe Cívella meant Joe Campisi involvement, besides

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Six Dimes and a Nickel

29.

Frank Castella and ~~he~~ telling subo else,
was 4- or 5 hit men probably looking
for Sandy.

Kay walked into the room, I been
listening J.T. You can do it, Vinson will
never know. Only take a few hours. Besides
You need take off couple of days anyway.
Plus J.T. You are not afraid of anyone
and Joe Lee, Dale, Harold would fight
the U.S. Army for You. OK Kay you
don't have to pump me up, tell
me how big loud ass I am. So
J.T. will You do it. Look Sue You
can call Sandy? Yes, ok tell her to
meet me at Street Cafe Diner the
24 hour diner on Canine St. right
where Industrial Blvd. runs into
it. I will be in 1957 Chev 2 door
hardtop Candy Apple Red at 11:00 A.M.

at the diner, parked under the Awning
out front. If she is not there by
11:30 A.M. I'll gone 30 minutes later, is
all I will wait. Tell her to catch
a CaBa J.T. Thanks, don't thank
me Yet Sue. Till this is over.

Kay says I knew You would
do right thing J.T. Uh-huh, I
thought nothing about this, right.

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30.

Sue left I Picked up the Phone Called Danny, a very close high school friend of mine, but a straight dude. Danny I need to borrow your car tonight. maybe tomorrow too, OK? You gonna come get it? Yeah, but meet me at Busy Bee Cafe at 10:00 P.M. tonight.

You can take my vette, OK I will be there. Hey J.T. You need any help doing anything? "maybe". I will let you know at 10:00 P.M. tonight.

Anyway Sandy showed up, she had a altercation with some guys in 1962 StarFire Olds Solid Black and two other guys in Black Ford Sedan, it had looks of undercover or detective's car no markings. We got out of that because of a very fast car. then Sandy talk me into going by her apartment for 5 minutes. But I made a call and took Joe Lee with me then, and glad I did another altercation with a couple Chicago hoods. Which we handled, at her Apt. then the last stop was Mickys Lounge a after hours joint on Greenville Ave. and Ross Ave. corner, on the right where Ross Ave. connects with Greenville Ave. Mickys Lounge Location no longer there.

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31.

It was really against my better judgment, but Sandy finally talk me into it, only because she had loaned a 1 carat diamond cluster dinner^{ring} to her ex-roommate. Who was the night Bar-maid or Bar-tender at Mickys Lounge.

I stopped and Sandy called her ex girlfriend or roommate from pay phone on Ross Ave. about 2 blocks from the Mickys Lounge. Her friend come to the Lounge. Sandy went in, and she stalled Sandy. Told her she just called her brother and he was bringing the ring from her apartment 4 blocks from the Lounge off Greenville Ave. After 10 minutes I got edgy sitting in the car. I sent word in by Danny tell her she had better come on, or I was leaving her.

I was getting ^{more} nervous by the minute. Danny came out said 10 minutes the guy was bringing the ring. I said you go back in there tell her now. You come back without her. We already have left. You got it, Vas S.T. She went in told her, Danny came right back, he said she coming, just as Danny got that out of her mouth, she walked out. I heard sirens coming, did know why, or if it was because of her. I guessed the engine. Turn over her The Book Page # 32.

32.

Sandy was 50-60 ft. from the car a squad car, a detective car then 4 or 5 more squad cars. Sandy froze I sared off from the curb directly across the street. There is a small Park, or was across from Nicky's lounge, the other side of the park is a street then a big Sears & Roebuck store right off Rose Ave.

They handcuffed her, loaded her in the detective car. Took off with her. We followed at a safe distance. They took her to the City Jail on Hollywood Street downtown.

I stopped, turned around, told Joe Lee who was in another car to go home.

Went got my Vette, told Danny to for-
-get everything he saw. He laughed. said I already have. I gave him a hundred Bucks. He laughed said You hiring me?
I said Keep Your job less money I know Danny, but much safer.

I went to the or my Apartment told Kay. Called Kenner. W. Clay a attorney who handled all our affairs. Kenner's attorney always on the payroll, but Clay and I were very close, because he handled all our business legal wise, bonds for girls and whatever came up, I told him this was personal thing not to tell, or ~~on~~
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Six Dimes and a Nickel

33.

involve Vinson. I should have known better, but Clay would probably never tell Vinson, but after Sandy supposedly hung herself in Dallas City Jail, during her stretch pants to do so. Clay got nervous over that, especially after finding out Sandy White was not even her real name and she was a Burlesque Queen who worked for Ruby. Vinson did not even raise his voice at me. He said J.T. we need keep this quiet, ok. Yes, but you know what time it is if you bring heat on me. Will cause major problem with Camp's organization, not telling what kind of problems from Costello, & Civallo who was with you? Joe Lee. I did not mention Danny at all. Keep you some money alot of money. If I call you get Joe go to Lake House in Hot Springs, Arkansas.

Get by for 2 weeks we home free. Nothing ever came back on me, but Vinson told me later. You ever do anything again without telling me, J.T. I'm sure you understand. I said yes I do.

All this is in the book, written just like a novel. I never mentioned any of this to anyone except my second wife.

This was in 1975, we had been married for over a year she was 20 years old and
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